crown; pompous arrogance keeps his royal company; lust and greed are his two dear friends. The heavenly maidens peace, forbearance and kindness do not visit the palace, having been insulted. There ignorance reigns supreme as the favourite queen, pandering to all the foolish desires of the Prince, who is found steeped in the well of foul passions."

After this the various processes of Yoga are detailed in the poem, on the merits of which we can not pronounce any judgment.

Yoga Sāra.

2. Yoga sāra or the essence of Yoga. As the name implies, this book describes Yoga, leading to the emancipation of the soul, and attainment of the stage of beatitude, step to step. The author's name is not found in the book; he introduces himself by his title Gunarāj Khān. He undertook the work at the command of a rich man named Çachipati Majumdār.

Hāḍamālā and other poems on Yoga.

3. Hāḍamālā, a poem relating to Yoga. The author's name is not known.

4. Jnāna Pradipa by Saiyad Sultān who calls himself a disciple of the saint and Fakir named Sāhā Hosen. Though a Mahomedan, the author

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শান্তি, ধৃতি, ক্ষমা, নীতি, শুভশীলা নারী।
মান করি রাজপুরী নাহি যায় চারি॥
পতিব্রতা ধর্ম্মরতা অবিদ্যা মহিষী।
পতি কাছে সদা আছে রাজার হিতৈষী॥
নারী সঙ্গে রতিরঙ্গে রসের তরঙ্গে।
এইরূপে কামকূপে জীব আছে রঙ্গে॥"

acknowledges the God Çiva as the authority in all matters relating to Yoga.

5. Tanu Sādhana—a poem on Yoga. The author, who was a Mahomedan, writes elegant Bengali and has a profound respect for the tenets of the Hindu Çāstras.

6. *Jnana Chautisa.* This poem contains only 152 couplets. The author Saiyād Sultān explains the metaphysical truth embodied in the symbol of Çiva and Çakti and describes the processes of Yoga. This book was written in 1780 A.D.

There are other small treatises on Yoga, a brief notice of which is to be found in the catalogue of old Bengali Mss. published by Munsi Abdul Karim in the Sāhitya Pariṣad Patrikā issued from Calcutta.

The above poems were written within the last 200 years; the latest of them comes up to the middle of the 19th century.

Kaçi Khanda by Jayanārāyaṅā.

Translation of Kāçi Khanda by Jayanārāyaṅa Ghoṣāla. Passing from the subject of metaphysics, we shall here take up a work of translation, which deserves a somewhat elaborate notice. It was compiled by its illustrious author with the help of many distinguished Pundits.

From a copper-plate inscription prepared by Rājā Kāli Çaṅkara Ghoṣāla of Bhukailasa son of Rājā Jayanārāyaṅa, we glean the following particulars about the poet. Jayanārāyaṅa was born in October, 1752. He received a sound education in Sanskrit, Persian, Hindi, English and French. He

inherited from his father a vast property which comprised the villiages of Govindapur, Garya and Behālā. He obtained the title of Maharājā from the emperor of Delhi for his patriotism and munificience, and founded a college at Benares which was called Jayanārāyaṅa College after him. He built a temple moreover for the worship of the image of Karunā Nidhāna (Kriṣṅa) at Banares in 1790. He enjoyed the confidence of Warren Hastings, and helped the Government of the East India Company in their work of Survey and Settlement in various provinces of Bengal. Jayanārāyaṅa died in 1818 A.D. at Benares in his 66th year.

The translation of Kāçī Khanda was however the joint work of several scholars and one of its chief contributors was a Kāyastha nobleman named Narasinha Deva Ray who bore the title of Çūdramaṅi. The translation took many years for its completion. Here is the account given by Jayanārāyaṅa himself as to how the arduous work was gone through.

The history of this compilation.

*"Dwelling at Benares, which is situated on the five noble streams of the Ganges, I was desirous of writing something in praise of the holy city. I thought of translating the Sanskrit work Kāçī-Khanda into Bengali, but found none who could

*" কাশীবাস করি পঞ্চ গঙ্গার উপর।
কাশী গুণ গান হেতু ভাবিত অন্তর॥
মনে করি কাশীখণ্ড ভাষা করি লিখি।
ইহার সহায় হয় কাহারে না দেখি॥
মিত্রশত চৌদ্দ শক পৌষ মাস যবে।
আমার মানস মত যোগ হইল তবে॥

help me in the undertaking. In the month of January in 1792, an opportunity presented itself for the fulfilment of my wishes. Çrijukta Narasinha Deva Rāy of the Çūdramaṅi family and an inhabitant of Pātuli, visited the city of Benares. With him came Jagannātha Mukerjee, and in the month of February the work was commenced by us jointly. Rāma Prasāda Vidyā Vāgiça, a learned Sanskrit scholar, explained the text and Narasinha Rāy prepared his drafts of the translation in prose, based on the interpretations given by the former. Jagannatha Mukerjee turned them into metrical verse; Narasinha Rāy corrected the rhymes and prepared fair copies; when forty chapters were thus completed, the learned Vidyā Vāgiça died, in September, and Jagannatha Mukerjee went home to

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শূদ্রমণি কুলে জন্ম পাটুলি নিবাসী।
শ্রীযুক্ত নৃসিংহ দেব রায়াগত কাশী॥
তার সঙ্গে জগন্নাথ মুখুয্যা আইলা।
প্রথম ফাল্গুনে গ্রন্থ আরম্ভ করিলা॥
শ্রীরামপ্রসাদ বিদ্যাবাগীশ ব্রাহ্মণ।
ভাঙ্গিয়া বলেন কাশীখণ্ড অনুক্ষণ॥
তাহারে করেন রায় তর্জ্জমা খসড়া।
মুখুয্যা করেন সদা কবিতা পাতড়া॥
রায় পুনর্ব্বার সেই পাতড়া লইয়া।
পুস্তকে লিখেন তাহা সমস্ত শুধিয়া॥
এইমতে চল্লিশ লাচাড়ি হৈল যবে।
বিদ্যাবাগীশের কাশী-প্রাপ্তি হৈল তবে॥
ভাদ্রমাসে মুখুয্যা গেলেন নিজ বাটী।
বৎসর স্থগিত ছিল গ্রন্থ পরিপাটী॥

Bengal, for one year. Owing to these causes, the book could not make any progress. In the meantime Narasiñha Rāy removed himself from the house which he occupied at Benares to Bāngālitolā; there he found a companion and friend in Valarāma Vāchaspati who was a profound scholar. Jointly with Vakreçvara Panchānana, another Pundit, they finished the translation of 75 chapters,—Vakreçvara contributing two chapters one on Kaçi Panchakroçī and the other describing a journey through the city. The work now again came to a standstill for various reasons. After this, however, we happened to meet with a Pundit named Umāçañkara Tarkālankāra. Though by the will of Providence this excellent man is blind in both eyes, yet he is possessed of some very admirable qualities. He is a native of Kāçīpur and a thoroughly truthful man of a highly religious

পরন্তু বাঙ্গালীটোলা গেলা যবে রায়।
বলরাম বাচস্পতি মিলিলা তথায়॥
পচত্তরী অধ্যায় পর্য্যন্ত তার সীমা।
বক্রেশ্বর পঞ্চাননে সমাপ্ত গরিমা॥
কাশী পঞ্চক্রোশী আর নগর ভ্রমণ।
এই দুই অধ্যায় পঞ্চাননে সমাপন॥
পরে সম্বৎসরাবধি স্থগিত হইলা।
শ্রীউমাশঙ্কর তর্কালঙ্কার মিলিলা॥
যদ্যপি নয়ন দুইটী দৈবযোগে অন্ধ।
তথাপি তাহার গুণে লোকে লাগে ধন্ধ॥
ইষ্টনিষ্ঠ বাক্‌নিষ্ঠ কাশীপুরে জন্ম।
পরানিষ্ট পরাঙ্মুখ বিজ্ঞমর্ম্মি-মর্ম্ম॥

temperament. He never dreams of doing harm to any one, appreciates merit in others; and is a true advocate of noble ideas. The blind Pundit became eager to help in the completion of the work. His father Rāma Chandra Vidyālañkāra is also a learned Pundit of a quiet and obliging disposition. With the latter I travelled for six months, in search of good and reliable manuscripts. The accounts of different festivities held in the different parts of the year are given in Bengali poetry, literally translated from the Sanskrit texts. Viṣṇu Rāma Siddhānta, a high-minded scholar and a friend of the blind Pundit, helped us with a right interpretation of these Sanskrit texts, and Narasiñha Rāy finally published the work when completed. The description of the city of Benares and of the origin of this work added to the book, is my own. In it I have given a faithful account

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লোক উপকারে সদা ব্যাকুল অন্তর।
গ্রন্থের সমাপ্তি হেতু হলেন তৎপর॥
শ্রীযুক্ত রামচন্দ্র বিদ্যালঙ্কার আখ্যান।
তৎকালঙ্কারের পিতা সুধীর বিদ্বান॥
নিজে তার সহিত করিয়া পর্য্যটন।
ছয় মাসে বহুগ্রন্থ করি সঙ্কলন॥
ঋতু মাস তিথি বার বর্ষ যাহা যত।
পদ্যেতে আনিয়া সংস্কৃত অভিমত॥
তৎকালঙ্কারের বন্ধু বিষ্ণুরাম নাম।
সিদ্ধান্ত আখ্যান, অতি ধীর গুণবান্॥
পদ্ধতি ভাষাতে করিলেন পরিষ্কার।
রায় করিলেন সর্ব্ব গ্রন্থের প্রচার॥

of my own observations. Rājā Jayanārāyaṅa of the family of Ghoṣāla, here ends his account."

The translation of Kāçī Khanda is complete in 11,200 lines; it forms a record of patient labour, carried on by half a dozen scholars for many years. In the Bhaṅitā (signature) at the end of each chapter we find the name of Rājā Jaya Nārāyaṇa, given no doubt by way of courtesy, having regard to the high position and munificence of this scholarly nobleman who initiated and maintained this undertaking, as the patron of the scholars. The main portion of the work was done by Narasiñha Deva Rāy of Pātuli whose descendants now dwell at Bañsberia in the district of Hughly.

But the chief interest of the work lies in the supplementary account of the City of Benares which the Rājā himself gives in Bengali verse. Literal translations from the Sanskrit have little value in this country. The learned do not care to read translations instead of the original texts, and those who do not know Sanskrit, do not care to read literal translation, in which they do not find an adequate or modernised expression of the thoughts to which they are accustomed. The translation of Kāçī Khanda is thus a lost labour, though the labour that produced it was great.

A description of the city.

But the supplementary account of the City of Benares is full of interest. In simple and unassum-

নগর বর্ণন মোর গ্রন্থের কারণ।
প্রত্যক্ষ বৃত্তান্ত তাহা যথার্থ বর্ণন॥
ঘোষাল বংশের রাজা জয়নারায়ণ।
এইখানে সমাপ্ত করিলা বিবরণ॥"

ing language the Rājā, who was a pious man, jotted down notes in verse of what he saw in the Holy City, a hundred years ago. He begins his description of 'the abode of Çiva,' as Kāçī is called, with a few poetic lines in which its semicircular shape, as observed from the Ganges, is compared to the crescent moon on the forehead of Çiva. He next gives a short notice of the bathing ghātas—the Parçvnāth ghāta, the Asi ghāta, the Vaidyanāth ghāta, the Nārada Pāṇde's ghāta and so on. There were then altogether 53 bathing ghātas at Benares and all of these are faithfully noticed. Though the notes are short, the writer makes them interesting by his witty remarks in many of them. He then proceeds to give a description of the Postās (embankment), the chief amongst which is the Mirer Postā: it is 120 ft. in height and 600 ft. in breadth. Hurriedly taking a note of the great houses, some of which were seven stories high, he gives an account of the Dhārāras or pinnacles. The pinnacle named Çri Madhava Rāyer Dharārā rises to a height of 172 ft.; at 135 ft. there is a seat for visitors, from which a bird's-eye view of the City of Benares may be taken. *"Like the cliffs of Mount Sumeru, it appears as if the Dharārā might pierce the heavens." At the time when the Rājā lived at Benares, this Dharārā was used by the desperate and unhappy as a place for committing suicide. The Rājā has given a list of the people who killed themselves during his time by throwing themselves down from

The Ghātas.

The Postās.

Dhārāras

A place for suicide.

*"সুমেরুর চূড় শৃঙ্গ যেমত প্রকাশ।
মনে লয় তার চূড়া ভেদিল আকাশ॥"

the above-mentioned seat in Dharārā. A young Kṣetri with his lady-love had disappeared for three days, and on the fourth, they were found dead in close embrace on the ground-floor of the temple; they had evidently thrown themselves down from the great height, after enjoying each other's company for three days. But death does not always come to the unfortunate, though he may sincerely wish for it. *" Another person ascended the great height and threw himself down, but he fell on the top of a tree and catching hold of a branch reached the ground safe and quietly glided into his own chamber."

Warren Hastings stayed in the garden house adjoining this temple for a time when he was in that City for carrying on hostile operations against Chait Singh, Rājā of Benares.

The lighting of the roads.

Instead of the modern centralisation of municipal arrangements, there was the mutual agreement of honest and public-spirited citizens:—†" In the Mahājantolā the lanes were so dark that neither the sun nor the moon could look within them. At night the residents here kept lights in their windows for the convenience of the passers-by."

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*" অন্য এক জন সেই ধরারাতে চড়ি।
দৈবক্রমে তথা হইতে তরুপরে পড়ি॥
তরুডাল সহ পুনঃ হইয়া ভূমিষ্ঠ।
অনায়াসে নিজ ঘরে হৈল প্রবিষ্ট॥"

†" মহাজন টোলী মধ্যে রাস্তাতে সন্দথা।
দিনকর হিমকর করহীন তথা॥
একারণ নিশাযোগে, পথিকের প্রীতে।
দীপ-শিখা করে সবে নিজ খিড়কিতে॥"

The writer of the sketch made notes of all that he saw; the short lines call up living pictures before one's imagination. Regarding the Buddhist Lāmās (Priests) he says:

The Lāmās.

*"The ascetics called Lāmās who outwardly profess renunciation are in reality full of worldliness. They transact a prosperous loan-business and trades of various kinds; and everyone of them is immensely rich, having residential houses like palaces."

Social gatherings.

The various amusements and religious festivities of Benares, the mode in which the citizens passed their evenings in idle gossip lounging on the banks of the Ganges, and other matters chiefly of social and domestic interest have been briefly noted. A chapter is devoted to the silk industry for which the Benares weavers have always been so famous. We find in this chapter a list of various kinds of cloth which used to be manufactured there,—the far-famed Benares Sādi, the fine silken stuff coloured with various dyes, a piece of which used to sell for Rs. 200, velvet of the first quality, striped silk with which turbans were made, silk adorned with gold embroidery and so on. He concludes his remarks under this head by saying,—†"They show admirable skill in making artistic designs on cotton with coloured silk threads, but they can not produce

Silk industry.

*"লামা সন্ন্যাসীর কত শত মঠ।
বাহে উদাসীন মান, গৃহী অন্তঃপট॥
সদাগরী মহাজনী ব্যবসা সবার।
এক এক জনার বাড়ী পর্ব্বত-আকার॥"

†"সাদাতে রেশম পাড়ি কত রঙ্গ করে।
শুদ্ধ সাদা অত্যুত্তম করিতে না পারে॥"

fine cotton pieces of the first quality." While writing these lines, the Rājā evidently had in mind the unapproachable muslins of Dacca.

The temples.

Next he proceeds to describe the temples. The accounts are vivid and life-like. He begins with a description of the temple of Ahalyā Bāi, the famous Maharatta queen, who spent three lakhs of rupees on building a beautiful shrine at Benares. Next he describes the temple of Viṣṇu Mahādeva, Kāṅchī and others. The architectural points of the edifices are mentioned, and the use served by their important apartments is also described at some length.

Lanes of the city—a scene of bloodshed.

The lanes of Benares were at one time scenes of bloodshed, assassination and plunder. The Ahir Rājputs are described as always carrying swords with them. *"Each looks like a king of death (যম). If he happens to have a grudge against a man, he does not feel the least scruple in wounding him. Every month there is deadly strife, and many heads roll on the ground as a result."

Our author's account of the Hindu women who visited the shrines or lived holy lives in the city, during his time, verges on the poetic :—

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*"..... যমের আকার ॥
যার সঙ্গে যাহার আক্রোশ রোষ থাকে।
অনায়াসে নির্ঘাত আঘাত করে তাকে ॥
এইমতে প্রতি মাসে প্রায় হয় দ্বন্দ।
ক্ষণমাত্রে গড়াগড়ি যায় কত স্কন্ধ ॥"

The Hindu women.

*"Some of them wear bracelets made of the horns of rhinoceros, mounted in gold which look like dark clouds lined by lightning. Their lovely tresses that hang loosly down their backs are peerless; over the breasts of some hang necklaces of bright pearls, which look as though over the peaks of the Himālaya flowed the white stream of the Ganges."

But the Rājā knew where to stop. At this stage of his description, he suddenly cuts it short by saying:—

†"The sight of women should create in the mind feelings of respect; never should any unholy thought be entertained."

This account of Benares giving a topography and other details about the city of a particular period will increase in value, in course of years, and will possess the same interest as the account of Jeruselem by Mandevile, Brahmakhanda by Vyāsa, and Navadwipa by Narahari Chakravarty.

The interchange of customs and ideas bet. Mahomedans & Hindus.

Hindus and Mahomedans had now lived in Bengal for long years in close proximity and on terms of peace and unity, and they were naturally

* "গণ্ডারের চুড়ী কারু কনক-রচিত।
ঘোর ঘন মাঝে যেন তড়িত জড়িত॥
কি উপমা দিব যেই পিঠে দোলে বেণী।
.....
কারু উরোদেশে মুক্তা-মালার দোলানী।
হিমাচলে আন্দোলিত যেন মন্দাকিনী॥"

† "এ সব দর্শনে ভক্তি মনেতে হইবে।
কদাচিৎ অন্যভাব মনেতে নাহিবে॥"

influenced by one another in many respects. In Kṣemānanda's Manasā Mangala, written more than 300 years ago, we find a passage in which it is told that in the steel-house made for Lakṣmindhara, along with many other charms to ward off evil influences, a copy of the Korān was kept. Many a Mahomedan offered *puja* at Hindu temples, as the Hindus offered *sinni* at Mahomedan mosques. In the N. W. P. the Hindus celebrated the Mahorum festivals with as great enthusiasm as the Mahomedans. Mirza Hosen Āli, a native of the Tippera district, who lived a hundred years ago, not only composed songs in praise of the goddess Kāli, but worshipped her at his house with great *eclat*; and Gariv Hosen Chaudhury of Dacca, a contemporary of the Mriza, another Mahomedan zeminder, was a devout worshipper of Çitala Devī, the goddess of small pox, worshipped by the Hindus.* Gol Mahāmud is to-day the leader of a professional party of singers in Tippera who sing only praises of the goddess Kāli, and his party carries the palm in this respect and gets engagements in preference to Hindu parties at the houses of the orthodox Hindus. Hindus have borne Mahomedan names and the Mahomedans are often called by Hindu names and such instances

*Gariv Husen Choudhury, when only 24, had gone a-hunting in the jungles on the banks of the Boori Ganga, where he chanced to see an image of Citala Devi in clay placed on the sand bank, and calling her a witch, aimed a shot at the clay image, as a mark of his contempt. The bullet fell on one of the eyes of the image, and disfigured that side of the face. That night Gariv Husen caught fever, and the symptoms of small pox quickly followed. The goddess is said to have appeared to him in a dream and told him that she would spare his life, but take one of his eyes, as he had done hers. Gariv Husen recovered with the loss of an eye, and since then turned into a devout votary of the goddess.

are very common in this country even now. In the Statesman of the 17th November 1910, there is a leader on an article from the pen of the Hon'ble Mr. Mazhal-ul-Haque on this mutual assimilation by the Hindus and the Mahomedans of the customs and thought of each other. The article appeared in the magazine—"Modern Behar." We quote from the Statesman,—"From the begining the Musalman invaders adopted wholesale the customs of the Hindus, says Mr. Mazhar-ul-Haque, and when these went entirely against their religious ideas they so adapted them as to give a semblance of conformity to their own religion. From birth to death at every stage of life, the Mahomedan in India perform ceremonies which are of purely Hindu origin. When he is born, the songs sung are not of Musalman conception but those in which allusions to Çrī Kriṣṅa are frequent. The series of ceremonies which are performed during pregnancy are adopted from the Hindus, and the symbols of Hindu religions and philosophical ideas play the most important part. At marriage the ceremonies are even more Hinduised. In Islam the simple reading of the Nikāh is quite sufficient to complete the marriage contract, and unnecessary and wasteful ceremony has always been expressly discouraged. But the Indian Musalman goes through a long series of festivities and ceremonies, most of which are bodily importations from the Hindus while others are adapted with slight modifications to give them some colour of Mahomedanism. The custom, in connection with marriage ceremonies to which Mahomedan ladies attach the greatest importance, is of purely Hindu

origin: so, too, is the line of vermilion and the dot on the forehead, while the bridal songs are all in Hindi, a language which is certainly not the mother-tongue of the Musalmans. Funeral rites, too, can be easily traced to a Hindu origin, and widow re-marriage, which is not only permitted but enjoined by Islam, is considered a disgrace in Muslem as well as in Hindu society. The mutual participation in religious festivals is a phenomenon which strikes even the European observer, though perhaps none have had the experience of Mr. Mazhar-ul-Haque himself, who relates that in his childhood at Mohorum time, he has seen Hindus weeping as copious tears at the recital of the incidents of Karbalā, as any pious Shiā would do. But perhaps the most striking instance of the sympathy of ideas to which Mr. Mazhar-ul-Haque refers is the well-known sight of Hindus revering the shrines of Musalman saints and martyrs in the same degree as, if not in a greater degree than, Musalmans themselves. Mr. Mazhar-ul-Haque repudiates the idea that this is to be attributed merely to the superistitious nature of the Hindu. "It is to be ascribed to a deep truth ingrained in "the human nature and discovered by Hindu "philosophers." No man is absolutely bad or good. Some are more, others less so. If a man was adored by his own people who know him well, the good in him must have predominated over the bad, and, acting on this principle, the Hindus adore and worship the good qualities of the man and not the man himself. "To me," says Mr. Mazhar-ul-Haque, "this worship of the Musalman "saints and pious men by the Hindus reveals

"another side of their lovable nature, and my "heart goes out to them in gratefulness and "fraternal love."

The Mahomedans of Rājshahi have the monopoly of *Bhasan gan* or songs on Manasā Devi. In Chittagong this fusion of ideas and interchange of customs and usages seems to have reached its highest point. In a Bengali poem called the Bhelua Sundari, written by Hāmidullā of Chittagong, we read that the Brahmins who had assembled to find out an auspicious day for the hero's journey abroad, consulted the Korān for the purpose. The hero, who was the son of an orthodox Hindu merchant, obeyed the injunctions 'as if they were laid down in the Vedas' and started on his voyage, 'praying to Āllāh' for his safety! Even at the present time the lower clases of Hindus in Chittagong use the expression *Allar hukum* (command) in the same sense as '*Deo volente*.' Aptavuddin, another Mahomedan poet of Chittagong who wrote a poem called the Jāmil Dilāram in 1750, writes that his hero, who was a Mahomedan, went to the nether worlds to seek a boon from the Saptarsies or the seven sages of the Hindus.

A common god

When the two communities mixed so closely, and were so greatly influenced by one another, the result was that a common God was called into existence, worshipped by Hindus and Mahomedans alike. His name was formed by compounding an Arabic word with a Sanskrit word. He was called Satya-Pir. There are many poems on Satya Pir in old Bengali, some of which are noted below:—

Satya Pir

1. Satya Pirer Pānchāli by Fakir Chānd, an inhabitant of Çuchia in Chittagong, written in 1734.

2. Satya Pir by Rāmānanda.

3. Satya Pir by Çankarāchāryya written in 1636 A.D.* A complete Ms. of this poem has been recovered by Babu Nagendra Nath Vasu from Mayurbhanja. It is a voluminous work and is divided into 15 chapters. The book discloses a curious fact about the origin of the god Satya Pir. It is a legendary account, but by comparison with the story in another work on Satya Pir by Nāyek Mayāj Gāji, we glean the fact that the Emperor Hosen Shāh of Gauḍa who tried to ensure the good will of his Hindu subjects, was the originator of the Satya Pir-cult, which made Hindus and Mahomedans join hands in worshipping a common God. Though in Orissa Satya Nārāyaṅa and Satya Pir are reckoned as the same God, they do not appear to be identical in Bengal. There is not a village in Bengal where Satya Nārāyaṅa is not worshipped once evey week, but in these *pujas* the Mahomedans do not join with the Hindus.

Poems on Satya Nārāyaṅa are to numerous to be mentioned here, as there is hardly a village in Bengal in which there is not a poem on the God; they scarcely deserve any notice being generally very short. We have quite a heap of Mss. on the subject giving short stories to illustrate the might and the grace of the deity: but none of them has risen to the dignity of a poem except the Hari Lilā by Jaya Nārāyaṅa and Ānanda Mayī about which we have already written, on pages 683-687. Amongst these Mss. we may mention one by Kavi Chandra containing a description of a river trip from Hugli to the Bay of Bengal with short notices of the

places lying on both sides of the river. This account may be found interesting by students of Geography as it was written more than 200 years ago.

Hymns to Çiva and Sarasvati by Mahomedan poets.

In a work called Yāmini Vahāl by Karimullā—an inhabitant of Sitākundu in Chittagong (1780 A.D.), the heroine, a Mahomedan, is represented as praying to the God Çiva and in another work named Imam Yātrār Puthi, the Mahomedan author has a hymn addressed to Sarsvati, the goddess of learning, beginning with the lines—

*" Hail O Sarasvati, thou art my mother.

" Thy helpless child invokes thee ; will thou not hear."

Karamali.

Karam Ali, a leading poet of Chittagong, sang exquisitely on Rādhā and Krisṇa. One of his *padas* runs thus :—

†" Rādhā wept and said, who amongst you, O my maids will bring Krisṇa to me ?

" Vrindā, my friend, help me by bringing him here from Mathura "

" My heart burns with the fire of love.

" The cuckoos on yonder boughs coo pleasantly

*" যায় মা সরস্বতি, তুমি আমার মা।
মা অনাথ বালক ডাকি শুনে শুনে না॥"

†" কান্দা কান্দা বলিতেছে শ্রীমতী রাই।
আনাদে, আনাদে মোর নাগর কানাই॥
শুন আয় বৃন্দা দূতী বলি তোমারে
মথুরায় গেল হরি আনাদে মোরে॥
প্রেমানলে দহে মোর হৃদয় অন্তরে।
বৃন্দাবনে বসিলে, দেখি কোকিল কুহরে॥

"How can I describe the agony that are caused by their notes.

"O maids of my heart, tell me who was so cruel as to cause the moon of the Vrindā groves to depart from here!

"No more do the bowers resound with the sweet notes of his flute calling 'Rādhā Rādhā.'

"Alas! am I become as nobody to him? O how sorrowful am I, when I think upon this!

"The poet Karam Āli says "Hear me Rādhā, Krishna is always in thine heart, enjoy the spiritual union, and do not weep."

Musical treatises

There are short poetical treatises on music in old Bengali literature, mainly written by the Mahomedans.

1. Rāga Mālā or an account of the various modes of Indian music with a poetical description of the presiding deity of each, and with songs in illustration by Āli Miān, Aloāl, and Tāhir Mahmud.

2. Tāla nāmā—a similar work containing songs by Saiyad Ainuddin, Saiyad Murttajā, Nasiruddin, Ālāol, Gāyeja, Dvija Raghu Nāth, Bhava-

কে হরিল প্রাণ দূতি, ব্রজের শশী।
বৃন্দাবনে রাধা বলে ডাকে না বাঁশী॥
সেই সে মনের দুঃখ কহিতে নারি কার ঠাঁই।
অভাগী রাধারে দিয়ে বুঝি শ্যামের কাজ নাই॥
কহে শ্রীকরম আলি শুন গো প্যারী।
ধ্যানে ভজ নাগর কানাই, কেঁদনা শ্রীমতী রাই॥
নিকটে আছেন তোমার প্রাণের হরি॥"

Karam Āli

nanda Āmin, Hira Mañi and other writers. This book was compiled in 1840.

3. Sṛiṣti Pattana—a work on Indian music compiled by Dāneça Kāji, Nasir Mahamud and Baksh Ali. This book also gives an account of various modes of Indian music, with a number of songs in illustration of each.

4. Dhyāna Mālā by Ali Rāj. Ali Rāj was a fine poet. In this book he gives a detailed account of various modes of music—of the six Rāgas and 36 Rāginies with directions as to the hour and season suited for singing each, and accounts of the deities presiding over them. The songs given in illustration are all composed by Ali Rāj.

5. Rāga Tāler Puthi—a poem on Indian music compiled by Jivan Ali and Rāma Tanu Achāryya.

6. Rāga Tāla by Champā Gāzi.

7. Pada Saṁgraha—This work also deals with music. It is besides a compilation of songs by different poets of whom Lāl Veg contributes a large number.

8. Jubiā—a short treatise containing only 20 songs. These used formerly to be sung on the occasion of Mahomedan marriages.

(c) Stories.

We have a pretty large number of stories written by Mahomedan writers, most of them composed in the latter part of the 17th and in the earlier half of the 18th century. In most of them the decadent taste which marks the age of Bhārata Chandra is prominent. Though the heroes and

heroines are generally Hindus, yet the inspiration of these poems seems to have come from Persian tales and poems.

Lor Chandrāni.

Under this head we should begin with Lor Chandrāni by Daulat Kāji,—a poem mentioned by Ālāol in his Padmāvati. Ālāol himself completed the book, for Daulat Kaji had not lived to finish it. The supplementary portion of Lor Chandrāni was contributed by Ālāol in the year 1657. Daulat Kāji's work was composed early in the 17th century. He had undertaken to write the poem at the command of Uzir Āsraf Khan of the Court of Runta Dharma-Rājā of Rosāng (Chittagong) whose capital is described as situated on the eastern bank of the river Karnafuli. The supplementary portion by Ālāol excels the original poem of Daulat Kāji in poetical merits.

Sapta Payakar and other stories.

Sapta Payakar by Ālāol—This poem contains seven stories, each said to have occupied one night in its narration.

Ranga Mālā by Kavir Mahmud.

Rejoān Sāhā by Samser Āli.

Bhāva Lābha by Sāmsuddin Chhiddik.

A passage in this poem runs as follows :—

"O my mind, on the ocean of this world, you have put out for trade but could win no profit.

"You forgot your real master and did not serve him as you should have done.

"The riches you sought are within you. How foolish are you to seek them elsewhere!

"Call upon Him who is the soul of your soul and He will give you relief.

"The poet Chhiddik here tells how he spent his life in vain pursuits, when he should have been serving his Master."

Eusuf Jelekhā—a Bengali rescension of Persian poem of Mahābbat nāmā by Ābdul Hākim.

Layeli Majanu—a famous Persian tale rendered into Bengali verse by Daulat Uzir Baharam.

Yāmin Jelāl and Chaitanya Silāl—a love-story by Mahomed Ākbar.

(*d*) Buddhist poems recovered from Chittagong.

Buddha Ranjikā.

Bauddha Ranjikā by Nīla Kamala Dās. This is a translation of the Burmese work Thāḍu Thāng into Bengali metrical verse. The date of composition of this work is not known, but the Ms. is more than 100 years old. Nīla Kamala Das translated it under orders of Rāni Kālindi, wife of Rājā Dharma Baks of the Chittagong Hill tracts. It gives an account of Buddha's life from his birth to the time of his preaching the doctrine of Nirvāṅa. It is the only book yet found in old Bengali literature in which Buddha's life is described.

Nīlār Vāra Māsa.

Nilār Vāra Māsa. Who this Nīlā (Lilā) was no one knows; but the Bengali ladies still observe a fast on a particular day of April in memory of Lilāvati. From the poem under notice it appears that Nilā's husband turned a Buddhist monk renouncing his home, and Nilā passed through unheard of hardships to get him back and win him to the sweets of a domestic life. The poem has come down to us as a rustic song; but though woven into crude rhymes, it has a deep pathos

which explains to us the impression that the woes of Līlā must once have made on the popular mind. Līla's husband is described as having been an inhabitant of Nanda Pātana in Sulluk. His father's name was Gangādhara and his mother's name Kalāvati.

Mss. brought to light by M. Abdul Karim.

The works by Mahomedan writers noticed under the head 'Miscellaneous works' have been mainly brought to light by the researches of Munsi Abdul Karim, late Head Master of the Anwārā School in Chittagong. We have not been able to see these Mss., but brief notices of them have from time to time appeared in the Vangiya Sāhitya Parisat Patrikā from which our accounts are gleaned. The Mss. may be traced with the help of Munshi Abdul Karim. Considering the fact that a large number of these Mss. is being destroyed every year by white ants, worms and fire, as they are generally preserved in wretched straw-built huts, immediate efforts should be made to recover them. Otherwise we may only rise to the consciousness of the necessity of preserving them when it will be already too late.

Moslem writers of Radhā-Kriṡṇa songs.

The works mentioned above disclose plenty of songs by Mahomedan writers on Rādhā and Kriṣṇa, which show that the love songs of the Vaiṣṇavas were appreciated beyond the pale of their own society, and inspired even that race of *Iconoclasts* who had once gloried in breaking up Hindu temples. The soil of India favours the growth of toleration and sympathy in religion, and it is no wonder to find that those who came with the

sword became, in course of time, united to us in love and good will.

The works of Mahomedan writers mentioned in this book are all written in more or less sanskritised Bengali, and not in that style known as Musulmānni Bāngālā, which shows an admixture of Urdu, Persian and Arabic words with corrupt Bengali.

Works written in Musalmāni Bāngālā.

A vast literature of the rustic Mahomedans is to be found written in Musalmāni Bāngālā, and there are many works of this class, some of which may be traced back to the 16th century. But for various reasons we have not found it convenient to include books written in Musalmāni Bāngālā in the present work.

II. Mainly on style, literary tastes and language.

The chief feature of the poetical literature dealt with in this chapter is its wealth of *chhandas* or metres adopted from Sanskrit. Though in the earlier epochs some of our writers had tried to introduce Sanskrit metres, their attempts were marked with that crudeness which often characterises the products of beginners. Bābrata Chandra has done yeoman's service to our literature by enriching it with various Sanskrit metres, some of which he imitated to perfection in Bengali. His *totaka* and *bhujanga prayata* are almost faultless—a success which could not have been anticipated in a language that seemed so unsuited as our own for the rich and varied metres of Sanskrit, especially as there is no distinction between long and short

The Sanskrit metres in Bengali.

vowel sounds in its syllables. Rāma Prasāda was the first to attempt some of the Sanskrit metres in high-flown Bengali, and though his efforts were not crowned with a full measure of success, yet he discovered the innate strength of our language, which gave promise in his writings, of happier developments. In the Vidyā Sundara by Rāma Prasāda we often find the right accent of vowels not adhered to, as required by the particular metre that he attempted. For instance in his *totaka* in the line ধনি মুখ চিবুক ধরে যতনে the উ is untenable in মু and বু owing to its short sound. In the Hari līlā by Jaya Nārāyana, another clever poet, who tried his hand at Sanskrit metres in Bengali compositions, we find his *bhujanga prayata* faulty in many places, as for instance in the lines বসিয়া সুবর্ণের পীঠে হাসিছে। প্রবালাধরে মন্দ মন্দ ভাসিছে,—the ই in the second and the eleventh letters and the আ in the tenth letter of the 1st line are incorrect, and in the second line the 1st, the 7th, the 10th, and the 11th letters do not conform to the rules required by the metre: the first three ought to have short sounds and the last (the 11th) a long sound. Numerous instances of such faults may be found: but it was surely a bold step for writers to attempt Sanskritic metres in a language which had no long short and vowel-sounds in its current forms. But Bharata Chandra had a remarkable aptitude for hitting on the most appropriate words, and though he had to struggle against these disadvantages, yet he put the materials at his command to the best possible use. His remarkable power of choosing elegant expressions is best evidenced by the fact that though he successfully introduced some of the

Bhārata Chandra's signal success,

noblest Sanskrit metres into Bengali, yet there is no trace of any struggle on his part for this end. He creates pictures in words, as for instance, in his description of Çiva's great wrath, to which I have already referred on page 668. This could not have been grander in any other language. When we peruse his poems we are so powerfully captivated by his descriptions, that we quite forget that they were wrought in one of the most difficult metres of Sanskrit, with a perfection hitherto unequalled in Bengali. Bhārata Chandra's writings have suffered considerably in the hands of his copyists who were ignorant of the rules of Sanskrit verse. They occasionally tampered with the readings, and copyists as a class have always done so in regard to all other poems, with this difference that in the case of works written by other poets they have occasionally improved on the orignal by such changes, whereas in the case Bhārata Chandras's works they have invariably done more harm than good, as the change of a single syllable would disturb his scheme of metre, a matter of which ordinary copyists had no knowledge.

Çiva's anger in bhujanga prayāta.

I quote below the famous lines in the *bhujanga prayata* describing Çiva's anger. Now in the printed books we find শঙ্গ in the second line for শৃঙ্গ, শৰ্দ্দি in the 17th line for নর্দ্দি, ই having been changed to ঈ, as the word forms a compound with তৃপ্তী. The metre contains 12 letters in each line and runs thus ⏑ – ⏑ – ⏑ – ⏑ – The text should be reduced to the following form for a right exposition of the metre :—

*ম হা রু দ্র রূ পে ম হা দে ব সা জে।

ভ ভ ম্ভ ম্ ভ ভ ম্ভ ম্ শি ঙা ঘো র বা জে॥

ল টা পট্ জ টা জূ ট সং ঘ ট্ট গ ঙ্গা।

ছ ল চ্ছল্ ট ল ট্টল্ ক ল ক্কল্ ত র ঙ্গা॥

ফ ণা ফ ণ্ ফ ণা ফ ণ্ ফ ণী ফ ণ্ণ গা জে।

দি নে শ প্র তা পে নি শা না থ সা জে॥

ধ ক ধ্বক্ ধ ক ধ্বক্ জ্ব লে ব হ্নি ভা লে।

ব ব ম্বম্ ব ব ম্বম্ ম হা শ ব্দ গা লে॥

দ ল ম্মল্ দ ল ম্মল লে মু ণ্ড মা লা।

ক টি ক ট্ট স দ্যো ম রা হ স্তি ছা লা॥

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*মহারুদ্ররূপে মহাদেব সাজে।
ভভম্ভম্ ভভম্ভম্ শিঙা ঘোর বাজে॥
লটাপট্ জটাজূট সংঘট্ট গঙ্গা।
ছলচ্ছল্ টলট্টল্ কলকল্ তরঙ্গা॥
ফণাফণ্ ফণাফণ্ ফণীফণ্ণ গাজে।
দিনেশপ্রতাপে নিশানাথ সাজে॥
ধকধ্বক্ ধকধ্বক্ জ্বলে বহ্নি ভালে
ববম্বম্ ববম্বম্ মহাশব্দ গালে॥
দলম্মল্ দলম্মল্ গলে মুণ্ডমালা।
কটি কট্ট সদ্যোমরা হস্তিছালা॥

˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — —
প চা চ র্ম্ম ঝু লী ক রে লো ল ঝো লে।
˘ ˘ ˘ — ˘
ম হা ঘো র আ ভা পি না ক ত্রি শূ লে॥
˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — —
ধি য়া তা ধি য়া তা ধি য়া ভূ ত না চে।
˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — —
উ ল ঙ্গী উ ল ঙ্গে পি শা চী পি শা চে॥
˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — —
স হ স্রে স হ স্রে চ লে ভূ ত দা না।
˘ ˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — —
হু হু ঙ্কা র হাঁ কে উ ড়ে স র্প বা ণা॥
˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — —
চ লে ভৈ র বা ভৈ র বী ন ন্দি ভৃ ঙ্গী।
˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — —
ম হা কা ল বে তা ল তা ল ত্রি শূ ঙ্গী॥
˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — —
চ লে ডা কি নী যো গি নী ঘো র বে শে।
˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — — ˘ — —
চ লে শাঁ খি নী পে তি নী মু ক্ত কে শে॥

পচাচম্ম ঝুলী করে লোল ঝোলে।
মহাঘোর আভা পিনাকে ত্রিশূলে॥
ধিয়া তাধিয়া তাধিয়া ভূত নাচে।
উলঙ্গী উলঙ্গে পিশাচী পিশাচে॥
সহস্রে সহস্রে চলে ভূত দানা।
হুহুঙ্কার হাঁকে উড়ে সর্পবাণা॥
চলে ভৈরবা ভৈরবী নন্দিভৃঙ্গী
মহাকাল বেতাল তাল ত্রিশৃঙ্গী॥
চলে ডাকিনী যোগিনী ঘোর বেশে।
চলে শাঁখিনী পেতিনী মুক্ত কেশে॥

ᴗ – ᴗ – – ᴗ – – ᴗ – –
গি য়া দ ক্ষ য জ্ঞে স বে য জ্ঞ না শে।

ᴗ – – ᴗ – ᴗ – – ᴗ – –
ক থা না স রে দ ক্ষ রা জে ত রা সে ॥

ᴗ – – ᴗ – – ᴗ – – ᴗ – –
অ দূ রে ম হা রু দ্র ডা কে গ ভী রে।

ᴗ – – ᴗ – – ᴗ – – ᴗ – –
অ রে রে অ রে দ ক্ষ দে রে স তী রে ॥

ᴗ – – ᴗ – – ᴗ – – ᴗ – –
ভু জ ঙ্গ প্র য়া তে ক হে ভা র তী দে।

ᴗ – – ᴗ – ᴗ – ᴗ – –
স তী দে স তী দে স তী দে স তী দে ॥

Besides closely following, as far as possible in Bengali, some of the noble Sanskrit metres, Bhārata Chandra performed a much more arduous task by making the couplets composed in Sanskrit metres rhyme with one another. Sanskrit verse does not require this, but the readers of Bengali during this period considered it to be an indispensable condition of poetical compositions. With all these self-imposed restrictions in his poem Bhārata succeeded in hiding the art he had employed, and the verses run clear and limpid reflecting the merry and sublime sentiments of the poet's soul.

Rhyming added.

গিয়া দক্ষযজ্ঞে সবে যজ্ঞ নাশে।
কথা না সরে দক্ষরাজে তরাসে ॥
অদূরে মহারুদ্র ডাকে গভীরে।
অরে রে অরে দক্ষ দে রে সতীরে ॥
ভুজঙ্গ-প্রয়াতে কহে ভারতী দে।
সতী দে সতী দে সতী দে সতী দে ॥"

Long after Bhārata Chandra, Valadeva Pālit, a poet who wanted to revive the old taste for artistic poetry, which had, however, in his time grown to be a thing of the past, employed in his Bengali poem called Bhartṛihari Kāvya, all the chief metres of Sanskrit. He was a true student imbued with a refined classical taste and his Sanskrit vocabulary was immense. With all these qualities, however, he failed to make any impression in the literature of his period. Bhārata had been essentially a poet of his age which had demanded in Bengali poetry a close conformity with the rules of Sanskrit rhetoric; alliteration and other figures of speech were prominent characteristics of the period, and the school begun by Bhārata Chandra served as a model to a host of writers; he had besides been a born poet, who adorned all that he touched, and if he employed Sanskritic metres, it was because a keen appreciation of the beauty of their sound so completely possessed his soul that he could not resist their flow in his Bengali poetry. Valadeva, however, wrote with the pedantic object of showing himself learned, and he succeeded in this end, for his readers certainly gave him a certificate that his ingenuity elicited their admiration; but the laurels which adorn the brow of a true poet were not reserved for a writer of his conceit and pedantry. I quote below two extracts from the writings of Valadeva Pālit to illustrate the metres Mālinivritti containing fifteen letters in each line running thus: – ⏑ – ⏑ – ⏑ – ⏑ – – – – – – – – – and Vaṁçasthavila containing 12 letters in each running thus: – ⏑ – – – ⏑ – ⏑ – ⏑ – respectively.

Valadeva Pālit.

His attempts to revive Ssnskrit metres.

Mālinivritti :—

"ফুল সম সুকুমারী, দীর্ঘকেশী কৃশাঙ্গী
অচপল তড়িতাভা সুন্দরী গৌরকান্তি।
মধুর নববয়স্কা পদ্মিনী অগ্রগণ্যা
যুবক-নয়ন-লোভা কামিনী কামশোভা॥"

Vaṁçasthavila :—

"তথায় ভীমাসিত-বর্ম্ম-ভূষিত
প্রচণ্ড আভাময় চক্র মস্তকে।
সবিদ্যুতাগ্নি প্রলয়োন্মুখাভ্রবৎ
কৃপাণ-পাণি প্রহরী ব্রজে ভ্রমে॥"

The lines in the Mālini *chhanda* are nearly correct. In the third line of the stanza in Vaṁçasthvila the writer commits a mistake in compounding সবিদ্যুতাগ্নি which should have been সবিদ্যুদগ্নি. There are, besides, some other inaccuracies also. Valadeva Pālit, when putting Bengali verse in Sanskrit metre, omits to conform to the rule observed by the preceding Bengali writers, *viz.*, that all metrical verses should rhyme. Strictly speaking the words প্রচণ্ড আভাময় are untenable in a Bengali poem which requires, that after the first word in a line containing three letters there should be a corresponding word containing three letters.

Payāra Chhanda.

The bulk of the old poetical literature of Bengal is in the metre called the Payāra. It consists of 14 letters in each line, and there is a cæsura after 8 letters. If the first word in a line of Payāra consists of two letters, either the second must have four letters or the second and the third must have two letters each. If the first word has four letters, the second word must have either four letters or

the second and the third words, two letters each. If the first word has three letters, the second word must have three letters as well. That verse is defective which violates this rule, though all the letters counted in a line may come up to 14. The first line rhymes with the second and the two rhyming lines make an entire stanza. The word Payāra has been evidently derived from the word Pada. The word 'Pāyā' in Bengali which means the foot of a bedstead, or 'Tripāyā' which means a three-footed light-stand, illustrates the similar forms derived from the word Pada.

Tripadī.

The next favourite metre of the old poets was the Tripadī. The Tripadī was a verse of the Rig Veda containing three padas or hemistiches. The verses were called Tripada Riks (*vide* Pānini IV, 1, 9). This metre which is traced to the Rig Veda was adopted in Prākrita and through that channel passed into Bengali. In Tripadī as in the case of Payāra, there was in the early times no hard and fast rule about the number of letters, but gradually as the study of metre reached perfection, the number of letters in each hemistich, of which there are three making a half stanza, was fixed. The first two half-lines which rhyme, contain six letters each, and the third half-line which rhymes with the 6th contains eight letters. Jayadeva introduced this Sanskritic metre though without observing any definite number in the letters. Rhyme was no necessary condition. The half-stanza 'রতিসুখসারে, গতমভিসারে মদন-মনোহরবেশম্'—sounds as the keynote to the modern Tripadī in Bengali. In the next half-stanza, however, '—ন কুরু নিতম্বিনি, গমনবিলম্বন মনুসর হংস হৃদয়েশম্

and its off-shoots.

the first half-lines do not rhyme. They consist besides of seven letters each, and the third half-line of eight letters. In Prākrita, the verses like চরণ-গণবিপ্ল, পঢ়মলইথপ্ল or সত্তা দীহা জানেহী, কপ্লাতিপ্লামানেহী" (Pingala) illustrate that the Tripada and the Dvipada metres first traced in the Rig Veda had branched off into many quaint forms in the Prākrita language. The Dvipada and Tripada metres attained perfection in Bengali ; and various metres in this tongue, such as the *Dīrgha Tripadī, †Laghu Tripadī, ‡Bhanga Tripadī, §Dīrgha Chaupadī, ‖Hinapada

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*" কালীদহের জলে, কুমারী কমলদলে,
গজ গিলে উগারে অঙ্গনা ॥"
Chandī by Kavikañkaṅa.

†" থাক, থাক, থাক, কাটাইব নাক, আগেতে রাজারে কহি।
মাথা মুড়াইব, শালে চড়াইব, ভারতে কহিছে সহি ॥"
Vidyāsundara by Bhārata Chandra.

‡" ওরে বাছা ধূমকেতু, মা বাপের পুণ্যহেতু,
কেটে ফেল চোরে, ছেড়ে দেহ মোরে, ধর্ম্মের বাঁধহ সেতু।"
Vidyāsundara by Bhārata Chandra.

§" এক কাণে শোভে ফণিমণ্ডল, এক কাণে শোভে মণিকুণ্ডল,
আধ অঙ্গে শোভে বিভূতি ধবল, আধই গন্ধ কস্তুরীরে ॥
Annada Mañgala by Bhārata Chandra.

‖ " হর মম দুঃখ হর।
হর রোগ, হর তাপ, হর শোক, হর পাপ, হিমকরশেখর শঙ্কর ॥"
Annadā Mañgala by Bhārata Chandra.

Tripadi, *Mātrā Tripadi and †Mātrā Chatuspadi, &c., have been formed in Bangali by an archaic manipulation of the Dvipada and Tripadī metres, as also by an artistic combination of them.

The earlier Tripadī.

The earlier Tripadī metres were of a crude form. There was neither that elegant rhyming nor that fixity in the number of letters in each line which have rendered it now-a-days one of the most lovely metres in our tongue. We quote the following extracts from the Mahabhārata by Kavindra Parameçvara, written 400 years ago, to show how quaint in form it was in those days.

and its example.

"শিশু হতে পুত্র, দেবগুরু পূজন্ত,
নাহিক যে পরস্পর ভেদ,
বিপ্রতপন্ত, সতত করেন্ত,
অভ্যাস করন্ত ধনুর্ব্বেদ ॥

সতত সত্য ছাড়ি অসত্য না বোলেন্ত।
প্রতিবর্গের, প্রাণ সমসর,
বিচিত্র যোদ্ধা মহাবীর ॥
মাদ্রী গর্ভে হৈল, মোহর প্রিয় পুত্র,
নকুল কোমল শরীর ॥
বহুশত্রু ক্ষয়, করিল পুত্র মোর,
পুনি কি দেখিম নয়নে
কহ ত গোবিন্দ, হাহা শিশুপুত্র,
নকুল চলিয়া গেল বনে ॥"

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*"ঝন ঝন কঙ্কণ, নূপুর রণ রণ।
ঘুন্থ ঘুন্থ ঘুঙ্গুর বোলে।"

Vidyasundara by Bharata Chandra.

†"হে শিবমোহিনি, শম্ভুনিসূদনি, দৈত্যবিঘাতিনি, দুঃখহরে ॥"

Annadā Mañgala by Bhārata Chandra.

In all the earlier works we find Tripadī adopted in Bengali verses for the purpose of conveying sentiments of grief; it was considered to be the fit metre by the poets of old school for giving expression to feelings of mourning or of any dire loss, and it was called লাচাড়ী which is no doubt a corrupt form of the word লহরী.

Folly in alliteration and puns.

The artistic school of Bhārata Chandra greatly improved the resources of our language, and contributed to that elegance for which it has now won universal praise; but their attempts often produced abortive results also in the craze for alliteration, evinced not only by poets but by writers of prose during this period. Alliteration and puns on words became a notorious literary folly, many writers having carried them to abnormal excesses. One can hardly imagine how a sane man could have produced a composition like the following;—

"রে পাষণ্ড ষণ্ড, এই প্রকাণ্ড ব্রহ্মাণ্ডকাণ্ড দেখিয়াও কাণ্ডজ্ঞান শূন্য হইয়া বকাণ্ড প্রত্যাশার ন্যায় লণ্ডভণ্ড হইয়া ভণ্ড সন্ন্যাসীর ন্যায় ভক্তি-ভাণ্ড ভঞ্জন করিতেছ এবং গবা-পণ্ডের ন্যায় গণ্ডে জন্মিয়া গণ্ডকীস্থ গণ্ডশিলার গণ্ড না বুঝিয়া গণ্ডগোল করিতেছ."

Even gifted writers like Içvara Chandra Gupta were not free from the great folly of the age, and we find his prose writings often disfigured by too much indulgence in alliteration. In the Çiçu Vodhaka, an elementary book for children, that used to be read in the Pathaçālās half a century ago, there is much useful and instructive information for the boys to which no one can take objection, but there is an atrocious model letter in it which must have been contributed by a pedantic Sanskrit

scholar, the silliness of which, not to speak of its wicked taste, passes all limit of decency, specially as it has been incorporated in to a juvenile reader. We need not dwell upon the letter which is an example of a wife writing to her husband, but to show how a spirit of alliteration prevailed in the age, we quote its first lime.

"শ্রীচরণ-সরসি দিবানিশি সাধন-প্রয়াসী দাসী"

Not only in regard to alliteration but in puns on words also, the fashion ran to excess. We quote below passages from various writers to show the sort of puns which characterised the writings of the day. Examples of them are only too numerous in the writings of standard authors of this period :

"ও বীণে, লবিনে, জানকী-প্রাণকান্তের নাম বিনে।
যে পথে আছে কাল রবিসুত রে, সে পথে যেন রবিনে॥"

Daçarathi.

"যতই কাঁদে বাছা বলি সর সর
আমি অভাগিনী বলি সর্ সর্
বল্লেম নাহি অবসর কেবা দিবে সর
অমনি সর্ সর্ বলে ফেলিলাম ঠেলে"
"যদি না পাই কিশোরীরে কাজ কি শরীরে"
"উপেখিলে রাই স্থান অখিলে নাই"

Krisna Kamala.

The typical writer of the age like Butler's Hudibras

"..... ...could not ope
His mouth, but outflew a trope."

But artificiality can never completely crush nature. Like those tiny weeds and plants whose rootlets pierce through adamantine rocks and draw their sap from stones, the literature of an age held

in the iron grip of rhetoric, has yet strange offshoots which, though humble, discover a strength not possessed by the great,—sufficient to assert the victory of nature over all the forces and appliances employed to thwart her. Some of the Kaviwālās, who were almost illiterate, composed songs in unassuming and artless language, which charmed even the highly educated of this age of rigid classic taste by their simplicity. The Umā *sangita*, of which I have already spoken in a foregoing chapter, composed by writers of meagre education, discloses a style in which simple and elegant words produce, without any attempt at puns or alliteration, a far greater effect on the emotions than all the grandiloquent phraseology at the command of a poetic master of rhetoric could do.

How nature asserts herself.

Not only some of the Kaviwālās, but also Nidhu Babu, who was a man of light and leading, preferred simple words and a plainness of style which strikes us by its contrast with the spirit of pedantry that guided contemporary writers.

When Sanskrit metres were being so closely adopted in Bengali poems, and learned scholars were trying to place the art of writing poetry hopelessly out of reach of the common mortals by imposing subtle rules on all forms of versification, Dāçarathi Rāy's new school of doggerel, called Pānchāli, asserted itself in bold defiance of all metrical rules,—rhyming being the only condition in their composition. He certainly took his cue from the sort of verses made extempore by the Kaviwālās as sequel to their songs. The Bengali poetry of a very early age had been called Pānchāli. This was a period

Daçarathi's Pāñchāli—a departure from classical model.

when the metre Payār had not been fossilised into 14 letters with the rules of cæsura and the arrangements of words in each line to which I have already referred. Pānchāli was the metre for the masses. The last letter of the first line agreed with the last letter of the second line; and no other restraint was put upon it. Sometimes we get couplets of the following nature:—

"পরিধানের সাড়ী দিল ময়নামতি জলত বিছায়্যা।
যোগাসন করিল ময়না ধরম স্মরণ করিয়া॥"

Mānik Chandra Rājār Gān.

The first line contains 20 letters and the second line 19. There are also numerous instances of very short lines, as "তার বদলে ছয় মাস কাল খায়" (13 letters).

Dāçarathi revised the Pānchāli with this difference that without conforming to the rules of the Payār, Tripadi, or any other kind of Bengali metre, he had still a way of rhyming of his own, and the expressions that he particularly chose were not crude or inelegant as in their earlier prototypes, but were generally of a refined character, though simple and colloquial. The Pānchāli suited the understanding of illiterate audiences who were taken by surprise by the wonderful rapidity and flow of doggerel-rhyme, which took a wild course, owing to its freedom from the restraints of any regular metre. I quote a few verses from Dāçarathi's Pānchāli.

"রাজার মায়ের এমনি গুণ—11 (letters)
ভাল করুণ বা না করুণ—10 (letters)
না গেলে পরে মন্দ করবেন রাগে—13 (letters)
উনি বল্‌ছেন পাবে অশ্ব—10 (letters)
আমি বল্‌ছি পাব ভস্ম—9 (letters)
পোড়া কপালে জোড়া নাহি লাগে—11 (letters)

The first line rhymes with the second, the third with the sixth and the fourth with the fifth, so he follows no fixed code. Besides this, while going on with his verses in the above strain, he suddenly introduces a quite different form, which shows some affinity with the Tripadi, more often breaking its rules, however, than conforming to them.

When the rules of metre had put such complex restraint on metrical compositions, the Pānchāli and the extempore verses of the *Kaviwalas* opened out a new channel for the free expression of the thoughts and sentiments of our masses for whom Bengali had already became too learned,—not so much in its vocabulary as in its artistic forms and in the subtle conditions of its metre.

Learned discussions.

This was an age when a display of classical learning was made through the vehicle of the vernacular, and as a matter of course it was most in evidence in the discussions of scholarly Brahmins on various points of philosophy and literature. On these occasions there were animated scenes in which the Brahmins, in the enthusiasm of advocating their own points, often dragged their opponents by the locks of hair that dangled behind their shaven heads, or otherwise offered what appeared like affronts of a personal nature. These of course never reached any very immoderate excess. The lock was really pulled to draw the attention of the opponent to the points which his rival Pundit had so enthusiastically tried to establish. In a heated scene of this nature box after box of snuff was emptied of its contents in a few moments, and the discussion sometimes continued day and night. There was

invariably a judge or mediator where two Pundits argued, and his duty was not only to give the final verdict, so that the vanquished might not argue any more, but also to interrupt when any irrelevency or want of moderation marked the controversy. The Pundits were generally called to a rich man's house on the occasion of Çrāds and other religious ceremonies, and those who excelled in open controversy with their rivals were entitled to special rewards, though many would not accept any gift whatever, priding themselves both on their scholarship and their poverty. This system of inviting the Pundits by rich men is still preserved in Bengal *in form*; but with the decadence of the spirit of patronising Sanskrit learning, the matter has lost the great importance and interest which it once possessed. In rich men's houses, the well-known Pundits not only of Bengal, but of the whole of India, used to be assembled for the discussion of Philosophy, Logic, Poetry, Astronomy, Theology and other subjects. Thus learning received a social impetus, and even fresh life on such occasions. Opportunities were frequently offered to Pundits for such meetings, so that during a period when there were no facilities of communication, and no proper conveyances for undertaking long journies, this system kept alive a continual interchange of high thoughts and thus contributed to the preservation and development of classical learning. The Pundits led very simple lives, without coveting earthly fortunes or caring for luxury of any kind, and were quite indifferent to praise or blame—often really devoted to a high spiritual life and to the cause of learning. The following passage from

The meeting of the learned.

And its great usefulness.

The description of a meeting

Jaya Nārāyaṅa's Hari Līlā shows what the discussions of the Pundits were like. The poet describes a meeting on a festal occasion.

*"The learned Brahmins received letters of invitation and hastened to attend the meeting.

"They were present there with the sole object of furthering the cause of their religious doctrines and were not prepared to accept any gifts.

"Their faces beamed with intelligence, and dressed in white garments, they seated themselves on scarlet-coloured Bhutan seats.

"They wore the sacred Ganges' mud on their foreheads; and white sacred threads adorned their breasts.

"As soon as they took their seats they commenced an animated discussion.

"The Logicians stepped forward to discuss the question of conclusions from given premises, and the evidence of the senses, pointing out the connection between proof and the thing proven.

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*"ব্রাহ্মণ পণ্ডিতগণে, পাইয়া পত্র নিমন্ত্রণে,
উপনীত সভা আরোহণে।
কেবল অধিষ্ঠান মাত্র, দান নিতে নহে পাত্র,
ধর্ম্ম সংস্থাপন কারণে॥
তেজসপুঞ্জ সুকিরণ, শুক্লবর্ণ সুবসন,
ভালেতে গঙ্গামৃত্তিকা ফোঁটা।
শুক্ল যজ্ঞোপবীতে, রক্ত ভোট আসনেতে,
বসিতেহি বিচারের ঘটা॥
অনুমান প্রত্যক্ষেতে, পরস্পর সম্বন্ধেতে,
তার্কিক ঘটায় নানা তর্ক।

"They cited Kusumānjali as their authority and tried to establish the fact of the divine existence by various methods of argument.

"In a discussion about words and topics, containing long compound words of which each would take half an hour to recite, the grammarians began to find fault with one another's arguments, and made home-thrusts against their opponents, basing their discourses chiefly on the supplement by Gopinātha.

"In another quarter sweet discourses on rhetoric were going on. Their subject was figurative allusions and the suggestions they contained. They drew illustrations in support of their theories from the Kāvya Prakāça.

"There were fair fights on literary subjects also. The mediators were often called in to give their verdict in respect to the interpretations given by

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প্রমাণ কুসুমাঞ্জলি. নানা মতে ব্রহ্ম বলি.
একে আর ঘটায় সম্পর্ক ॥
পদ পদার্থ বিচারেতে. এক দণ্ড সমাসেতে.
কার কত নিন্দিত ঘটাইয়া ।
বৈয়াকরণিয়া সবে. বিচার কর্কশ রবে.
গোপীনাথ পরিশিষ্ট লইয়া ॥
মধুর বাক্যের বাণী. অলঙ্কার শুনি ধ্বনি.
এক দিগে কহিছে রসেতে ।
ধ্বনি বাক্য কয়ে কয়ে. ব্যঞ্জনাদিক লয়ে.
কাব্য প্রকাশ উদাহরণেতে ॥

opposing parties, of the meanings of lines from the Raghu, the Bhatti, the Çiçupāla Vadha and the Naiṣadha Kāvya.

"Those who discoursed on the Purāṅas quoted chapter and verse from Vaçiṣtha, and others, who elected Astrology as the subject of their discourse discussed particular conjunctions of planets and their aspects, positions, and influences in regard to human life. Their chief authority was the Suryya Siddhānta.

"The Vedāntists held that the supreme soul pervades all; virtue and vice, which appear to us as such from a superficial point of view, are merely phenomenal. All alike spring from Him. There is nothing hostile or friendly. Such ideas are merely

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নানা ছন্দে শ্লোক পাঠ, সাহিত্যে বিচার ঠাট,
কত মত বর্ণনা ভাবের।
রসিক বিবুধগণে, মধ্যস্থ পণ্ডিত মানে
রঘু, ভট্ট, মাঘ, নৈষধের॥
পৌরাণিক পণ্ডিতে, নানা মত প্রসঙ্গেতে,
বিচার করিছে ভাবি মনে।
বশিষ্টাদি বেদ জানে, সূক্ষ্ম ভাবগণে,
অন্ত প্রত্যন্তর লিখি।
দশা বিদশা বসতি, জানায় সাধু প্রতি,
সূর্য্য সিদ্ধান্তের মত দেখি॥
সকলেতে ব্রহ্মময়, বেদান্তে এমত কয়,
পাপ পুণ্যালয় নিরঞ্জন।
শত্রু মিত্রময় তিনি, জ্ঞান ভেদে ভিন্ন মানি
শঙ্করাচার্য্যের এ লিখন॥

illusive. He alone is really root of all. This is the view, the Vedantists argued, that was held by Çankarāchāryya; also the great law-giver Çula Pāni, Manu, and others have openly avowed this truth."

The education of women.

Amongst respectable people the women-folk not only received a sound education in Bengali, but often acquired a good knowledge of Sanskrit also. Ānandamayī's education made her a match for any ordinary Sanskrit-knowing Pundit; and of her literary compositions, bearing evidences of great pedantry, we have already spoken in full. Yajneçvari, a poetess who composed songs for a Kavi party, lived in the beginning of the 19th century, and some of her songs show creditable command over the language. Gangāmaṅi Devī, a sister of the poet Jaya Nārāyaṅa Sen and a native of Vikrampur in Dācca, composed a large number of songs, which the women of that place sing up to now, during marriage festivities.

Arabic, Persian, and Hindi.

In the courts of the Hindu Rājās it was considered an indispensable acquirement for a scholar to have a knowledge of Arabic, Persian and Hindusthāni. The Pundits who scrupulously avoided all court-influences, considered a knowledge of any other language than Sanskrit as profane, just as they would not touch a non-Hindu or a low caste Hindu for fear of contamination.

পড়িলে বিপত্তিকালে, দোষ যদি ঘটে বলে,
ধর্ম্মশাস্ত্র মতে পাপ নহে।
স্মৃতিশাস্ত্রে লেখা এই, শূলপাণি মত এই,
মক্তকণ্ঠ হৈয়া মনু কহে॥"

But those Brahmins, who did not soar so high in their fancied greatness and cared for the favour of the Rājās, acquired Bengali, Persian, Arabic and Hindusthani along with Sanskrit, and Bhārata Chandra Rāy Guṅākara was a man of sound culture in all these tongues. In describing a conversation between the Emperor Jāhāngīr and Rājā Mān Sinha, our poet says :—

*"It would be fit in the nature of things to give the gist of the conversation, that took place between Rājā Mān Sinha and the Emperor in Arabic, Persian and Hindusthani, for it must have been carried on in a mixed language. I have studied these languages and can write in them; but the account would scarcely be intelligible to ordinary people. Besides, by giving the discourse in different languages I should destroy the effect on the reader's mind of my own poetry, and it would lose much of its simplicity. So I must be content with borrowing only occasionally, words from those languages in my Bengali."

But though he curbed his desire in this instance to display his varied scholarship, he did not always use such discretion. He adopted a heterogenous

* "মানসিংহ পাতসার হইল যে বাণী।
উচিত যে পারশী, আরবী, হিন্দুস্থানী॥
পড়িয়াছি সেইমত বর্ণিবার পারি।
কিন্তু সে সকল লোক বুঝিবারে ভারি॥
না রবে প্রসাদগুণ না হবে রসাল।
অতএব কহি ভাষা যবনী মিশাল॥"

language in a certain short poem for the purpose of display. The following extract will show what such efforts were like.

"শ্যামহিত প্রাণেশ্বর, বারদকে গোয়দ রুবর,
কাতর দেখে আদর কর, কাহে মবরো রোয়কে
বক্ত্রং বেদং চন্দ্রমা, চুঁ লালা চে রেমা,
কোধিত পর দেও ক্ষমা, মেটিমে কাহে শোয়কে ॥"

Change undergone by words in use and meaning.

Some of the words that were largely used in the 18th century have grown obsolete. The word 'মেনে' for instance, which we meet with frequently in Bhārata Chandra's poems, is no longer used in writing. The word seems to have no meaning; it was only used to emphasise a statement or merely to fill up a space in a line of verse which did not come up to the fixed number of letters required by the metre. The words নেহা, পেখিল, রঘরণী দোহে, এথায়, এবে, এড়িল are not now used in prose-writings; they are confined to poetry.

There are numerous words in Bengali which have lost their original Sanskritic significance. The word পীরিত is derived from প্রীতি-love, but the former word in colloquial Bengali has been degraded in sense, and implies an illicit love. It was the promiscuous mixing of men and women in the lower orders of Vaiṣṇava society, which by leading to immorality, caused the degeneration in the meaning of this word. But at the time of Chandi Dās, and even of the poets of a subsequent age, the word was still true to its original significance in current Bengali and implied a pure sentiment. Chandi Dās wrote short discourses using the word to imply a highly refined and austere feeling. The

word রাগ has two meanings in Sankrit; it means colour and attachment. In Bengali it has come to signify fits of anger, probably owing to one's face and eyes being reddened under passion. But at the time of Chaitanya, 400 years ago, the Bengali word had not yet lost its original meaning. In the Kaḍcnā by Govinda Dās we find it used in the sense of love or attachment, as in the line "রাগে ডগমগ প্রভু করে সন্তরণ." There is no difference in Sanskrit between the words রাগ and অনুরাগ. In Bengali, the one implies anger, and the other love, though the words রঞ্জিত and অনুরঞ্জিত—participal adjective-forms of the two words respectively—have retained their Sanskritic significance. The Bengali word derived from Sanskrit ভর্ত্তা (lit. one who maintains), a husband, has been degraded in Bengali and is not used in decent society, though I can not make out the reason why. The word ভাণ্ডারী (lit. a store-keeper) does not possess its original elevated sense; it now generally means with us a menial servant. The word ভাসুর in colloquial Bengali means the husband's elder brother; but in Sanskrit it means shining, splendid. The Hindu women of Bengal consider it sacrilegious to name the elder brothers of their husbands. When he is to be mentioned, they refer to him by some qualifying adjective. The word ভাসুর, originally 'shining,' must have been thus reduced to its present restricted meaning. The words শ্রীযুক্ত and শ্রীমান (endowed with *Cri*—fortune) in Sanskrit have the same meaning, but in Bengali শ্রীযুক্ত is used in regard to elders or equals, and শ্রীমান্ invariably to junior relations. The word রৌদ্র in Sanskrit means 'fierce,' though there is a rare use of it in that tongue implying sun-

shine. In Bengali রৌদ্র is the commonest term to signify sun-shine, and except scholarly folk, no one knows that originally its meaning was fierce. The word মহোৎসব has been restricted in Bengali to imply that particular festivity of the Vaiṣṇavas in which cooked food is indiscriminately distributed amongst the poor, who assemble there without invitation. The word literally means a great festivity, and in Sanskrit it is always used in that sense. Similarly the word সঙ্কীর্ত্তন, which in Sanskrit means reciting or singing, has been restricted in Bengali to a particular kind of singing of God's name by a procession party of the Vaiṣṇavas.

Bengali sculptors.

We find frequent references to sculptural work done in Bengal on stone in which the artisans of Navadvipa excelled. Rājā Jaya Narayaṇa in his Kāçi Khanda says that many orders of stone images for the temples at Benares were executed by Nadiā artisans. In the Bhakti Ratnākara we find the name of one renowned sculptor to be Nayana Bhāskara, a resident of Hālisahar in Twenty-four Parganas.

III. Early Prose Literature.

Bengali, a mixed language.

A people who had lost their political supremacy, and had no voice in the administration of their own country,—who had retired to quiet village-life and pastoral occupations, and had scarcely any occasion to commune with the rest of the world,—what need had they for cultivating prose? Outside their quiet homes they came to towns only for trade or to transact litigation in courts, and had to deal with a heterogenous people who would not recognise pure Bengali as a medium of communication. In

their correspondence or documentary writings the Bengalis had to adopt a mixed language, into which not only Persian and Arabic but even Portuguese elements had entered in no inconsiderable degree; for these people were a great power in Bengal, more than two centuries and a half ago; and we read the following account of their language, having been adopted, for business purposes, by Europeans and Bengalis alike. We quote from Mr. Marshman's history of the Çri Rāmapur Mission Vol. I.* The writer refers to incidents occurring in 1759.

Portuguese elements.

"Portuguese came in with the Portuguese power two centuries and a half before, and survived its extinction. It was the Lingua Franca of all foreign settlements around the Bay of Bengal and was the ordinary medium of conversation between the Europeans and their domestics; while Persian was the language of intercourse with the native courts. Even in Calcutta Portuguese was more commonly used by the servants of the company and the settlers than the language of the country. The charter granted to the East India Company at the beginning of the 18th century contained a provision that they should maintain one Minister at each of their garrisons and superior factories, and that he should be bound to acquire the Portuguese language within a twelve-month of reaching India. Clive, who was never able to give an order in any native language, spoke Portuguese with fluency. The use of this language has since died out in

* pp. 21—22.

Bengal so completely that the descendants of the Portuguese now speak Bengali from their cradle. Yet down to so late a period as 1828, the Governor of Çri Rāmapur, a Norwegian, received the daily report of his little garrison of 30 sepoys from the Native Commandant, a native of Oudh in Portuguese."

A small number of words subjoined in the foot-note* are some of the remnants retained in Bengali of the great admixture of Portuguese which our language must have once borne in business and domestic colloquies.

The nature of the mixed language.

The prose, in which business transactions were conducted in Bengal, was thus a medley of many different languages, and it was to this point that Mr. Halhed one of the first Bengali grammarians refers with regret. In the very nature of things a pure Bengali prose could not grow up. The Maho-

*Bengali.	Portuguese.	Bengali.	Portuguese.
জোলাপ	.. Jalapa.	রেস্ত	.. Resto (fund)
টোকা	Toca (to note down).	সুরতি	.. Sorte.
		আনারস	. Ananaz.
নোনা	Annona (fruit).	আয়া	. Aya.
		আলকাৎরা	... Alcetrao.
পিপা	.. Pipa.	কপি (শাক)	.. Couvi.
পেরেক	. Prego	কাকাতুয়া	... Catatua.
ফর্ম্মা	. Forma	কিরীচ	. Cris.
ফিতা	. Fita	কেদারা	.. Cathedera.
বোয়া	. Boia.	গরাদে	. Grade.
বরগা	. Verga.	গির্জ্জা	.. Igrija.
বাল্‌তি	Baldi.	চাবি	. Chave.
বোতাম	... Botao	জানালা	. Janella.

medans did not recognise it in their courts, and the people had no power to assert their own tongue in the field of business. As long as Mahomedans held the supreme power, Arabic and Persian were recognised by all as the chief languages of the Court, and in the mixed dialects, which grew up, an admixture of these two languages was held to be a point of glory. Says Mr. Halhed in the preface to his grammar published in 1778 :—

"At present those persons are thought to speak the compound idiom (Bengali) with the most elegance, who mix with pure Indian verbs the greatest number of Persian and Arabic nouns."

What this prose was like may be seen from the documentary writings still prevalent in courts. The court language still favours a preponderence of Persian and Arabic elements in Bengali, as in 'টাল মাটালে আদায় না করায়' or in 'ওয়াদা কার্ত্তিক মাসে টাকা আদায় করিব.' Curiously enough remnants also of Sanskrit elements still persist in the language of the courts, reminding us of the ancient days of Hindu supremacy, when all court transactions were carried on in Sanskrit. The form 'কস্য কর্জ্জ পত্রমিদং কার্য্যঞ্চাগে' has preserved, though in a ridiculously corrupt style, some of the legal terms of the Hindu age. In ordinary letters written by the gentle folk of Bengal there was a large admixture of Persian words. Mr. Beveridge published some letters of the Mahārājā Nanda Kumāra in the National Magazine of September, 1872, written to Radhā Krishna Ray and Dinanatha Sāmantaji in August, 1756. We quote an extract from one of these letters.

"অতএব এ সময়ে তুমি কমর বাঁধিয়া আমার উদ্ধার করিতে পার, তবেই যে হউক, নচেৎ আমার নাম লোপ হইল, ইহা মকররর, মকররর জানিবে, নাগাদি ওরা ভাদ্র, তথাকার রোয়দাদ সমেত মজুমদারের লিখন সম্বলিত মনুষ্য কাসেদ এথা পৌঁছে তাহা করিবা, এবিষয়ে এক পত্র লক্ষ হইতে অধিক জানিবা।"

Causes leading to the development of modern prose.

I may add here, that the chief causes that have contributed to the development of Bengali prose in modern times are (1) the preference of Bengalis to live in conjested cities, (2) the establishment of Post offices all over the land, (3) the easy means of communication afforded by railways and steamers, helping the unification of different provincial dialects by eliminating provincialisms, (4) the great efforts of Missionaries and of Government, particularly in the earlier periods of British rule, to spread education amongst the masses.

The early Bengali prose-works.

But though circumstances did not favour the development of Bengali prose before the advent of the English on the field, and though Mr. Nathenie! Prassy Halhed could not lay his hand upon any prose-work in Bengali, as he tells us in his preface, such works, nevertheless, did exist in the country in his time, and long before it, though they did not possess that importance which would render them accessible to any casual enquiry. I shall here notice some of the books that have come down to us, as specimens of early Bengali prose.

The Çunya Purāṇa.

1. The Çunya Purāṇa is one of the earliest works in Bengali, upon which we have already written (page 30). It was composed in the 10th century and though it was recast in subsequent times, the few prose portions which it contains have

retained their antiquated form. The sentences are like short riddles and sound more like poetry than prose. Here is a specimen.

*"Who is the scholar in the western gate? Çvetāi with four hundred followers. Chandra, the Police Officer.....the messenger is not afraid of thee. Chitra Gupta keeps a register." The portion left out is unintelligible. There is a very considerable portion of prose-writing in the book in this style.

Deva Dāmara Tantra.

2. Along with this writing may be placed the specimen of prose which we have found in the Deva Dāmara Tantra, running as follows "গোসাই চেলা সহস্র কামিনী ডোমা, চাঁড়াল পাই মই আকাটন বিষ হাতে এ গুয়া পান খাইয়া." We avow our inability to translate or interpret this.

3. A small prose treatise ascribed to the poet Chandi Dās, who lived 500 years ago, has come down to us. It is called Chaitya Rupa Prāpti. The booklet seems to interpret in mystic language the incantations and riddles of the Tāntrikas. The Ms. copy in our possession was written in the year 1674. The preliminary sentence runs thus:—

Chaitya Rupa Prāpti

"চৈতন্যরূপের রা চ অধরূপ লাড়ি। রা অক্ষরে রাগ লাড়ি। চ অক্ষরে চেতন লাড়ি। র এতে চ মিশাল। ইবে এক অঙ্গা লাড়ি। রাগ রতি। লাড়ির নাম সুধা॥ সেই লাড়ি সাতইস প্রকার।"

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*"পচ্ছিম দুআরে কে পণ্ডিত। সেতাই যে চারিসঅ গতি আনি লেখ্যা॥ চন্দ্র কোটাল যে বসুয়া ঘটদাসী। দুত নাহি ডরাই তুহ্মাক দেখিআ। চিত্রগুপ্ত পাঁজি পরিমান কর এ দুত ক্ষমর বিদ্যমানে॥"

Çunya Purāna.

Prose works by Sahajiyās.

A host of writers of the Sahajiyā cult wrote short treatises in prose or introduced prose passages in their poetical works. We briefly notice them below.

1. Dvādaça Pāta Nirṅaya written early in the 16th century by Nilāchala Dās.

2. Āchraya Nirṅaya by Chaitanya Dās.

3. Rupa Gosvāmir Kārikā. Rupa Gosvāmi, who is said to have written this book, was born in 1489 A.D. He was a contemporary and follower of Chaitanya Deva. The Ms.-copy with us was written in 1675.

4. Rāgamayi Kaṅā by Kriṣṅa Dās Kavirāja who lived in the middle of the 16th century.

5. Ātma Tattva Jijnāsā.

6. Dāsyadāsatattva Bhāvartha. The copy with us was written in 1685 A.D.

7. Ālamvana Chanrikā by Kriṣṅa Dās Kavirāja. The Ms.-copy found was prepared in 1655 A.D. and the composition of the treatise must have been at least half a century earlier.

8. Upāsanā Tattva—the Ms. is dated 1755.

9. Siddhi Tattva—the Ms. is dated 1755.

10. Trigunātmikā Do.

11. Ātma Sādhanā.

12. Bhoga Patala.

13. Deha Bheda Tattva Nirupana.

14. Chandra Chintāmaṅi by Prema Dās.

15. Ātma Tattva Jijnasā Sārātsāra by Kriṣṅa Dās.

16. Sādhanā Traya.

17. Çikṣā Patala

18. Siddhānta Tikā by Damu Ghoṣe Gosvāmi.
19. Kriṣṇa Bhakti Parāyaṇa.
20. Upāsanā Nirṇaya.
21. Svarupa Varṇanā.
22. Rājamāla by Narottama Dās.
23. Deha Kaḍacha by Narottama Dās.
24. Champaka Kalikā. This book describes the incidents of the release of Sonātana Gosvāmi from prison.
25. Ātma Tattva.
26. Pānchānga Niguḍha Tattva.
27. Hari Nāmer Artha.
28. Goṣthi Kathā.
29. Siddhi Patala.
30. Jijnāsā Praṇāli.
31. Javā Manjuri.
32. Vraja Kārikā.
33. Rasa Bhajana Tattva copied in 1650.
34. Vrindāvana Parikramā copied early in the 18th century.
35. Vedādi Tattva Nirñaya.
36. Vrindāvana Lilā copied in the middle of the 18th century.

We have, besides, in prose a vast number of treatises on medicine and on the genealogies of old families written within the last three centuries.

Of the books, mentioned in the above list, Nos. 6, 7, 9, 10, 12, 14, 18, 25, 27, 28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 34, 35, 36 are written in prose and the rest are in prose and poetry combined. Genealogical works are numerous, and in many of them we find elaborate passages in prose. We quote below a

Genealogical works in prose.

specimen of prose from one such work on the Bārendra Brahmins of Bengal.

*" Ādi Sur was a powerful King. He brought to his capital five Brahmins of five different Gotras: —Nārāyaṅa of Çāndilya Gotra, Dharādhara of Bātsya Gotra, Susen of Kāçyapa Gotra, Gautama of Bharadvajā Gotra, and Parāçara of Savarṅa Gotra.

"The whole of Bengal was made pure by the holy influence of these Brahmins, and after the country had been thus improved, Ādi Sur, the King died."

One thing strikes us here. Prose was more often adopted by the Sahajiyā Vaiṣṅavas than by other sects for the exposition of their doctrines. Nos. 32, 34, and 35 show elaborate specimens of prose. The Sahajiyās who were, as we think, originally a Buddhist sect, imbibed this taste for writing in prose from a very early age, when the Buddhists used to elucidate their views in prose in the Prākrita language.

Logic and Law in prose.

We have come upon translations of Bhāṣa Parichchada—a work on Logic, and of Vyavasthā Tattva, a book on Hindu Law, copied in 1773 which show that prose was adopted at least two centuries ago, for dealing with highly metaphysical

* "আদিশূর রাজা বড় প্রতাপযুক্ত রাজা। আদিশূর রাজা পঞ্চগোত্রের পঞ্চ ব্রাহ্মণ আনয়ন করিলেন:—যথা নারায়ণশ্চ শাণ্ডিল্যঃ সুষেণঃ কশ্যপস্তথা. বাৎস্যো ধরাধরো দেবঃ ভরদ্বাজশ্চ গৌতমঃ সাবর্ণশ্চ পরাশরঃ—এই পঞ্চগোত্রে পঞ্চ ব্রাহ্মণ আনয়ন করা গৌড়মণ্ডল পবিত্র করা আদিশূর রাজার স্বর্গারোহণ।"

subjects. We quote a passage from the Bhāsa Parichchada.

Bhāsa parichchada.

*"The disciples of the sage Gautama approached him with these words. How, master, may our deliverance be obtained? Graciously enlighten us on this point: Gautama said—'deliverance may be obtained by a knowledge of the predicaments.' The disciples wanted to know what were these predicaments, and Gautama replied:—'Seven predicaments may be enumerated. *viz*:—(1) Substance, (2) quality, (3) action, (4) genus, (5) difference, (6) co-inherence, and (7) non-existence.'"

The language of the treatises in the list just given is invariably very simple, though owing to our ignorance of the special terms and technicalities used by the Sahajiyā Vaiṣṇavas, much of their writings is unintelligible to us. The sentences are generally short and rarely loaded with compounds. Here is a passage which may be taken as a specimen of the sort of style used by them. We quote from the *Karika* by Rupa Gosvāmi who lived 400 years ago, †"Victory be to Rādhā and Kriṣṇa! First of all a classification of subjects: proceeding

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*" গৌতম মুনিকে শিষ্য সকলে জিজ্ঞাসা করিলেন, আমাদিগের মুক্তি কি প্রকারে হয়? তাহা কৃপা করিয়া বলহ। তাহাতে গৌতম উত্তর করিতেছেন। তাবৎ পদার্থ জানিলেই মুক্তি হয়। তাহাতে শিষ্যেরা সকলে জিজ্ঞাসা করিলে. পদার্থ কতো? তাহাতে গৌতম কহিতেছেন। পদার্থ সপ্ত প্রকার। দ্রব্য. গুণ, কর্ম্ম. সামান্য. বিশেষ, সমবায়. অভাব। তাহার মধ্যে দ্রব্য নয় প্রকার।"

†" শ্রীশ্রীরাধাবিনোদ রায়। অথ বস্তু নির্ণয়। প্রথম শ্রীকৃষ্ণের গুণ নির্ণয়। শব্দগুণ. গন্ধগুণ. রূপগুণ. রসগুণ. স্পর্শগুণ. এহ

Kārikā.

with the enumeration of the qualities, we should note five points :—perception of sound, of smell, of colour, of taste and of touch. These belong to Rādhā and Krishna alike. The first perception belongs to the ear, the second to the nose, the third to the eyes, the fourth to the tongue and the fifth to the skin. These five perceptions create a desire for love."

Kāminī Kumāra.

In *Kamini Kumara*, a poem written in the middle of the 18th century, we find a passage written in simple prose, showing a contrast with the subtle and abstruse style of the learned men of the period. We quote the passage below.

*"When the merchant again and again swore in this manner, the lady smiled and addressed Sonā and said, "Well, my servant. This thief has thus foresworn himself several times, and has surrendered himself entirely to us. Suppliant for mercy as he is, he should not be further molested. In his present predicament, he deserves to be treated with indulgence because he is so helpless. This is what the sacred books enjoin. The number

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পাঁচ গুণ। এই পঞ্চ গুণ শ্রীমতী রাধিকাতেও বসে। শব্দগুণ কর্ণে, গন্ধগুণ নাসাতে, রূপগুণ নেত্রে, রসগুণ অধরে, ও স্পর্শগুণ অঙ্গে। এই পঞ্চ গুণে পূর্ব্ব রাগের উদয়।"

*"সদাগর অতিকাতরে এইরূপ পুনঃ পুনঃ শপথ করাতে সুন্দরী ঈষৎ হাস্য পূর্ব্বক সোণাকে সম্বোধন করিয়া কহিলেক। 'ওহে চোপদার এই চোর এতাদৃশ কটু দিব্য বারম্বার করিছে ও নিতান্ত শরণাগত হইয়া আশ্রয় যাচিঞ্চা করিতেছে, অতএব শরণাগতে নিগ্রহ করা উচিৎ নহে বরং নিরাশ্রয়ের আশ্রয় দেওয়া

of our servants besides is not sufficient; though he may not be trusted with any responsible work, what harm if he be appointed to prepare *silims* of tobacco for us? That would be a great service in the present state of things. Sonā said 'well said, my master; let him be kept as a servant.' Kāminī thus taking the sense of Sonā addressed him thus: "Well, thief, the highly criminal act that you have committed, deserves a severe punishment, but owing to your solicitations, humility and promises we excuse you this time. You must now become our constant attendant obeying our commands in all respects. Whatever we may be pleased to order, it will be your duty to execute promptly. If you play the truant, you will at once be brought before the king without mercy; on the other hand if you can please us by your obedience and prompt execution of our orders, we promise to

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বেদ বিধি সম্মত বটে। আর বিশেষত আমাদের অধিক ভৃত্য সঙ্গেতে নাই, অতএব অন্যকর্ম্ম উহা হইতে যত হউক, আর না হউক, কিন্তু এক আধ ছিলিম তামাক চাহিলেও ত সাজিয়া দিতে পারিবেক। তাহার আর তো কোন সন্দেহ নাই তবু যে অনেক উপকার। সোণা কহিলেন 'হাঁ থাকে থাক।' কামিনী এইরূপ সোণার সহিত পরামর্শ করিয়া সদাগরকে কহিতেছেন। "শুন চোর তুমি যে অকর্ম্ম করিয়াছ তাহার উপযুক্ত ফল তোমাকে দেওয়া উচিত, কিন্তু তোমার নিতান্ত নূন্যতা ও বিনয়ে কাকুতি মিনতি এবং কঠিন শপথে এ যাত্রা ক্ষমা করিলাম। এক্ষণে আমার সর্ব্বদা আজ্ঞাকারী হইয়া থাকিতে হইবেক, আমি যখন যাহা কহিব তৎক্ষণাৎ সেই কর্ম্ম করিবে, তাহাতে অন্যথা করিলে তদ্দণ্ডে রাজার নিকট প্রেরণ করিব, তাহার আর কথা নাই। কিন্তু

consider your case favourably in future. When the merchant heard this he thought, "By Rāma, it is a great relief, I am out of danger now." He folded his hands, and said to Kāminī, 'Sir, the great relief you have given to your most humble servant by granting him pardon is a proof that in a past life you were one of his kith and kin, or else how can this act of favour at the hands of a stranger be explained? Now, by God, I say you are my God-father, I accept you as my master. Whatever order you may graciously be pleased to make, it will be my duty as a humble servant to execute to the best of my powers, and if required even with my life.' Kāminī said, 'What work will you do here? There is not much to be done. I would simply put you in charge of my *huka* for the present; one word more, how long shall I address

যদি কর্ম্মের দ্বারায় আমাকে সন্তোষ করিতে পারহ, তবে তোমার পক্ষে শেষ বিবেচনা করা যাইবেক।" সদাগর এই কথা শুনিয়া মনে মনে বিবেচনা করিলেক, যে রাম বাঁচা গেল, আর ভয় নাই পরে কৃতাঞ্জলি পূর্ব্বক কামিনীর সম্মুখে কহিতেছে, "মহাশয় যে ঘোর দায় হইতে এ দাসের প্রাণ রক্ষা করিলেন ইহাতেই বোধ হয় আপনি জন্মান্তরে এ দীনের কেহ ছিলেন তাহার কোন সন্দেহ নাই, নতুবা এমত উপকার পর পরের যে তো কখন করে না। সে যাহা হউক আজি হইতে কর্ত্তা তুমি আমার ধরম বাপ হইলে, যখন যে আজ্ঞা করিবেন এই ভৃত্য কৃতসাধ্য প্রাণপণে পালন করিব। কামিনী কহিলেক, ওহে চোর তুমি আমার আর কি কর্ম্ম করিবেক, কেবল হুকার কর্ম্মে সর্ব্বদা নিযুক্ত থাকহ, আর এক কথা তোমাকে চোর চোর বলিয়া সর্ব্বদা বা কাঁহাতক ডাকি, আজি হইতে আমি তোমার নাম রামবল্লভ

you as a thief, I give you a name; I shall henceforth call you Rāma Vallabha.' The merchant said 'So be it sir.' After such conversation Kāminī said, 'Now my Rāma Vallabha, do kindly prepare a *silim* of tobacco for me.' Rāma Vallabha immediately prepared a *silim* and bringing the *huka* held the pipe before Kāminī. Rāma Vallabha being appointed to the work soon became an expert in the art, and it became the subject of his constant thought, so much so that if Kāminī called him while dining or while asleep, saying 'Where have you gone, my Rāma Vallabha?' He would immediately answer, 'Sir, I am preparing tobacco.'''

For conveying the humour of the passage an introduction to the story is necessary. The young merchant Kumāra, the husband of Kāminī, went to a distant country for trade immediately after his marriage. There he fell in love with a young princess and was admitted into the Rājā's harem in the guise of a maid servant. There he stayed for a fairly long time, till his wife Kāminī became anxious about his safety, and started in the

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রাখিলাম। সদাগর কহিলেক 'যে আজ্ঞা মহাশয়।' এইরূপ কথোপকথনান্তে ক্ষণেক বিলম্বে কামিনী কহিলেক 'ওহে রাম বল্লভ একবার তামাক সাজ দেখি।' রামবল্লভ 'যে আজ্ঞে' বলিয়া তৎক্ষণাৎ তামাক সাজিয়া আলবোলা আনিয়া ধরিয়া দিলেক। এই প্রকার রামবল্লভ তামাক সাজা কর্ম্মে নিযুক্ত হইলে পরে, ক্রমে ক্রমে তামাক সাজিতে সাজিতে রামবল্লভের তামাক সাজায় এমত অভ্যাস হইল যে রামবল্লভ যদ্যপি ভোজনে কিম্বা শয়নে আছেন ও সেই সময়ে যদি কামিনী বলে—'ওহে রামবল্লভ কোথায় গেলে হে'—রামবল্লভের উত্তর 'আজ্ঞে তামাক সাজিতেছি॥'

guise of a prince with her maid, Sonā, who was also dressed as a young man. After a weary search—they traced out Kumāra, and learning all about him went to the palace of the Rājā, whose daughter had kept him in her vicinity as a lover. Kāminī, who was a very beautiful woman, played her part as the young prince so well, that the Rājā offered his daughter in marriage to her. After the marriage was over, she at once detected the guilty man, her own husband, and brought the matter to the notice of the Rājā, playing her mock-anger with admirable tact. The Rājā in great consternation offered the thief to his false son-in-law saying that he might inflict any punishment on him that he liked,—at the same time he begged him to pardon his daughter. Kāminī, on the pretext of going away for a short time on business, marched homewards with her husband who thought her to be the prince and had not recognised her as his loyal and loving wife. This passage describes what took place after she had taken the thief into custody. She gave him the name of Rāma Vallabha, because it was held sacrilegeous in those days for a Hindu wife to utter the name of her husband.

Before we close the account of our early prose, we should note some points about it. Though the above passage is connected with the incidents of an illicit love, which forms the subject matter of the poem Kāminī Kumāra, the author of which belongs to the depraved school of Bhārata Chandra, yet the rest of our early prose which we have noticed, shows that it was mainly employed for the purpose of metaphysical and religious writings.

The translation of the Sanskrit work on Logic called the Bhāṣā Parichchada, in simple Bengali, was indeed a bold attempt, for even in the present advanced development of our prose literature, the subject is considered to be too intricate for Bengali, especially as it would be most difficult to translate the technical words of Sanskrit Logic. The same may be said of the various translations of the Hindu Law-books compiled in prose two centuries ago. We find mention in a poem named Kirtī Latā by Rājā Prithvi Chandra of Pākur, of an author named Rādhā Vallabha Çarmā who translated most of the Hindu Law-books before the battle of Plassey. All this shows that though prose-writing was not much in favour with the authors of past ages in Bengal, yet on account of the high development which our language had already attained through its vast poetical literature, there would be no difficulty experienced by any author in attempting translation into Bengali prose the most abstruse and metaphysical of Sanskrit works. This fact also explains why our prose has developed so wonderfully within the last half century. The literary language was already in a highly prepared state, so it needed no great effort to bring our prose to a considerable degree of perfection within a comparatively short time.

The development of poetical literature helping the cause of prose.

In early times prose was classified in Bengali as a sort of metre. With what justification they called it so is not known; but prose passages are generally found introduced by the word গদ্য ছন্দ. In a poem in praise of Chandi Dās by the poet Vaiṣṇava Dās we find the line—"যাকর নিরমল গদ্য পদ্যময় গীত" which indicates that prose pass-

'The prose metre.'

ages also along with poetic used to be sung or chanted. This is substantiated by the fact that the genealogical accounts of the noble families of the Hindu community in Bengal used to be chanted by Kulāchāryyas, though a considerable portion of them was written in prose. The Kathakatās even in our own day show unmistakably how prose passages may be used for the purposes of vocal music. Most probably it was owing to this adaptability of prose to the purposes of song, as found in Bengali, that they called it গদ্য ছন্দ—the prose metre. The authors of early prose in many cases used to include their *bhanita* or signature in the same form in which they did so in their poetical compositions. The last lines of the passage from Kāminī Kumāra quoted above run as follows :—

**Kali Krisna Das* (author of the poem Kāminī Kumāra) *says* that Rāma Vallabha in course of time became so clever and practised a hand at the art of preparing tobacco, that he would not wait till his full name was pronounced. As soon as 'Rāma' came out of Kāminī's lips, Rāma Vallabha was ready with his tobacco."

When a whole paragraph was finished the sign of punctuation was ॥ ; but after the completion of the sentence, the sign generally used was ।.

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*"কালীকৃষ্ণ দাস বলে, পশ্চাৎ রামবল্লভের এমনি কর্ত্ত হইল যে, কামিনীকে আর পষ্ট রামবল্লভ বলিতে হয় না, 'রাম' বলিবা মাত্রেই রামবল্লভ তামাক সাজাইয়া মজুত।"

CHAPTER VII.

THE MODERN AGE.

I. (a) The epoch ushered in by European workers—civilians and missionaries.

(b) Dr. Carey and his colleagues.

(c) Bengali works written by Europeans.

(d) A new ideal in the country.

II. (a) The College of Fort William.

(b) The Pundits of the College—Mrityunjaya—Rāma Rāma Vasu—Chandi Charan Munsi—and Rājiva Lochana—Their Bengali works.

(c) The Rev. K. M. Banerjee and other authors who followed in the wake of European writers—a list of their publications.

III. General remarks chiefly indicating the characteristics of the new age and its contrast with the earlier one.

IV. (a) Decadance of the high spiritual ideal in Hindu society and the advent of Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy.

(b) A comprehensive review of his life and work.

(c) The writers that followed Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy — Devendra Nātha Tagore — Akṣaya Kumāra Dutta and others.

I. (a) The new epoch ushered in by European workers,—civilians and missionaries.

Whatever remnants of prose we may be able to unearth from old records and manuscripts in order to vindicate the glory of our past literature, it must, for the sake of truth, be admitted that they were too insignificant to deserve prominent mention in a history of literature. Disconnected from the story of the later development of prose, that has grown up like a rich harvest during the British rule, they would scarcely deserve more than a passing notice.

Early prose—of a minor importance.

Bengalis hitherto content with village-life.

I have said more than once in the foregoing chapters that the heart of Bengal lay in her villages,—contented as these were with their never-ceasing fountain of domestic and spiritual happiness. Our people did not hitherto care for the world outside the pale of their homes. They worked and sang, prayed, fasted and had visions of God. They heard the bird Kokil coo from the mango boughs in spring, and saw their favourite flower, the lotus, bloom in their tanks in autumn: and blithely did they sing about all these, and about the sweets of home life. They were content with loving their kith and kin, their mothers, wives and children, and thought that God revealed Himself to them in domestic tenderness. They pursued the nicities of Logic or indulged in abstruse metaphysical contemplations, and disciplined their mind that they might take a quiet and ungrudging view of the ills of life and encounter nobly the supreme penalty of nature when in due course it would come upon them.

But this village life underwent a sudden disturbance. Political changes were of little importance to the people. They heard from gossips that the *Badsah*, who ruled from the throne of Murshidábád, had been ousted by the English, and that a great battle had been fought at Plassey, but this did not seem at all any important news to them. Now, however, for the first time in history, a set of people came with the distinct object of improving them spiritually and morally. The Mussalmans had not done so,—not even the great Akbar in his dream of a political empire. The Portuguese, the Burmese and the Maharattas had all overrun the country

during successive ages. They came to loot or judge criminals—restore rights or seize them; that was in the eyes of the Hindus the true function of their foreign sovereigns. The Mussalmāns had come with the Korān, but often with a dagger also, as an alternative for the acceptance of their faith; those that failed to be convinced were sometimes forcibly served with beef and made converts.

A call from outside.

But here came a people who showed real anxiety to ameliorate the condition of the people. Bent on high motives of philanthropy and love, they did not apply force but used gentle persuasion. Besides they showed a great anxiety to give to our countrymen the sort of education which they had not yet had, notwithstanding their higher flights in theology and metaphysics. A class of philanthropic men, whose mission was the propaganda of the great love of their master, Jesus Christ,—the missionaries in the earlier stages of British rule did for our country and her literature what we can not too highly eulogise. They approached with love and so touched the heart of the people. Dr. Carey called us semi-barbarians in a letter to a friend, but he had no contempt for the people; it was a *bonâ fide* statement which we may very well excuse, when we know that he was truly inspired with the spirit of Christian love for his fellowmen and did not mean to abuse. This love touched the heart of the Bengalis. In fact the ardour, with which the missionaries and even some members of the Civil Service commenced their self-imposed task of educating the masses and ameliorating their condition, elicits our unqualified respect and admiration. The first Bengali types in the country were those em-

Halhed's Grammar.

ployed in printing a Bengali grammar by Mr. Nathenial Prassy Halhed who was a Civilian and oriental scholar and "was so well acquainted with the language as sometimes to pass in disguise as a Native."* The grammar was printed in 1778 A.D. in a press at Hugli. The punches of the fount were prepared by Mr. Wilkins who rose to great distinction as an oriental scholar, and published a translation of the Gitā which was the first Sanskrit work made accessible to the scholars of Europe by translation. Mr. Wilkins, who was afterwards decorated with knighthood, belonged to the Service of the East India Company, and in his researches in the field of Sanskrit lore was a recepient of the distinguished patronage of Warren Hastings. Wilkins made it the mission of his life to improve the condition of the masses of Bengal by giving them a general education for which printing was essentially necessary. In his zeal to do so, he acquired the art of punch-cutting and prepared a set of Bengali punches with his own hands, after he had been seven years in this country, and in this stage he also trained another hand to do the same work. Panchānana Karmakāra and his relation and assistant Manohara Karmakāra belonging to the caste of blacksmiths, were instructed in the art of punch-cutting by Mr. Wilkins; and the worry and trouble attending the enterprise for years would have been considered not worth undergoing, had not Mr. Wilkins proceeded with a true Christian spirit of patient philanthrophy. In fact the amelioration of the condition of

Punches by Wilkins.

* A descriptive catalogue of Bengali works by J. Lang, p. 20

the people, amongst whom he was called upon to work, had become the all-absorbing matter of his thought. Through the labours of Panchānana Karmakāra and his relative and colleague Manohara the art of punch-cutting became domesticated in India. We do not, however, mean to say that the art of printing in a crude form was not known in Bengal before Charles Wilkins came to the field. We have come across a Ms. nearly 200 years old which was printed from engraved wooden blocks. But the art was not in general use; a stray endeavour for decorative purposes does not prognosticate a system or a regular cultivation of the art, so we may rightly pass over it.

Panchānana and Manohara.

Crude printing known, 200 years ago.

The next notice that we have of printing in Bengali is that of the printed Code of Regulations drawn up by Sir Elija Impey on which all subsequent legislation has been based. The regulations were translated by Mr. Jonathan Duncan, afterwards Governor of Bombay, and were printed at the 'Company's Press' in 1785. The great Cornwallis Code of 1793, translated into Bengali by Mr. Forster, who was in his time the most distinguished European scholar of Bengali, was printed at the same press but from an improved fount, which continued to be the standard of Bengal types, till a neater and a smaller fount was prepared by Dr. Carey.

Early printing.

Next to Sir Charles Wilkins, Natheniel Prassey Halhed and Graves Chamney Haughton came a host of European scholars in Bengali and other oriental languages, many of whom belonged to the Çri Rāmapur Mission, but none of them was so

Dr. Carey.

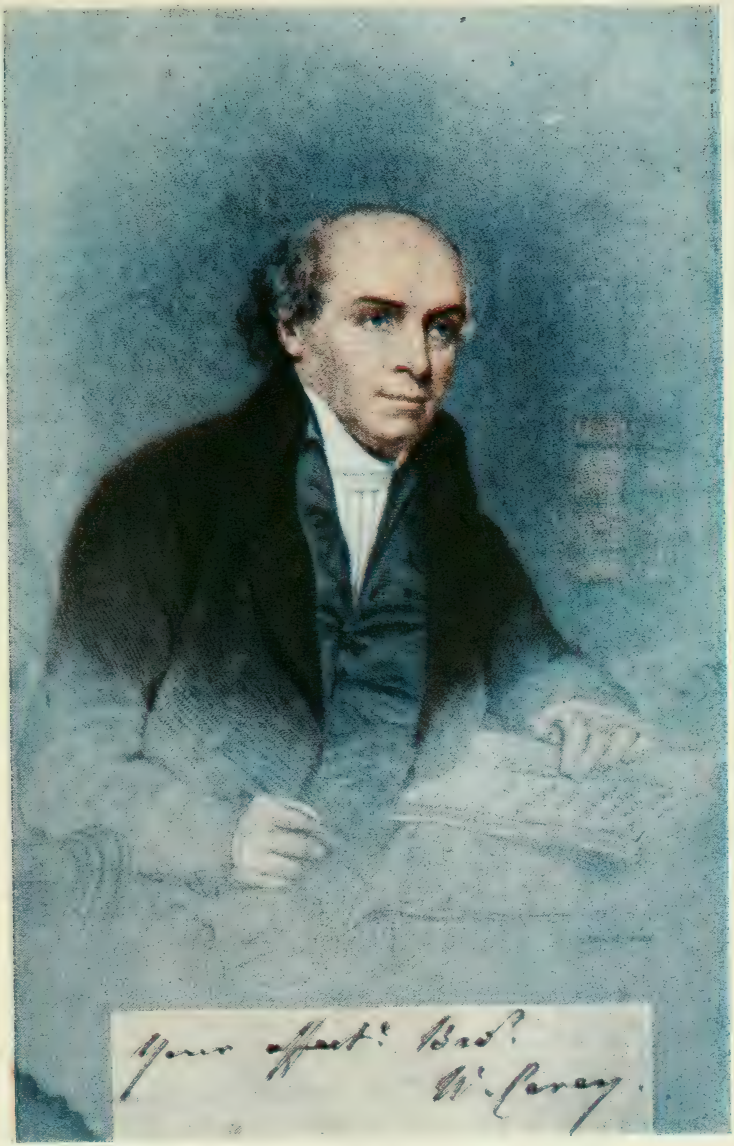
conspicuous in his efforts to improve the resources of Bengali prose or help the circulation of Bengali printing as was Dr. Carey

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b) Dr. Carey and his colleagues.

He had started in life as a cobbler. When, however, by his great diligence, piety, scholarship and strength of character he had raised himself to a position of eminence as missionary, he was dining one summar day in 1786 with the Governor General, the Marquis of Hastings, at Barrackpur Park, opposite Çri Rāmapur and, "overheard one of the guests, a general officer, making enquiry of one of the Aides-de-Camp, whether Dr. Carey had not been a shoemaker, on which he stepped forward and exclaimed, 'No Sir, only a cobbler!" "Carey might be seen" writes John Clark Marshman "walking eight or ten miles to Northampton with his wallet full of shoes upon his shoulders and then returning home with a fresh supply of leather to fulfil his engagements with a Government contractor."

This man came subsequently as a missionary to Bengal and felt a true Christian love for the people around him who appeared to him to be sunk in superstition, vice and idolatory. He learnt Sanskrit, Bengali, Persian and Maharatti, not with a view to know the people or profit by the wisdom contained in oriental books, but with the object of bringing a large mass of humanity, whom he sincerely believed to be grovelling in darkness, to light. We may regret that Dr. Carey failed to observe the religious life in Bengal which,


Your affect. Bro.
W. Carey.

inspite of superstitions, was permeated with a noble purpose and a spirit of true devotional fervour. But we can by no means ignore or underestimate the great pains and the indefatigable industry that mark his endeavours to improve the lives of the Bengalis by spreading education and by disseminating the truths of the Gospel among them. To him we pre-eminently owe the rapid development of Bengali prose before Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy took up the work right earnestly.

The difficulties in the way of Dr. Carey were many and great. It was his greatest ambition in life to publish a translation of the Gospel in Bengali. When after years of hard and unremitted labour, he had brought the translation of the New Testament almost to completion, he estimated the cost of printing at Calcutta of 10,000 of copies at Rs. 43750. This was quite beyond his means, and he thought of getting the book printed in England. At first he proposed to obtain punches from Caslon, the eminent letter-founder in London, calculating that the cost of each punch would be 5 *s.* only; but he was wrong; the cost of the punches was a guinea a piece. So he gave up the idea of getting the book printed in England, though before doing so he had made another attempt to engage the services of a letter-founder whom he knew at Derby. In 1798 he read an advertisement that a letter-foundry was established for the 'country language' at Calcutta. Dr. Carey lost no time in corresponding with the projector of the scheme, and found that the punches of the foundry were cut by Panchānana, who had been trained by Sir Charles

His efforts to print the Bible.

Wilkins. Soon after a printing press constructed of wood was advertised for sale and Dr. Carey immediately purchased it for £40. Panchānana was once more found out and his services engaged by the the Çri Rāmapur Mission. Here Panchānana completed a fount of 700 separate punches for Devanagri letters and their compounds. Panchānana was now an old man, so his worthy colleague Manohara, already mentioned, was called in to assist him and "was subsequently employed for forty years at the Çri Rāmapur press and to his exertions and instruction, Bengal is indebted for the various beautiful founts of the Bengali, Nāgri, Persian, Arabic and other characters which have been gradually introduced into the different printing establishments."*

All this was due to the indefatigable industry of Dr. Carey and his colleagues. They were determined to publish the Bible in Bengali, and this Carey was ultimately able to do. Imagine his great delight when on the 18th of March, 1803, Mr. Ward set the first types with his own hands and presented him with the first sheet of the Testament. We find the following account of him in the notice of his career published by the British and Foreign Bible Society at his death in 1834. "The extent of his zeal may be judged by the fact that, in conjunction with his colleagues, he has been instrumental in giving to the tribes of Asia the sacred scriptures in whole or in part in between 30 and 40 different languages." He acquired Bengali with a thoroughness which we scarcely find in any other

He acquires Bengali.

* History of Çri Rāmapur Mission Vol. I., p. 179.

foreigner who has studied our language. He had employed Pundits to help him to acquire knowledge of Bengali, and when they declared that he was fit to address the people he commenced preaching : and in 1794 we find him devoted to this task in the jungly tracts of Sundarvans. He writes on the 16th January, 1798, "I spoke in Bengali for nearly half an hour without an intermission." "But" says he later on "I recollect that after I had preached or rather thought that I had, for two years (in Bengali), a man one day came to me and declared that he could not understand me, and this long after my flattering teachers had declared that every one could understand me. I feel the impression which that poor man's remark made on me to this day."*

But we presume that it was his peculiarity of accent in pronouncing the letters ত, ব etc. which must have made his speech in some cases unintelligible to people. Reading his Bengali works on various subjects, one is struck with his wonderful command over the idioms and colloquial forms of our dialect so difficult for a foreigner to acquire. Dr. Carey was not, however, the man to be daunted by failures. He composed a short and simple marriage service in Bengali for meeting the growing demand of such formulæ, as there was already a good number of native Christians, whose marriage ceremonies were to be celebrated according to the new rites for which there was yet no guide in the vernacular. He besides composed songs in Bengali and we find one of his friends writing about himself and Dr.

* Memoir of Dr Carey by Eustace Carey.—p. 503.

Carey "This morning brother Carey and I took our stand like two ballad-singers and began singing in Bengali before one of Çiva's temples."* Of course now-a-days a European Missionary singing a Bengali song is no strange spectacle in this country; but Carey was the pioneer in all such matters and he was inspired by a real zeal to bring the people who, according to his notions, erred in religion, to the creed which he considered to be the only true one; and Hindus have always judged of a people by the sincerety of their faith and not by the loftiness of their doctrines, of which their own Çāstras furnish sufficiently great and noble examples. Before these sincere souls took up the task of propagating their religious faith "there had been no indication that the conquerers of Bengal possessed any religion at all, excepting the hoisting of the flag on Sundays and the official attendance of the few at the Sunday morning service" and it was the earnest endeavour of Carey, Marshman, Martyn and their colleagues to remove this impression. They spared no pains to bring the lost sheep to the fold. In the Sundervans Dr. Carey lost a son, but he could induce no person, not even a Mahomedan, to make a coffin, and the distress, to which he and his wife were put, can hardly be adequately described. All this he underwent with a patient and even a glad heart, because though the people opposed him, he wanted to do good to them —to return good for evil, as the great master had enjoined upon all true followers of his creed. This great love attracted the people and all difficulties, all problems —however insur-

The result of self-sacrifice.

* Memoir p. 129.

mountable or intricate—are overcome by love. The best men of the land during the first epoch of the British rule were drawn to Christanity by the noble examples of philanthropic love displayed by the Christian missionaries. They were not attracted by the inherent qualities of Christanity so much as by the examples of suffering for love before them. It was owing to these traits of disinterestedness in the life of early missionaries that men like the Rev. K. M. Banerjee, the Rev. Lāl Behari De, Michael Madhu Sudana Datta, Govinda Chandra Datta and last though not the least of this glorious band, Dr. K. C. Banerjee had embraced Christanity. For nearly a century the enlightened Hindus were dazzled by the glare of western civilisation; and showed no inclination to admit that anything could have been noble or great in the past of their own nation. The great personality of Chaitanya Deva and his heavenly love, the poems of Chandi Dās and the lays of other Vaiṣṅva poets, the songs of Rāma Prasāda, the vivid and noble portraitures of domestic life found in Kavi Kaṅkana's poems and the exquisite touches and elegance of Bhārat Chahdra's style could now command no attention from the educated young men of Bengal; in fact, Bengal with her wealth of noble ideas lay far off, though so near, and Europe, removed from us by land and sea became nearer and dearer to the new generation of the Hindus who came in touch with the missionaries. In the domestic circle the parents became anxious for children who under the spell of missionary influeuce failed even to admire the patient and self-sacrificing love for religion which had marked the Hindu women of the past, and revolted

Young men of Bengal anglicised.

against all that was old and had been sacred in popular estimation. The gods had now become to them mere earthen clay, the temples were unholy and the hallowed precincts of their homes a hole of superstition. Their noble literature was no more than a miserable scribbling and shreds of paper which they should consign to the fire or to worms. The songs of Rādhā and Krishna which, were expressed in the highest language of poetry, and were hitherto a fountain of joy and inspiration to the rich and the poor alike, now became horrible to them; and one of our greatest countrymen of that age was known to declare that Krishna, the supreme soul, was worse than a sweeper. The Hindu shrines had once been desecrated by Mahomedans who had thrown beef and other unholy things into them to destroy their sanctity; but they had only half succeeded, for thousands of hearts had remained true to them. But now our own people, the educated classes, lost faith in the temples, and looked upon them as pandemoniums and the gods enshrined in them as Beelzebubs and Molochs, whether they believed in Christanity or not. The victory of the missionaries was complete. The secret of their success, I beg to repeat, lay in the circumstance of their approaching us with love. They had shown a system of organised philanthrophy hitherto unknown to the country. Their charity, devotion, zeal and sympathy had drawn away those who were the natural ornaments of our society, and poor Bengal may consider this love to have been the greatest of her disasters, since more than the sword it upset time-honoured hoary institutions and alienated true hearts.

True love never spends itself in a single channel. Dr. Carey and his colleagues did not consider their work done by merely propagating the truths of Christianity. They wanted sincerely to give our countrymen education, according to their own standards, in all departments of knowledge; and the wonderful activity displayed by them in their labour of love draws forth our greatest admiration, when we consider that the Government of the East India Company, afraid of disturbing the conservative views of our people in the earlier stages, did not assist but often obstructed them. There is not a subject in which these Europeans did not come forward to write books in Bengali in order to spread education amongst the masses.

Dr. Carey's Bengali works.

Dr. Carey wrote the following books in Bengali besides numerous treatises on Christianity and the translation of the Bible.

1. A Dictionary of the Bengali language in three volumes, quarto size, containing 80,000 words —the work of thirty years. The original price was Rs. 120. This book came out in 1815—25.

2. A Bengali Grammar published in 1801. It had passed through four editions before 1855.

3. Kathopakathana or Colloquies, published in August, 1801.

4. Itihāsamālā, or garland of stories, published in 1812. It contains 150 short stories at that time current in Bengal.

The last two books form a rich mine of idioms of the spoken dialect of Bengal, from which Tek

Chand Thākur took the cue for his style in the composition of his masterpiece in Bengali—the Ālāler Gharer Dulāla. Dr. Carey writes in the preface to his Kathopakathana: "That the work might be as complete as possible, I have employed some sensible natives to compose dialogues upon subjects of domestic nature and to give them precisely in the natural style of the persons supposed to be speakers." So he did not write the whole of the book himself, but the dialogues, other than those written on domestic subjects, are his composition, and they do him a great credit. He had a high regard for Bengali as a language. He says of it in the aforesaid preface, "This language... current through an extent of country nearly equal to Great Britain.....when properly cultivated, will be inferior to none in elegance and perspicuity." He wanted not only to educate and elevate the masses of Bengal, but also to develop, as best he could, the resources of a language for which he had a great respect. The style of his colloquies inspired many of our countrymen to write in the current dialect, and not only do we find it imitated in a pre-eminent degree in Ālāler Gharer Dulāla and Hutum Pechār Naksā, but even in the style of a Bankima Chandra and Dina Vandu Mitra. I quote a passage from his colloquies. Dr. Carey appended an English translation which I adopt with some modifications.

Specimens of colloquial style.

*"Yesterday at 12 o'clock my youngest wife had cooked the dinner, and my children had first eaten

*"কাল দুপর বেলা ছোট বৌ রাঁধিতেছিল, ইহার মধ্যে

their rice. At that moment the middle woman came in and set up a quarrel."

"None of the women of your house can bear to see any good happening to another."

"What can I say? There is no place where I can go and stay for 4 or 5 days, and allow the breeze to blow on my face (enjoy peace)."

"Why don't you go to your brother's house and stay there for a few days?"

"What, go to their house! If I were to go to their house, do you think I should be preserved from these abusive women? There is not one of them who can bear to hear of my brothers. My husband scarcely stays at home at all, on account of their quarrels. When he does come, he himself abuses and scolds."

"Formerly you lived on such good terms. Strange, you are always differing now."

আমার ছ্যালা আগে ভাত খাইয়াছিল, ইহার মধ্যে মায্যা মাগী আসিয়া দ্বন্দ্ব আরম্ভ করিল।"

"তোরগো বাড়ীর ম্যায়াগুলা কেহ কাক ভাল দেখিতে পারে না।"

*"কি করিব, এমন ঠাঁই নাই যে সেখানে গিয়া থাকিলে দশ পাঁচ দিন গায় বাতাস লাগে।"

"কেন? তোর ভাইদের বাড়ী দিন কতক যা না কেন?

"তাদের বাড়ী যাব কি? তাহা হইলে কি ভাইখাগীদের কাছে রক্ষা আছে? আমাদের ভাইদের নাম শুনতে পারে না কেউ। কর্ত্তা যিনি তিনি দ্বন্দ্ব ডাকাডাকির জন্য বাড়ী প্রায় থাকেন না। যখন আইসেন তখন গালাগালি তিরস্কার করেন।"

"If I could only give my daughters in marriage, I would take seven mustard seeds and bathe (an idiom in Bengali signifying great relief of mind). I would offer betel to Kulai Chandi and send *puja* to Suvachani."

"Where do you think of marrying your girls? In the country or outside it?"

"I cannot say what God intends. I think it would be well to marry them near home."

"What do all the brothers' wives say? What say the uncles and aunts? What all agree upon is proper."

"As it happens I will go home; if the evening comes I shall be scolded."

"তোদের সংসারে এমন ঐক্য ছিল, এখন এমন অনৈক্য হইয়াছে।"

"ম্যায়া দুটার বিয়া দিতে পারিলে আমি সাতটা শরিষা দিয়া স্নান করি, কুলাই চণ্ডীর বাড়ী গুয়া পান দিই, সুবচনী পূজা করি, মনস্কামনা সিদ্ধ করিলে হয়।"

ম্যায়ার বিবাহ কোথায় ঠাওর হইয়াছে? দেশের মধ্যে না বিদেশে দিবা?

"ঈশ্বরের মনে কি আছে বুঝতে পারি না; আমার ইচ্ছা দেশের মধ্যে হইলেই ভাল হয়।"

"তোমার যারা সকলে কি বলে? ম্যায়ার মামা, মামী কি বলে? পাঁচটার যে মত সেই কর্ত্তব্য।"

"সে যেই হউক, আমি বাড়ী যাই, বেলা গেলে এখনই গালাগালি দিবে।"

The colloquy under the head "Quarrels of Women" beginning with "Where have you been, gossip? Is none of the business of the evening in your mind?" presents to us a disagreeable scene, which, assuming that some pundit wrote it for Dr. Carey, though he himself appends an English translation, should not, for the sake of decency, have found a place in a missionary's book. We find slang of a most revolting type used freely in that dialogue, and we wonder how Dr. Carey could have published it in his own name. This goes to show that even a European missionary of such spotless reputation as Dr. Carey's was, could not escape from that corrupt taste of the age which marks the writing of Içvara Gupta and Gauri Çankar Bhattāchāryya.

We quote below two more extracts from Dr. Carey's Bengali writings, which will illustrate his great command over the language. I take both of them from his Itihāsamālā or Garland of Stories.

The story of a thief.

1. *"Once upon a time a thief was running away with the articles stolen from a house, and was passing by the fields adjoining the village. A ploughman, who happened to see him, said, 'Would you mind returning those things to the rightful owner? If you do not, I shall have you punished in the court of the king.' The thief replied, 'Mind your

*"এক চোর কোন গৃহস্থের কতকগুলি দ্রব্য চুরি করিয়া গ্রামোপান্তে যাইতেছিল; সেই সময়ে এক কৃষক তাহাকে দেখিয়া কহিল, 'তুই যে লোকের দ্রব্যাদি লইয়া যাইতেছিস্ তাহাকে ফিরিয়া দে, নতুবা রাজ নিকটে দণ্ড হইবে।' চোর উত্তর

own business, fool. If you show any undue enthusiasm in this matter I shall make you suffer capital punishment at the hands of the king.' The ploughman, who was naturally very angry at the audacity of the thief, caught hold of him with the stolen articles and brought him before the king to whom he related the whole story. When the king asked the thief what he had to say in reply, he answered, 'Great king. I saw that this man was sitting with these articles in a jungle: I told him that he looked like a thief and threatened to bring him before your majesty, if he would not return the articles to the owner. But the man abused me for saying so. Be pleased to judge this thief as he deserves.' The king asked if there was any eye-witness to substantiate the statement of either; but both of them declared that there was none. The king ordered his officers to take away both of them, and, after tightly binding each to a corpse, to burn them at separate places. He desired, moreover, that his order should be quickly executed.

করিল, তুই আপনার কর্ম্ম কর, অতিরিক্ত কহিলে রাজার অগ্রে তোর প্রাণদণ্ড হইবে।' কৃষক ইহা শুনিয়া ক্রুদ্ধ হইয়া দ্রব্যের সহিত চোরকে ধরিয়া রাজার সমীপে সমস্ত গিয়া নিবেদন করিল। অনন্তর নৃপতি চোরকে আসিয়া জিজ্ঞাসা করিলে, সে উত্তর করিল, 'হে মহারাজ আমি দেখিলাম যে এই লোকে ঐ সকল দ্রব্য লইয়া বন মধ্যে বসিয়া রহিয়াছে। তাহাতে আমি কহিলাম যে তুমি চোর হইবা। যাহার দ্রব্য আনিয়াছ তাহাকে দিয়া আইস, নতুবা তোমাকে মহারাজের নিকট লইয়া যাইব তাহাতে ইনি আমাকে কটুবাক্য কহিলে, আমি ইহাকে এখানে ধরিয়া আনিলাম। ইহার বিচার করিতে আজ্ঞা হউক।'

After publicly passing this sentence, he brought the officers into his private chamber, and instructed them to keep a secret watch upon these men after they had been bound to the corpses as directed. They were instructed to listen to the conversation of the two and report it to him at once. The officers accordingly took the two men to the river side, where they bound them to two different corpses; and on the pretext of going away to bring fuel for burning them, hid themselves close by, so that they could overhear without being seen. The two men thinking they were left to themselves, now felt sure that death was inevitable, upon which the ploughman said to the thief, 'Well, thief, you are a remarkably clever fellow, you have succeeded in bringing death and ruin upon me though I am innocent.' The thief said in reply, 'I begged you not to adopt the course you took, saying that if you quarrelled with me your life would pay the forfeit. For my part, I am a thief, and death is just the punishment that I deserve. But you are going to lose your life

তদনন্তর রাজা কহিলেন, 'উহার কেহ সাক্ষী আছে?' তাহাতে উত্তরে কহিলা 'সাক্ষী কেহ নাই।' অনন্তর ভূপতি ভৃত্যের দিগকে আজ্ঞা করিলেন, যে এই দুই জনকে লইয়া নদী তীরে দুই শবের সহিত পৃথক পৃথক দাহ কর, ইহাতে বিলম্ব না হয়। পশ্চাৎ নির্জ্জনে ঐ দাসের দিগকে ডাকিয়া কহিলেন 'ঐ দুইজনকে দুই শবের সহিত পৃথক পৃথক বন্ধন করিয়া গুপ্তবেশে নিকটে থাকিয়া উভয়ের কথোপকথন শুনিয়া আমাকে কহিবা।' পরে দাসেরা সেই দুই লোককে নদীতীরে শবের সহিত বন্ধন করিয়া কাষ্ঠাদি আনিতে যাই ইহা কহিয়া অস্পষ্টরূপে নিকটে থাকিল, তাহাতে ঐ দুই ব্যক্তি আপন মরণ নিশ্চয় বুঝিয়া কৃষাণ চোরকে

out of sheer foolishness.' The officers overheard the conversation and at once reported to the King who, on knowing the facts, inflicted a suitable punishment on the thief and duly rewarded the ploughman."

How 23 fish disappeared.

II. *" A husbandman went with his plough to the fields one day, and got 24 fish from a neighbouring canal. He came back to his home and, after having made over the fish to his wife for cooking, returned to his duties. His wife prepared a curry with the fish and wanting to know the taste of her preparation took a sip from it. She found that it tasted well, and then she thought, 'But I don't know how the fish tastes; let me eat one.' So she ate a fish, and then she thought 'But still I donot

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কহিল যে 'হে চোর তুই এতবড় বুদ্ধিমান, বিনাপরাধে আমার প্রাণদণ্ড করিলি!' ইহাতে সে প্রত্যুত্তর করিল 'আমি পূর্ব্বে তোমাকে বারণ করিয়াছিলাম যে আমার সহিত বিবাদ করিলে তোমার প্রাণ যাইবে, আমি চোর, আমার মৃত্যু অবধারিত আছে। তুমি না বুঝিয়া প্রাণ হারাইয়াছ।' রাজ-ভৃত্যেরা এই কথোপকথন শুনিয়া রাজ-সমীপে সমুদায় কহিল। রাজা সমস্ত বৃত্তান্ত অবগত হইয়া চোরকে উপযুক্ত দণ্ড করিয়া কৃষকে তুষ্ট করিয়া বিদায় দিলেন।"

*" এক কৃষক লাঙ্গল চষিতে গিয়া কোন খানে গোটা চব্বিশেক মৎস্য ধরিয়া গৃহে আনিয়া আপন গৃহিণীকে পাক করিতে দিয়া আপনি পুনর্ব্বার চষিতে গেল তাহার গৃহিণী সে মৎস্য কয়টী পাক করিয়া মনে বিবেচনা করিল, যে মৎস্য পাক করিলাম কিন্তু কি প্রকার হইয়াছে চাখিয়া দেখি। ইহা ভাবিয়া কিঞ্চিৎ ঝোল লইয়া খাইয়া দেখিল যে ঝোল সুরস

know how that one on the dish would taste, and she ate the second fish also. In this manner she proceeded till she had finished all but one; and when her husband came home, she presented him with a dish of rice and a single fish. The husbandman wondering said 'what is the matter? I got 24 fish; what about the rest?' His wife gave him the following account of the fish.

"You brought 24 fish. A kite fell upon them and took away eight; sixteen remained.

"I took them to the tank for washing and eight swam away in the water; eight remained.

"I got two bundles of fuel in exchange of two fish.

হইয়াছে। পরে পুনর্ব্বার মনে ভাবিল মৎস্য কিরূপ হইয়াছে, তাহাও চাখিয়া দেখি, ইহা ভাবিয়া একটা মৎস্য খাইল। পুনর্ব্বার চিন্তা করিল ওটী কিরূপ হইয়াছে, তাহাও চাখিতে হয়: ভাবিয়া সেটীও খাইল। এইরূপে খাইতে খাইতে একটীমাত্র অবশিষ্ট রহিল। পরে কৃষক ক্ষেত্র হইতে বাটী আইলে তাহার গৃহিণী সেই মৎস্যটী আর অন্ন তাহাকে দিলে, কৃষক কহিল 'যে একি? চব্বিশটী মৎস্য আনিয়াছি, আর কি হইল?' তখন তাহার স্ত্রী মৎস্যের হিসাব দিল।

মাছ আনিলা ছয় গণ্ডা,
চিলে নিল দুই গণ্ডা,
বাকী রইল ষোল।
তাহা ধু'তে আটটা জলে পলাইল॥
তবে থাকিল আট।
দুইটায় কিনিলাম দুই আটি কাঠ॥

"Your good neighbours ought to have a share.

"I presented them with six; and then only two remained.

"I ate one to see how it tastes: there remained only one.

"Look for that on the dish.

"If you are a true man eat the bone and keep the flesh (for me).

"Because you have got such a wife as myself, you are furnished with a true account."

The above two extracts illustrate the easy and simple style which is to be found in some of the text books compiled for the college of Fort William in which Dr. Carey taught the Bengalee, Hindusthāni, and Mahārathi languages. He not only contributed very considerably himself to Bengali prose literature, but always befriended those who took good vernacular work in hand. For instance we find that Thākur's Bengali and English Diction-

A friend of Bengali writers.

তবে থাকিল ছয়
প্রতিবাসীকে চারিটা দিতে হয়॥
তবে থাকিল দুই।
তার একটা চাখিয়া দেখিলাম মিঠ॥
তবে থাকিল এক।
ঐ পাতখানে চাহিয়ে দেখ॥
এখন হইস যদি মান্সের পো।
তবে কাঁটাখান খাইয়া মাছখান খো॥
আমি যেঁই মেয়ে।
তেঁই হিসাব দিলাম ক'য়ে॥"

ary, an admirable work of scholarship, was compiled for the Fort William College in 1805 at the suggestion of Dr. Carey. He employed Rāma Rāma Vasu and Rājiva Lochana to write Pratāpaditya Charita and Krishṇa Chandra Charita respectively, the former of which appeared in 1801, and the latter in 1805.

His colleagues.

Thus lived Dr. Carey in Bengal from 1793 when he first landed here till his death in 1834,—one of those rare spirits who, crossing the barriers of their national prejudices, by dint of that all-embracing brotherhood which every true Christian should feel for all men, worked without a thought of reward or personal aggrandisement. He and his colleague Mr. J. Marshman had nothing to bequeath to their children at death, but enough as heritage to the suffering race whose cause they espoused, not under obligation or extraneous mandate, but according to the dictates of their own consciences through which their God spoke to them. Amongst his other colleagues the name of Yates, W. Marton (of whom the Rev. J. Long says 'He is one of the ablest Bengali scholars ever produced in the country'), and the Rev. J. Pearson deserve a special mention as having greatly furthered the cause of our prose literature.

(c) Bengali works written by Europeans.

The works written in the vernacular language about this time by European writers cover a vast field. We cannot name all of them. We confine ourselves to the following list of works, and our list even here is not exhaustive as we have not

included those that deal with Christianity. There is a great literature of translations of the Bible and treatises on Christianity which we cannot undertake to dwell upon at present. The list below is mainly based on the catalogue on vernacular works compiled by the Rev. J. Long in 1855. Most of these works were no doubt written for educational purposes.

Arithmetic.

1. Smith's zemindary papers, printed at the Çri Rāmapore press in 1817.

2. Mr. May's Arithmetical Table selected from those employed in the native schools. It was published in 1817 and called May-Gaṅita.

3. Harley's Arithmetic—Gaṅitāṅka. First Edition appeared from Chinsura in 1819.

Dictionary.

1. Bengali Dictionary by Forster,—a Civilian and Sanskrit Scholar. It contains 18000 words. Published in 1719 in two volumes. Price Rs. 60.

2. Miller's Bengali Dictionary, published in 1801. Price Rs. 32.

3. Haughton's Glossary, published in 1825.

4. Haughton's Bengali-to-English Dictionary, published at the expense of the Court of Directors in 1833. It contains 40,000 words. Price Rs. 80.

5. Marshman's Bengali Dictionary. Published in 1827,—25000 words.

6. Marshman's Bengali and English Dictionary, published in 1829. Price Rs. 10.

7. Rev. J. Pearson's School Dictionary, published in 1829.

8. Morton's Dictionary. 600 pages, Quarto size. Published in 1828. Price Rs. 6.

9. Mendie's Abridgment of Johnson's Dictionary (Bengali and English). First Edition appeared in 1822.

10. Rozario's Dictionary—1837. Price Rs. 6.

Ethics and moral tales.

1. Dr. Gilchrist's Bengali translation of Æsop's Fables—in 1803.

2. Upadeçakathā or moral tales by Stewart—in 1820.

3. Satguṅa O Viryya (95 anecdotes illustrating virtue and valour). Price Re. 1-8 as. compiled by a Çrī Rāmapore Missionary in 1829,

4. Æsop's Fables translated by Marshman.

5. Hitopadeça by Yates. Published in 1841.

6. Pārasika Itihāsa by Kneane.

Geography.

1. Bhugola Evaṁ Jyotiṣa (dialogues on Geography and Astronomy) by Pearson. Published in 1824.

2. A Map of the world in Bengali by G. Herklotts (1825).

3. J Sutherland's Geography of India.

4. Pearce's Bhugola Vrittānta (Geography)—in 1818.

5. Sandy's General Geography in Bengali—in 1842.

Grammar.

1. Halhed's Bengali Grammar—in 1778.

2. Carey's Grammar—in 1801.

3. Murray's English Grammar translated into Bengali by Rev. J. Pearson—in 1820.

4. Sir C. Haughton's Grammar. Price Rs. 15. Published in 1821.

5. J. Robinson's Bengali Grammar (a translation of Carey's Anglo-Bengali Grammar). Pages 109.

6. Keat's Bengali Grammar (Ket-Vyakarana). Published in 1820. Pages 59. Price 2 as. From 1820-1854 upwards of 15,000 copies were sold.

7. Wenger's Bengali Grammar. Pages 156. Price Re. 1-4 as.

History and Biography.

1. Goldsmith's History of England translated into Bengali by Felix Carey in 1819. Pages 412.

2. Captain Stewart's Moral tales of History with selections of historical subjects such as—glimpses of the early days of England, with moral instruction, historical anecdotes—illustrative of friendship, industry, justice, pride, anger; the arrival of the English in India, the Rules of the permanent settlement.

3. Itihāsa Samuchaya or Epitome of ancient history by Pearson. Pages 364. Price Re. 1. This book gives an account of the history of Egypt, Assyria, Babylon, Medea, Persia, Greece and Rome.

4. Prāchīna Itihāsa by Pearson. Published in 1830. Pages 623, compiled from Rollin and Anquetel ; it gives brief account of the Egyptians, Assyrians, Babylonians, Medes and Persians, Grecians, Romans, treating of manners, customs, buildings, natural productions, laws, Government and history of those States.

5. Vanga Deça Purāvritta translated from Marshman's History by Wenger. Pages 284.

6. Dharma Pustaka Vrittānta by Mrs. Hæberlin. Published in 1846. Pages 252 with 27 woodcuts.

7. Kāla Kramika Itihāsa by G. Pearce, published in 1838. Pages 89 with 10 wood cuts.

8. Daniel Charita by Morton. Pages 345 ; —in 1836.

9. Purāvritta Saṁkṣepa by J. Marshman ;— 1833. Pages 515. Price Rs. 3.

10. Bharata Varṣiya Itihāsa by J. Marshman. Two Volumes, 1831. Price Rs. 8.

11. Tucker's History of the Jews translated into Bengali by J. Kempbell. Pages 257. 1845.

12. Mahammad Jivana Charita by Rev. J. Long. Pages 121. Founded exclusively on Arabic authorities as given in the works of Sprenger, Weile, and Caussin de Percival—treats of Geography, Natural History and religious state of Arabia previous to Mahammad's time, Mahammad's youthful days, his

trading, when 40 years old he announces a new faith, opposition of his relatives, becomes a warrior, his polygamy, messages to foreign rulers, regulations for his followers: death in the midst of his plans. "The second part now in the press will take in the spread of Moslemism, the Korān, Moslemism as at present, the festivals and sects of the Mahomedans."

Medicine.

1. Carey's Bengali Anatomy (Hāḍavali Vidyā) Pages 638. Price Rs. 6. Published from the Çri Rāmapore press in 1820. Designed in 1818 to form the first part of a Bengali Encyclopædea, to consist chiefly of translation of 'esteemed compendiums of European art and science.'

2. Bachelor's Medical Guide. Pages 358. Price Re. 1.

Mensuration.

1. Robinson's Bengali Mensuration (Bhumi Parimāṅa) 1850. The author was an Inspector of Government Schools in Assam and the neighbouring districts. This work gives the elements of land-surveying and rules for finding the areas of 16 plain figures. 'It contains 10 problems—to find the area of a square, of a rectangular parallelogram: an oblique-angled parallelogram, a trapezium, a circle, ellipse, two sides of right-angled triangle, a triangle, a right angled triangle.'

Readers.

1. Yule's Spelling book—Çiçu Vodhodaya. A spelling book with short sentences and verses for reading.

2. Haughton's Selections, containing 10 stories from the Totā Itihāsa, 4 from the Vatriça Siṁhāsana and 4 from the Puruṣa Parikṣā. Published in 1822. Price Rs. 10.

3. Kṣetra Bhāgana Vivarana or Agri-horticultural Transactions, by J. Marshman, pages 730. Published in 1831 in two volumes.

4. Çiçu Çikṣā or Object Lessons—by J. Weitbrecht, in 1852.

5. Praçnāvali—by J. Long. This book contains questions on the animal, vegetable and mineral kingdoms, taken from objects in this country—designed to call forth the curiosity of the young people, and show them the wonders existing in common objects around them.

Natural Philosophy.

1. Padārtha Vidyā Sāra or Natural Philosophy and History by Yates, compiled from Martinet's Catechism of nature, William's Preceptor's Assistance and Bayley's Useful Knowledge, designed as an easy entrance to the path of science—treats of the properties of matter—the firmament and heavenly bodies, air, wind, vapour, rain, earth, man, animals, birds, fishes, insects, worms, plants, flowers, grass, grain, minerals and miscellaneous productions. Published in 1825.

2. Yate's Padārtha Vidyā—1824. Pages 91.

3. Kimiya Vidyā Sāra or Chemistry by Mack, pages 337—price Rs. 2-8 as,—treats of Chemical forces, Caloric, Light, Electricity, Chemical substances, Oxygen, Chloride, Bromine, Hydrogen, Nitrogen, Sulphur, Phosphorus, Carbon, Boron, Selenium, the steam engine.

Miscellaneous.

1. Rev. J. Pearson's Pāthaçālā Vivarāṅa—a translation of the more important part of Dr. Bell's instruction for modelling and conducting schools. Published from Chinsura in 1819.

2. Patra Kaumudi, composed by the Rev. J. Pearson, contains 286 letters on familiar subjects, commercial and familiar correspondence, forms of leases, zemindary accounts and other forms in common use. First edition 1819, sixth edition 1852 ; 8,500 copies sold within this period.

3. Pāthāvali by the Rev. J. Long—extracts chiefly from native works, on the life of a shepherd astronomer, Punjab salt mines, silk worms, Moslem saints, frog in a tone, printing the wonderful veil, the transparent watch, the tower of Pandua, ghāta-murders, steam engines, women devoted to Christ, a wonderful spring, the gold and silver of Scripture, balloons, Rāma Mohana Ray, productions of India-tin, lead and copper of Scripture, human body, Siamese twins, breathing, sagacity of elephants, etc.

4. Samvāda Sāra or selections from the native press by Rev. J. Long, 1853 ; pages 198. Price 6 as.

5. Yates' Prose selections, vol. I. 1847, pages 428. Price Rs. 5.

6. Prose selections from Bengali literature by Yates, vol. II, Octavo size, pages 407; gives 18 tales of a parrot, 9 letters from the Lipimālā, 14 stories from Vatriçā Siṁhāsana, notices of Indian kings from the Rājāvalī, the History of Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra Ray of Krishnagar, 16 moral tales from the Puruṣa Parikṣā, 5 chapters of the Hitopadeça, 9 moral essays from the Jnāna Chandrikā and 9 from the Jnānārṇava, 4th chapter of Pravodha Chandrikā, chapters against idolatry from the Tatta Prakāça, History of Nala from the Mahābhārata, specimens of Rāma Mohona Ray's hymns, selections from two native newspapers.

7. Vākyāvali (Idiomatical exercises) by J. Pearson, pages 294, Price Re. 1. A phrase-book with examples of words alphabetically arranged; "very useful for either natives wishing to learn colloquial English idioms or Europeans wishing to know Bengali dialogues." Forms of letters and notes; appeared in 1819.

8. Sāra Saṁgraha by Yates, 1845.

We have quite a large number of Law books translated into Bengali by European writers. Forster's translation of the Regulations of 1793, a work about 400 pages,—is a curiosity both as to style and typography. We have besides the Regulations of 1802—1809, pages 504, translated by Turnbull and Sutherland. Ditto 1816—1821 by Wynch; the Navavidhāna or abstract of miscellaneous Regulations of 1793—1824; Dewani Āin Sāra and Rjā Samparkiya Āin (in two volumes) by Marshman, any many other works of this nature.

9. In 1818 a Bengali Encyclopædea was commenced at Çrī Rāmapore, but only one part, Carey's Anatomy, was completed. In 1828 the society for translating European sciences with H. Wilson as president started the Vijnāna Sevādhi, a serial on the plan of the Library of useful knowledge. It reached 15 numbers embracing Indian Geography, Hydrostatics, Mechanics, Optics, Pneumatics and Broughām's discourse on the advantage of Science.

10. Virgil's Æneid. First book translated into Bengali by J. Serjeant, a Civilian and a student of Fort William College, pages 65 ; it came out in 1805.

11. Shakespeare's Tempest, translated into Bengali by Monckton, a student of the Fort William College.

12. First Part, Robinson Crusœ. Pages 261. Translated into plain Bengali by the Rev. J. Robinson, illustrated by 18 wood-cuts. A second edition was published in 1855.

13. Pilgrim's Progress, translated into Bengali in two volumes by Felix Carey.

14. Gladwin's Pleasant stories, translated into Bengali, by George Gallowway in 1840.

15. Mylius' School Dictionary, translated by J. Lavandier.

16. History of a lion.

17. Life of Fatik Chānd by the Rev. J. Lawson.

18. Madhu's conversation,—by the Rev. W. Morton.

19. Lamb's Tales from Shakespeare, translated by Dr. Roer.

20. Memoir of Pitāmvar Singh by the Rev. W. Ward.

Newspapers and Magazines.

"On the 31st of May, 1818, the first newspaper ever printed in any oriental language, was issued from the Çrī Rāmapore Press; it was called the Samāchāra Darpāṅa or the 'Mirror of News.' It was started jointly by Dr. Marshman and Dr. Ward.

In February, 1818, Dr. Marshman published the Dikdarçana, a monthly journal, in which amongst other subjects, there was given an account of the life of Rājā Kriṣṅa Chandra of Nadiā.

The Satya Pradipa by Mr. Townsend,—started in 1850, was a most useful paper; it gave a *precis* of news, correspondence, wood-cuts with descriptions of objects in art and nature.

The impetus given by European writers.

The above list shows that European writers, chiefly missionaries, were the pioneers in all departments of vernacular-writing which grew into favour with the awakening of Hindu intelligence under British rule. Every subject, from the principles of Arithmetic, Botany, Astronomy, Anatomy, Chemistry down to Law, is comprised in this list. The extraordinary energy displayed by foreign writers in mastering the idioms and technicalities of our language, and dealing with such widely divergent subjects, is a sure proof of the earnestness of their philanthropic mission. The writer of the present treatise can hardly refrain from giving expression to his gratitude, while reviewing these works, for the impetus given by them to the native mind in acquiring the knowledge so essential for the needs of modern civilisation. They laid the foundations upon which the vast fabric of our present-day-

literature is based—a literature which though necessarily lacking in originality, chiefly consisting as it does of translations and compilations, promises to rise to universal esteem under favourable circumstances, when it shall have passed its noviciate in acquiring all that it can assimilate from the vast resources of occidental learning.

(d) A new ideal in the country.

Contact with the west.

In the chapter on the Paurānic Renaissance, we noticed how mythological stories, fraught with a spirit of noble martyrdom and sacrifice, had elevated the minds of the people, and helped in spiritualising them. The Paurānic revivalists had held the earliest torch to enlighten our masses after Buddhism had declined in the country. The efforts of the missionaries and European scholars in giving culture through the medium of Bengali, now again after a lapse of nearly 700 years, served to awaken the Bengali mind to the consciousness of new ideas, the ideal of western civilisation.

The past ideal.

It was as if the home-stayers of Bengal had suddenly left the precints of home and launched out into the wide world. Hitherto the highest and noblest ideas that had inspired the Hindu mind in Bengal had drawn their impetus from home and from domestic life. Obedience to parents, loyalty to the husband, devotion to brothers and sacrifices to be undergone for guests, servants and relations, had all been elevated into the highest virtues, and the Puraṅas had supplied inexhaustible examples, illustrating each of these qualities. Rāma who left the throne and became an ascetic, and Viṣṇa, who

took the vow of celibacy, foregoing his rightful claims to the throne of Indraprastha, typify the highest example of filial obedience. Sītā, Sāvitrī, Damayanti, Çakuntalā, Behulā in the past and hundreds of those in the later age who courted death on the funeral pyre of their husbands, showed that the ideal of nuptial duties in this land was capable of raising women to the highest martyrdom. Hanumāna typifies devotion to a master, and Ekalavya to the religious preceptor. The home was the great sanctuary where sacrifices and martyrdoms were to be undergone for the sake of those sacred ties which bind one to it; and this would, according to the notion of the Hindus, infalliably lead him to a realisation of the supreme duty which a man owes to God,—culminating in a glorious renunciation of home for the good of the soul and of the world. Indeed, in a place where a joint and undivided family system required a man to live and eat together with all his near kinsmen, it would be impossible to live in harmony without elevating the domestic duties into the highest virtues. Hence no other nation has ever given so high a value to domestic duties, identifying them so closely with the spiritual.

The literature of a race inspired with such ideas has a unique value. Its scope may be comparatively small, but within its own narrow limits, it is deeper and purer than one could expect from a literature covering a wider range. The Bengali literature of the past had been reserved for the Bengalis alone; a fact which gives it an original character, displaying the subtle turns of the intellectual and spiritual qualities of the race; and one,

who may feel interested in studying our national ideas and aspirations, would do well to read this ancient literature, which, for a century after the English conquest, lay neglected and uncared for,—consigned to the care of the Batatalā publishing agencies of Calcutta.

The old and the new.

From the home to the world—it was a descent from the Himalayas to the plains,—from the lofty spiritual idea permeating the Hindu home,—the visions of beatitude which it was the dream of every great Hindu to attain,—to the matter-of-fact world and to an observation of things that are taking shape and changing all arround;—from the great examples of Bhiṣma and Rāma—cherished in the heart of every Hindu—the loftiest like the loftiest peak of the Himālayas,—to the stories of Duval's assiduity in learning, and Sir Philiph Sydney's offering his cup of water to the dying soldier: —from the pursuit and acquisition of Yoga to the knowledge of a Geographical catechism,—to be able to point out Popocatepetl on a map of the globe,—from the celestial songs of Rādhā and Kriṣṇa, which while gratifying all our yearnings for the loftiest of human love, have kept a door constantly open heaven-wards,—to the stories of Paul and Virginia or of Æneas and Dido: the descent is as great as one from the Himalayas to the plains. But a race of people confined within the narrow grooves of their own thoughts were dragged out to observe the wonders of the world, of which they had hitherto known nothing, nor cared to know,—nipping in the bud all curiosity about the material world by fabrication of monstrous

stories to explain the origin of things. To explain earthquakes, they had fabricated the story of Vāsuki, the great serpent who upholds the earth, as shaking his hydra-heads a little. To explain the origin of the universe they had invented the story of the golden egg that burst; with regard to the sea their idea was, that there were seven seas —one of curd, one of wine, one of salt, one of milk, and so forth; and as to the earth, that it consisted of seven islands and had a triangular shape. I do not mean to say that the race, who first formulated the principles of Arithmetic, Trigonometry, Geometry and Astronomy, and from whom the world learned these sciences, was so stupid as not to know the simple truths of Physical Geography; a Bhaskarāchāryya or a Varāhāmihira certainly knew them, and many things more, in advance of their age. But after the revival of Hinduism the spirit of inquiry had been directed from the material to the metaphysical world; the masses cared not to know the facts or the laws of the external world, and were content with fables regarding them, because the temporal had no longer any attraction for them. They took the same interest in the outer world as a globe-trotter takes in what he sees. Their knowledge of their surroundings was as superficial and as full of mistakes as that of one who merely passes through a country, thinking that this is not his true home. The Hindus showed the subtlest knowledge with regard to that world which they considered to be the only real one, and their Metaphysics is a mixture of the simple and the complex, in various grades of spiritual thoughts, springing from those

of home life—reaching the loftiest range in the conception of the Nirguṅa.

Nothing strikes a man so greatly as his contact with a person who possesses qualities other than his own, and the Bengalis are a race who owing to their keen intellectual powers can at once enter upon a new field, as soon as it is presented to them. European hand-books and manuals took them by surprise. They disclosed a world to them of which they knew nothing. They saw in the civilisation of Europe a success and acquisition of power which struck them with wonder and they became willing disciples of the new teachers. In the passionate sincerity of our race to acquire new knowledge, they forgot their home, their literature, their wonderful success in metaphysical learning, and their great spirituality, and felt that they were dwarfed in the presence of that great materialistic civilisation which, armed with thunder and lightning and with the tremendous power of steam, stood knocking at their door—demanding audience.

"Young Bengal."

Young Bengal, as the new generation of the Bengalis were then called, became thoroughly anglicised in spirit. They exulted in Shakespeare's dramas and Milton's poetry; they read Schiller's Robbers and Goethe's Faust; they could name all the English dramatists of the Elezabethan age—Marlow, Philip Massinger, Ford, John Webster, Ben Johnson and Shirley and reproduce from memory lines from still earlier dramatists and from Holinshed's chronicles which Shakespeare had improved on, in many a noble line. They grew mad after Shelley's Epipsychidion, Keat's Hyperion and

even after Chatterton's Death of Charles Bodwin. Poor Chandi Dās, poor Vidyāpati and Kavi Kañkaña! the tears of your departed spirit fell on the big towns of Bengal which lay under the charm of European influence,—mixed with nocturnal dews and unheeded by Young Bengal, who despised their own country from the bottom of their hearts and yet posed as representatives of the people in public meetings!

The College of Fort William.

The College of Fort William established by Lord Wellesley in 1800 was an institution, which having directly in view the imparting of knowledge of different languages and other subjects to the European candidates for the Civil Service, proved to be a bond of sympathy and good will between the rulers and the ruled. The test of proficiency was high and severe. It was laid down that "Before any Civilian could obtain a degree, he was required to demonstrate his knowledge of the native languages by holding in regard to the service in Bengal, four disputations in the Persian or Bengali language before all Calcutta in an august assembly comprised of the natives of rank and learning, Rājās, Foreign Ministers, Pundits and Munsies." It was further ordained that "no promotion was to be given in the public service throughout India in any branch of the service held by Civilians except through the channel of the College."

A knowledge of the vernacular essential for the Rulers.

This College was a place where the European candidates for the Civil Service, European professors and some of the best Indian intellects met on

terms of intimacy. It was not a meeting between officers and their subordinates which necessarily becomes formal for the discharge of official functions, but of those who made it a great point of their earnest endeavours to understand one another mutually. The study of the oriental languages, a high standard of proficiency in which was made compulsory, enabled the Civilians to comprehend the inner feelings and ideals of the vast population whom they were called upon to rule. The College of Fort William produced the most salutary results, creating a sympathetic attitude in European minds towards the native community, and both sections derived great profit from an interchange of thoughts. In the case of our countrymen, this result was manifest in the adoption of European manners and in the preference given to the civilisation of the west, and in the case of the European Civil servants, in their sympathetic attitude towards the people of this country, and in the hearty interest taken in all the movements of reform calculated to improve the condition of the latter.

The vast range of college-studies

"The range of studies marked out for the students in the College was very extensive. It embraced the modern languages of Europe, the Greek, Latin and English Classics; Geography and Mathematics; general History, Botany, Chemistry and Astronomy; Ethics and Jurisprudence, the laws of nations—of England, and in reference to Indian studies the Arabic, Persian, Sanskrit Hindustani, Bengali, Telegu, Mahratta, Tamil and Canarese languages and the history of the antiquities of Hindustan and the Decan . . . . . The

college was considered one of the most important departments of the State, and the Senior members of the Government were required in virtue of their office, to take a share in its management. Lord Wellesley proposed to erect a spacious and magnificent edifice for the institution in the immediate neighbourhood of Calcutta at Garden Reach, suitable for the accommodation of all professors and 500 students with a public hall, library, chapel and other requisite apartments."

"Such was the grand institution which, Lord Wellesley projected to qualify the public functionaries for their official duties. It was the noblest and most comprehensive plan of usefulness which had been devised since the Factory had grown into an Empire."

"The incitements to exertion in the College of Fort William were of the highest and most effective nature and its moral, economical and religious discipline such as was admirably calculated to promote all that was virtuous and useful in civil society.*

"Several of those who attained the highest posts in the empire, and many, who, if they did not reach such a proud eminence yet departed with the esteem of the high, and confidence of the lowly, laid the foundation of future success within the precincts of the College. The well-known names of Macnaghton, Bayley, Jenkins, Haughton, Prinsep and others, are sufficient to prove the justness of this observation."†

* Memoirs of Dr. Buchanan Vol. I, Page 208.
† Calcutta Review, Vol. V.

(b) The Pundits of the College.

The movement for undertaking literary and scientific works in Bengali prose, mainly initiated by the Europeans, served to evoke the zeal of the enlightened native community who pursued it with great vigour and activity. Some of the best prose works, on the lines indicated in the vernacular writings of Europeans, were compiled by the Pundits of the Fort William College, where Dr. Carey, as a professor of the vernacular languages, wielded a great influence, and was ever ready to render all possible help to all undertakings to promote the cause of vernacular literature. The works written by Bengali authors in this period mainly follow European models in style, and the best of them, making all possible allowances, scarcely possess the worth of second class literary productions, whereas most of the others, while embodying rudimentary information in all departments of useful knowledge, are mere translations of European works—mostly school-books.

The Pundits of the Fort William College, as I have said, wrote many Bengali prose works about this time which enjoyed great popularity not only with the native community but with the Europeans, specially the candidates for Civil Service Examination who had to read them as text-books in that College.

Mrityunjaya.

"At the head of the establishment of Pundits," (at the Fort William College) writes J. C. Marshman in his history of Çri Rāmapur Mission, stood Mrityunjaya, who although a native of Orissa,*

* Mrityunjaya Tarkālankara was born in 1762 A.D. at Midnapur

usually regarded as the Bœotia of the country, was a colossus of literature. He bore a strong resemblance to our great lexicographer not only by his stupendous acquirements and the soundness of his critical judgments but also in his rough features and unweildy figure. His knowledge of the Sanskrit classics was unrivalled, and his Bengali composition has never been surpassed for ease, simplicity and vigour. Mr. Carey sat under his instruction two or three hours daily while in Calcutta, and the effect of this intercourse was speedily visible in the superior accuracy and purity of his translations. In the English preface to the Probhoda Chandrikā, Marshman says of Mrityunjaya as "one of the most profound scholars of the age."

Of the Bengali works written by Mrityunjaya, his *Prabodha Chandrika* is a monument of learning; it contains dissertations on Hindu Astronomy, Rhetoric, Law, Logic, Philosophy and other branches of learning of which the author was a perfect master. He makes a curious hotch-potch of the whole by combining the serious with the comic. The metaphysical subjects are huddled up with colloquies of artizans and rustics, and the whole is treated without much care for arrangement or system. The book was written in 1813. An edition of it appeared in 1833 after the author's death. Marshman further says in the preface, "the book is written in the purest Bengali of which indeed it may be considered one of the most beautiful specimens.....Any person who can comprehend the present work and enter into the spirit of its beauties may justly consider himself

master of the language." Mrityunjaya Tarkālankāra wrote *Rajavali* in 1808. It traces the history of India from the earliest time down to Timur. Mr. Ward in his work on the Hindus bestows a high encomium upon this book. It contains some of the traditions about ancient Hindu kings which may be of much help to the students of Indian history in substantiating thereby some of the informations derived from copper-plate inscriptions and other historical sources. The book is written in a simple style, though some of the expressions used by the learned author appear quaint to us, owing to lapse of years. Mrityunjaya's third work *Vatrica-siñhasana* is a collection of tales illustrative of Vikramaditya's romantic self-denial and liberality to a beggar, to a Brahmin, to a scholar, to the poor, to a pundit and to an enemy.

Though the Pundit lived in close touch with his distinguished European students, and was highly admired by them for his learning and character, he was an orthodox Hindu all his life. His pamphlet called "a defence of idolatry" shows the sweep of his scholarly arguments and the sincerity of his conviction in defending the creed of his forefathers. Mrityunjaya translated the Sanskrit work Hitopadeça into Bengali. The book appeared in 1801. "It treats of friendship, discord, war and peace in 42 fables, in which after the manner of Æsop, animals are introduced to teach Ethics. The original, like Telemachus, was written for the ethical instruction of a king's son at Palibothera."

Mrityunjaya also translated from Sanskrit a treatise on the Hindu law of inheritance.

Rāma Rāma Vasu.

Next to Mrityunjaya, we find Rāma Rāma Vasu—a Kayastha held in high esteem by the Europeans at Fort William College, for his great learning in different oriental languages. Says Dr. Carey about him "a more devout scholar than him I did never see." Rāma Rāma Vasu was born towards the end of the 18th century at Chinsura. He got his early education in a *pathacala* at the village of Nimtā, a place in Twenty-four Parganas already noted as the birth-place of the old poet Kriṣṇa Rāma. "Rāma Basu" writes Dr. Carey "before his 16th year became a perfect master of Persian and Arabic. His knowledge of Sanskrit was not less worthy of note..... He was of a peculiar turn of mind. Though amiable in manners and honest in dealings he was a rude and unkind Hindu if any body did him wrong." Rāma Vasu was appointed as a Pundit in the Fort William College in 1800, but owing to difference of opinion, resigned his post shortly after.

Rāma Vasu's *Pratapaditya Charita* published in 1801 at Çri Rāmpur was one of the first works written in modern prose. "Its style, a kind of Mosaic, half Persian half Bengali, indicates the pernicious influence which the Mahomedans had exercised over the Sanskrit-derived languages." * We find the following account of the book in the descriptive catalogue of books by the Rev. J. Long. "The first prose work and the first historical one that appeared was the life of Pratāpāditya, the last king of the Sāgara island by Rāma Vasu, (page 156)." The Rev. J. Long also condemns this style

* Calcutta Review 1850.

of the book as corrupted by an admixture of Persian, but this estimate, I must say, is not just, for in the descriptions of wars and court-affairs the language could not in those days avoid a mixture of Persian in which all court affairs were managed even in the States under the control of Hindu Rājās. The great Sanskrit scholar and poet Bhārata Chandra himself, who introduced some of the choicest Sanskrit metres in Bengali, could not describe war or court scenes without having recourse to Persian words. In describing domestic or religious matters Rāma Vasu generally avoided Persian and Arabic words. His style is quaint and affected; at any rate as one of the earliest specimens of modern Bengali prose we may often excuse his faults, and be prepared to admit that he wrote a connected story in an interesting and lively manner. The other works by Rāma Vasu were his (1) *Lipimala*, or a guide to letter-writing containing a number of models for letters. This treats also of business, religion, and Arithmetic,—printed at the Çri Rāmapur Press in 1802. 2) *Attack on Brahmins*. Rāma Vasu was a friend of Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy who had kindly revised the Ms. of *Pratapaditya Charita* before it was published. From some of his writings it appears that he favoured the views of his enlightened friend.

Chandi charaṅa and Rājiva Lochana.

Two other works written by Pundits of the Fort William College respectively are 1) *Teta Itihasa* by Chandi Charan Munsi which appeared in 1826, (2) *Krisna Chandra Charita* by Rājiva Lochana Mukhopādhāya, which came out in 1805. The style of both these works is elegant. We

quote an extract from Rājiva Lochana's Kriṣṇa Chandra Charita. Rājā Kriṣṇa Chandra of Navadvipa, an account of whom we gave in a foregoing chapter, is the subject of this memoir. The Rājā, called by the Rev. J. Long 'The Augustas of the East' was a great friend of the English, and had been chiefly instrumental in persuading Mirzāfar and other leading men of Bengal to form a secret alliance with them on the eve of the memorable battle of Plassey. The extract refers to the defeat of Sirājuddaullā, his destitution and miserable end.

Kriṣṇa-Chandra Charita.

*"The English next came to the field of Plassey and began to fight. The soldiers of the Nawāb saw that their great generals were fighting in a half-hearted manner and that the volley of fire opened on them by the English was killing hundreds of them. In deep dismay many died fighting desperately. Mohana Dās, a general of the Nawāb saw that the fighting was not conducted as it should be, and informed the Nawāb that some of his generals had conspired against him and were trying to bring ruin upon him. The Nawāb wonderingly asked how that could be? Mohana Dās

* "পরে ইঙ্গরাজের যাবদীয় সৈন্য পলাসীর বাগানে উপনীত হইয়া সমর আরম্ভ করিল। নবাবী সৈন্য সকল দেখিল যে প্রধান ২ সৈন্যেরা মনোযোগ করিয়া যুদ্ধ করে না এবং ইঙ্গরাজের অগ্নিবৃষ্টিতে শত শত লোক প্রাণত্যাগ করিতেছে। কি করিব ইহাতে কেহ উষ্মা ক্রমে যুদ্ধ করিয়া প্রাণত্যাগ করিতেছে। যুদ্ধ ভাল হইতেছে না ইহা দেখিয়া নবাবের চাকর মোহন দাস নামে এক জন সে নবাব সাহেবকে কহিলেক আপনি কি করেন আপনার চাকরেরা পরামর্শ করিয়া মহাশয়কে নষ্ট করিতে বসিয়াছে। নবাব কহিলেন সে কেমন। মোহন

submitted that the Commander-in-Chief Mirzāfar Khān had made a secret league with the English and was not fighting. Mohana Dās wanted an army to lead to the field to destroy them and warned the Nawāb against placing confidence on any one at such a critical hour. He advised his master besides to keep a close watch, and guard the eastern gate with the remaining army. The Nawāb was alarmed at this information, and placed Mohana Dās at the head of 25,000 soldiers, and gave him every encouragement to fight at Plassey. Mohana Dās began to fight with remarkable zeal, which alarmed the English: Mirzāfar saw that matters would not stand well for him, if Mohana Dās should gain the victory over the English, and the present Nawāb

The assassination of Mohana Dās.

দাস কহিল সেনাপতি মিরজাফরালি খান ইঙ্গরাজের সঙ্গে প্রণয় করিয়া রণ করিতেছে না অতএব নিবেদন আমাকে কিছু সৈন্য দিয়া পলাশীর বাগানে পাঠান আমি যাইয়া যুদ্ধ করি। আপনি বাকী সৈন্য লইয়া সাবধানে থাকিবেন পূর্ব্বের দ্বারে যথেষ্ট লোক রাখিবেন এবং এইক্ষণে কোন ব্যক্তিকে বিশ্বাস করিবেন না নবাব মোহন দাসের বাক্য শ্রবণ করিয়া ভয়যুক্ত হইয়া সাবধানে থাকিয়া মোহন দাসকে পঁচিশ হাজার সৈন্য দিয়া অনেক আশ্বাস দিয়া পলাশীতে প্রেরিত করিলেন। মোহন দাস উপস্থিত হইয়া অত্যন্ত যুদ্ধ করিতে প্রবৃত্ত হইল। মোহন দাসের যুদ্ধেতে ইঙ্গরাজ সৈন্য সশঙ্কিত হইল। মীরজাফরালি খান দেখিলেন এ কর্ম্ম ভাল হইল না যদ্যপি মোহন দাস ইংরাজকে পরাভব করে আর এ নবাব থাকে তবে আমাদিগের সকলেরি প্রাণ যাইবেক অতএব মোহন দাসকে নিবারণ করিতে হইয়াছে। এহাই বিবেচনা করিয়া নবাবের দুত একজন লোককে পাঠাইলেন। সে মোহন দাসকে কহিল আপনাকে নবাব-

continue to reign, the lives of all of them would be forfeited. So it appeared to him of vital importance to check Mohana Dās. Apprehending dire disaster, Mirzāfar sent a messenger who declared himself as bearing a message from the Nawāb to Mohana Dās. He said that it was the order of the Nawāb that the general should at once appear before him. Mohana Dās said that it was not possible for him at that stage of the fight to leave the battle-field. The carrier of the false message said, "How is it that you do not obey the Nawāb?" Mohana Dās now felt sure that it was all a trick. Why should the Nawāb call him at such an hour? So he at once beheaded the man and resumed the fight. Mirzāfar was terror-struck; he thought all hope would be gone if things were allowed to continue in that manner any longer. So he called in a relation of his own, and ordered him to go as a soldier of the English and kill Mohana Dās. That person immediately took a gun with him and going close to Mohana Dās fired at him; So fell Mohana

Flight of the Nawāb.

সাহেব ডাকিতেছেন শীঘ্র চলুন। মোহন দাস কহিল আমি রণ ত্যাগ করিয়া কি প্রকারে যাইব। নবাবের দূত কহিল আপনি রাজাজ্ঞা মানেন না। মোহন দাস বিবেচনা করিল এ সকল চাতুরী. এসময় নবাবসাহেব আমাকে কেন ডাকিবেন ইহা অন্তঃকরণে সিদ্ধান্ত করিয়া দূতের শিরশ্ছেদন করিয়া পুনরায় সমর করিতে লাগিল। মীরজাফরালি খান বিবেচনা করিল বুঝি প্রমাদ ঘটিল পরে আত্মীয় একজনকে আজ্ঞা করিল তুমি ইঙ্গরাজের সৈন্য লইয়া মোহন দাসের নিকট গমন করিয়া মোহন দাসকে নষ্ট করহ। আজ্ঞা পাইয়া একজন মনুষ্য মোহন দাসের নিকট গমন করিয়া অগ্নিবাণ মোহন দাসকে মারিল সেই বাণে

Dās. The army of the Nawāb dispersed and fled and victory was obtained by the English.

"Sirājuddaullā heard all and saw that there was no way to escape, so he thought it prudent to beat a retreat. He embarked on a boat and fled. Mirzāfar Āli Khān brought all this to the notice of the English General, and going to the Fort of Murshidābād hoisted the English flag from which all knew that the noble people of England had gained the victory. They were all so delighted at the event that they began to shout for joy and play on various instruments of music. People of the higher class went in great numbers with presents to the English General, who received them cordially, and ordered that those officers who were already discharging State functions should all be reinstated. He distributed tokens of his favour, moreover,

Joy of the people at the Victory of the English.

মোহন দাস পতন হইল। পরে নবাবী যাবদীয় সৈন্য রণে ভঙ্গ দিয়া পলায়ন করিল, ইঙ্গরাজের জয় হইল।

পরে নবাব সাজেদৌল্লা সকল বৃত্তান্ত শ্রবণ করিয়া মনে মনে বিবেচনা করিলেন কোন মতে রক্ষা নাই, আপন সৈন্য বৈরী হইল, অতএব আমি এখান হইতে পলায়ন করি। ইহাই স্থির করিয়া নৌকাপরি আরোহন করিয়া পলায়ন করিলেন। পরে ইঙ্গরাজ সাহেবের নিকটে সকল সমাচার নিবেদন করিয়া মীরজাফরালি খান মুরসীদাবাদের গড়েতে গমন করিয়া ইঙ্গরাজি পতাকা উড়াইয়া দিলে সকলে বুঝিল ইঙ্গরাজ মহাশয়দের জয় হইল। তখন সমস্ত লোক জয়ধ্বনি করিতে প্রবৃত্ত হইল এবং নানা বাদ্য বাজিতে লাগিল। যাবদীয় প্রধান প্রধান মনুষ্য ভেটের দ্রব্য দিয়া সাহেবের নিকট সাক্ষাৎ করিলেন।

among them. They placed Mirzāfar Āli on the throne of Murshidābād and instructed the officers to carry on official work with care, so that the empire might flourish and the poor might not suffer. The officers began to work as they were bidden.

The sad end of the Nawāb.

"After his defeat the Nawāb in the course of his flight became oppressed with hunger: for three days he had had no meal, and when on the fourth day his boat was passing by the abode of a fakir he ordered a man to go to him and tell him that a certain man was very ill and that he wanted to eat food at his place. The fakir hearing this came near to the boat, and recognised the Nawāb, who looked exceedingly pale. He thought "once upon a time

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সাহেব সকলকে আশ্বাস করিয়া যিনি যে কর্ম্মে নিযুক্ত ছিলেন সেই ২ কর্ম্মে তাঁহাকে নিযুক্ত করিয়া রাজপ্রসাদ দিলেন। মীরজাফরালিকে নবাব করিয়া সকলকে আজ্ঞা করিলেন, তোমরা সকলে সাবধানপূর্ব্বক রাজকর্ম্ম করিবা যেন রাজ্যের প্রতুল হয় এবং প্রজালোক দুঃখ না পায়। সকলে আজ্ঞানুসারে কার্য্য করিতে লাগিলেন

পরে নবাব সাজেদৌল্লা পলায়ন করিয়া যান। তিন দিবস অভুক্ত অত্যন্ত ক্ষুধিত, নদীর তটের নিকট এক ফকিরের আলয় দেখিয়া নবাব কর্ণধারকে কহিলেন এই ফকিরের স্থানে গিয়া তুমি ফকিরকে বল কিঞ্চিৎ খাদ্য সামগ্রী দাও একজন মনুষ্য পীড়িত কিঞ্চিৎ আহার করিবেক। ফকির এই বাক্য শ্রবণ করিয়া নৌকার নিকট আসিয়া দেখিল অসুস্থ নবাব সাজেদৌল্লা বিষন্ন বদন। ফকির সকল বৃত্তান্ত জ্ঞাত হইয়া বিবেচনা করিল, নবাব পলায়ন করিয়া যায় ইহাকে আমি ধরিয়া দিব। আমাকে

the Nawāb oppressed me and now the time for retaliation has come. I shall bring him up to Mirzāfar." But with joined palms he said "I am arranging the dinner quickly, so that you may continue your journey as soon as possible after partaking of it." The Nawāb was highly pleased with the courteous reception thus given him by the Fakir, and went to his house in great confidence. The fakir began to make arrangements for the meal, but in the meantime he had sent a secret message to an officer of Mirzāfar reporting that the Nawāb was fleeing and that he should lose no time in seizing him. As soon as the officer got this information, he hastened to the fakir's abode with a body of men, seized the Nawāb and sent him to Murshidābād."

Fort-William College dissolved in 1854.

Fort William College with its glorious record of usefulness in various departments of knowledge —and with what particularly interests ourselves, its labours in the cause of Bengali prose literature

পরে যথেষ্ট নিগ্রহ করিয়াছিল তাহার শোধ লইব ইহাই মনমধ্যে করিয়া করপুটে বলিল সাহাবের দয়া আমি প্রস্তুত করি. আপনারা সকলে ভোজন করিয়া প্রস্থান করুন। ফকিরের প্রিয় বাক্যে নবাব অত্যন্ত তুষ্ট হইয়া ফকিরের বাড়ীতে গমন করিলেন। ফকির খাদ্যসামগ্রীর আয়োজন করিতে লাগিল এবং নিকটে নবাব মীরজাফরালিখানের চাকর ছিল তাহাকে সম্বাদ দিল. যে নবাব সিরাজেদৌল্লা পলায়ন করিয়া যায়. তোমরা তাহাকে ধর। নবাব মীরজাফরালি খানের লোক এ সম্বাদ পাবা মাত্র অনেক মনুষ্য একত্র হইয়া নবাবসিরাজদৌল্লাকে ধরিয়া মুরশিদাবাদ আনিলেক।"

gradually decayed in importance from the time of the foundation of Haileybury College in 1807, till its final extinction in 1854.

The Bengali prose works written by various authors early in the 19th century, though occasionally encumbered with compound words and quaint and high flown style, often show great erudition, as the writers were all learned Pundits. They enriched the prose literature by translations either from English or from the Sanskrit, Arabic and Persian languages. These works were generally compiled with great care; and considering the disadvantages from which the early labourers in any field must always suffer, we may excuse many of their inevitable short-comings. Personally, we have hitherto neglected the literature of this period being repelled, on the one hand, by the quaint bombastic style of our learned countrymen, and by the errors in idiom, on the other, into which European writers of Bengali have so frequently fallen. But this was an age in which Bengali prose had been taken up in earnest by men who spared no pains to contribute to its development; and there is surely much in these writings which will repay careful perusal by the writers of Bengal, at the present day.

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(c) The Rev. K. M. Banerji and other authors who followed in the wake of European writers. A list of their publications.

Foremost amongst those who laboured in the field of Bengali prose under the influence of Eng-

lish education and the missionaries, was the Rev. K. M. Banerji.

Born in 1813 at Calcutta, this scholar was trained in the Hindu College and was one of the most diligent pupils and admirers of Dr. Razario whose influence upon "Young Bengal" was unbounded in his time. His pupils were imbued with European tastes, and though many of them rose to great eminence in later times, nearly all of them despised the orthodox religion and by their unrestrained conduct created great alarm in the minds of the Hindus. The comrades of Mr. Krishna Mohana Banerji, in the enthusiasm of their reformation, used to throw bones and meat into the neighbouring houses, and then cry out that it was beef which they had deliberately thrown there to pollute the homes of their Hindu friends. Krishna Mohana in his youth was unsparing in his abuse of those who happened to hold a different view from himself in matters of religion and used to call the illustrious Rādhā Kanta Deva, who was one of the leaders of the orthodox community, by the name of Gādhā Kanta, the word '*gadha*' meaning an ass.

K. M. Banerji.

Krishna Mohana embraced Christianity in 1832, and after the hey-day of his youth had passed, was held in high esteem by Europeans as well as by our countrymen for the soundness of his views, his great scholarship and his coolness of temper.

His chief work in Bengali was the *Vidya Kalpa Druma* or Encyclopædea Bengalensis. It was started under the patronage of the Government in 1846, and dedicated by permission to the Governor-

His Encyclopaedea Bengalensis.

General of India. The following are some of the subjects which the Encyclopædea was designed to embrace—

(1). Ancient History—Egypt, Babylon, Greece, Rome, India. Manners, Customs, opinions etc., of the Egyptians, the Babylonians, the Greeks, the Romans, the Hindus and other Asiatic nations.

(2). Modern History—of Europe, England, India, Bengal, America, etc.

(3). Science, Geography, Mathematics, Natural Philosophy, Astronomy, Metaphysics, Moral Philosophy, etc.

(4). Biographies of eminent men,—politicians, scholars, etc., European and Asiatic, ancient and modern, more after the form of Cornelius Nepos, than the more elaborate work of Plutarch.

(5). Miscellaneous readings containing detached pieces of various kinds adapted to the comprehension of the people of Bengal. Anecdotes, orations, speeches, accounts of travels and voyages.

Thirteen volumes of the projected Encyclopædia came out, *viz* :—

1. History of Rome Vol. I.
2. Do. do. Vol. II.
3. Geometry Vol. I.
4. Do Vol. II.
5. Miscellaneous extracts Vol. I.
6. Do. do. Vol. II.
7. Biography (containing the lives of Confucius, Plato, Alfred, and Vikramāditya).
8. History of Egypt.
9. Geography.

10. Moral tales.
11. Watt's On The Mind Vol. I.
12. Do. do. Vol. II.
13. Life of Galileo.

The Encyclopædea contains much useful information for the enlightenment of the Bengal public who had hitherto had no knowledge of the outside world, but it shows no original research in any field by the compiler, consisting, as it does, mainly of translations from standard European writers. The Vidyā Kalpa Druma by Dr. K. M. Banerji and the *Vividhartha Samgraha* by Dr. Rājendra Lāl Mitrā (started in 1851) are two monuments of patient labour giving that up-to-date information in Science and Art which was so essential for the dessimination of useful knowledge amongst our countrymen in the earlier half of the 19th century.

A list of publications.

There was at the time quite a legion of Bengali works on the aforesaid lines, most of which have sunk into oblivion, after their brief day of usefulness in enlightening the masses of Bengal, and we can only name some of them to show in what direction the wind blew in our literature. For the list furnished below we have had to depend mainly upon the descriptive catalogue of Bengali books by the Rev. J. Long published in 1855.

Vocabulary

1. A Dictionary by Rāma Kamala Sen (Grand father of the illustrious Keçava Chandra Sen) pp. 1534. "A work of great research—the result of 15 years' labour—a translation of Todd and Johnson containing the meanings in Bengali of 5800 English words—a perfect chaos of materials for future lexicographers and a work of great

industry with Rādhā Kanta's famous Çavda Kalpa Druma." The price of the book was Rs. 50 per copy.

2. Çavda Sindhu—translation of the Amara Koṣa in Bengali by Pitāmvar Mukerjee of Uttarpārā, 1909.

3. Rāma Kiṣana's vocabulary—English, Latin and Bengali, 1821.

4. Anglo Bengali Dictionary by Tārā Chānd (75,000 words). Price Rs. 6.

5. Dictionary by Jaya Gopāla.

6. Do. by Lakṣmi Narayaṅa.

7. Çavda Kalpa Tarangini by Jagannāth Mallik.

These three works, all published in 1838, give suitable Bengali substitutes for the Persian terms prevalent in courts.

8. Dictionary by Jaya Nārāyaṅa Çarmā, (16,000 words), 1838,

9. Ratna Hāldar's Vangabhidhana (6224 words) 1839.

10. Anglo Bengali Dictionary by Rādhānath De & Co. A vocabulary giving the meaning of words relating to Grammar, Heaven, Earth, the Body, Natural Objects, Apparel, Minerals, and Agriculture, 1850.

11. *Parasikabhidhana* or Persian and Bengali Dictionary by Jaya Gopāla, 1840;—contains about 2500 Persian words arranged alphabetically with the Bengali meanings.

Grammar.

12. Gangā Kiçore Bhattāchāryya's Vyākaraṅa.

13. A Bengali translation of the Mugdhavodha by Mathurā Mohana Dutta of Chinsura, 1819.

14. Bhāṣā Vyākaraṅa, 1823.

15. Rāma Mohana Ray's Vyākaraṅa, 1833.

16. Vraja Kiçore's Bengali Grammar, 1845.

17. Bhagavana Chandra's Bengali Grammar, 1845.

18. Sanskrit Grammar in Bengali by Devendra Nāth Tagore, 1845. Part I "Extends to Pronouns—gives the rules of Sandhi and the declensions written after the European system of Philology,—simple, well illustrated by examples," published by the Tatta Vodhini Sabhā.

19. Çyāmā Charaṅa's Anglo Bengali Grammar, pages 408—the most elaborate grammar that had appeared up to that time. Government patronised it liberally taking 100 copies at Rs. 10 per copy:—contains much information on the prosody of Bengali poetry.

History.

20. History of India by Govinda Chandra Sen, 1836.

21. History of Bengal—a translation of Marshman's history, pages 337, 1840.

22. Vāngālā Itihāsa by Içhvara Chandra Vidyā-sāgara from the battle of Plassey down to Lord William Bentinck's administration, 1849.

23. History of the Punjab by Rājā Narāyaṅa Banerji, pages 194, gives much information respecting the Punjab, Kaçmir, Kabul, Kandahār and

the country of the Shikhs, derived from the Rāja Tarangini, Āin-Ākvari, Seyar Mutākharim, Prinsep's Life of Ranjit Singh, Lawrence's adventure in the Punjab and MacGregor's Çikhs.

24. Rome Purāvritta by K. M. Banerji, pages 610.

25. Bhāratvarṣer Itihāsa by Vaidya Nāth Banerji. Two volumes, pages 352, 1848. Compiled from Manu, Yajnavalka, the Rāmāyaṅa, the Mahābhārata, the Rājāvali, Book's Gazetteer, Marshman's History of Bengal, etc. One object of this book was to oppose the views given in Marshman's India which the author thinks are too much against the Brahmins and in favour of Christianity. The books treats of the Chronology of ancient Hindu King's, their residences, mode of government, origin of caste and other matters;—a defence of Hindu character.

26. Bharatvarṣer Itihāsa by Gopāla Lāl Mitra, pages 201, 1840.

27. Rājāvali by Çyāma Dhana Mukerjee, 1845.

Biography.

28. Life of Bhavāni Charaṅa, "editor of the Chandrikā and the great leader of the Pro-suttee party." "A curious piece of biography" I find the following notice of the subject of this memoir in John Clark Marshman's History of Çrirāmpur Mission. In 1821 a native newspaper was started in Calcutta which maintained great influence in native circles for many years. It was designated the Chandrikā, and was edited by Bhavāni Charaṅa,

a Brahmin of great intelligence and considerable learning, though no Pundit, remarkable for his tact and energy which gave him great ascendency among his fellow countrymen. The journal was intended to check the liberal tendencies of the age, and it soon became the organ of the orthodox Hindus. During the life of its able and astute editor, it was considered the great bulwork of the current superstitions. Its success was owing not only to the popularity of the opinions which it advocated, but also to the charm of pure and simple style."*

29. Satya Itihāsa, pages 239, 1830. Sketches of Semiramies, Sesostris, Homer, Lycurgus, Socrates, Demosthenes and Alexander.

30. Jivana Charita by Içvara Chandra Çarmā, 1849. Lives of Copernicus, Galileo, Newton, Herschell, Grotius, Linœus, Duval, Thomas Jenkins, S. W. Jones.

Moral tales and other subjects.

31. Ajnāna Timira Nāçaka, 1838. By Vaidya Nāth Āchāryya of Kānchanpāra.

32. Praçasti Prakāçika, 1842. By Kriṣṇa Lāl Deb, compiled from original Sanskrit of Vararuchi of the Court of Vikramāditya: gives rules according to the Çāstras for writing letters—the colour and size of the paper, the titles of letters and mode of address. Some curious things are to be found in this work, such as,—a person is to write to a young girl in red paper with red ink, to a great man in gold-coloured letters, to a man of middle rank in silver, to a

* Vol. II, p. 241

common man on copper or tin coloured paper, before marriage on vermilion ; a letter to a great man is to be six finger-breadths long, to a person of middle class 18 inches ; receiving a letter from a Rājā or Guru it is to be laid on the head, from a friend on the forehead ; from a wife on the breast.

33. Jnāna Kaumudi, on letter-writing by Rameçvara Banerjee of Gopālapur.

34. Lipi Mālā by Rāma Rāma vasu, 1802.

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34. Paçvāvali (Animal biography) by R. C. Mitra.

35. Pākhī Vivaraṅa—on birds, by R. C. Mitra, pages 660, 1834.

36. Padārtha Vidyā by P. C. Mitra, 1847.

37. Vividha Pātha—Miscellaneous readings, 1847.

38. Patradhara by Jaya Gopāla Tarkālankāra, 1821.

39. Vānarāṣtaka, 1834. By Rājā Kali Kissen. A man disguised as a male-ape questions Rājā Vikramāditya.

40. Strī Çikṣā Viṣayaka (on female education) by Goura Mohana De, 1818, gives evidence in simple language in favour of the education of Hindu woman " from the examples of illustrious ones both ancient and modern and particularly of Indian females, such as Rukmini, Khanā, Vidyālankār (?) who gave lectures at Benares on the Çāstras. Sundarī of Faridpur skilled in Logic, Ahalyā Vāi who conversed in Sanskrit and erected many buildings.

41. Stri Durāchāra—a reply to the above in the language of fierce ire published in 1840.

42. Hita Kathā—100 ethical stories by Rāja Kiçore of Pulāsati.

43. Jnāna Pradīpa—moral tales by Gauri Çankara Bhattāchāryya, 1848.

44. Jnāna Ratna—selection of morals by Prema Chānd Rāy, 1842, gives tales and anecdotes to illustrate the following subject:—Duty to parents and teachers—Knowledge and folly.

45. Jnāna Chandrikā—selection of ethical pieces, 1838, by Gopāla Mitra.

46. Niti Kathā—Moral tales by Rāma Kamala Sen, prepared at the suggestion of a Revd. gentleman who was the father of a late Lieutenant-Governor of the North-Western Provinces.

47. Manoranjana Itihāsa by Tārā Chānd Datta, 1819. "The school-book Society alone had sold 18,000 copies" of the book before 1854. The writer was in the employment of the late Captain Stewart of Burdwan.

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48. Rājā Kāli Kissen's—"A lithography of an Orrery," 1826.

49. Geography and eclipses by the same author, in 1836.

Geography.

50. Elementary Geography published by the Tatta Vodhini Sabhā, 1840.

51. Bhugola by Kṣetra Mohana Datta, 1840.

52. Geography of Asia and Europe by the Rev. K. M. Banerji, 1848.

53. Sandeçāvali—(Indian Gazetteer), pages 346, by Rāma Narsinha Ghoṣa.

54. Map of the world—the first specimen of a map engraved in Bengali,—executed by a Bengalee Kāçi Nātha under the superintendence of C. Montague. 1821.

Geometry.

55. Geometry by K. M. Banerjee, 1846.

56. Bhuvana Parimāṅa Vidyā (Land surveying) by Vraja Mohana, 1846.

Miscellaneous.

57. Chittotkarṣa Vidhāna—a philosophical work by the Rev. K. M. Banerji, pages 600 in two volumes, 1849–50.

58. Phrenology by Radhā Vallaba Dās, 1850.

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59. Bramly Vaktrita or Dr. Bramly's speeches by Udaya Charana Adhya, 1836.

60. Atma Rakṣā by Rājā Kriṣṇa Mukherjee. Compiled from Nidāna, 1849.

61. Dravya Guṅā by Içvara Chandra Bhattācharyya, 1835.

62. Auṣadha Kalāpāvali by Madhu Sudana Gupta, 1849, pages 244.

63. Jala Chikitsā (water cure) by Prema Chānd Chaudhuri, 1850. The writer professes having experienced wonderful benefits from Hydropathy; he points out its advantages to others in the various uses of water applied internally and externally to different parts of the body for costiveness, fever,

rheumatism, measles, small-pox, dysentery, etc. He fortifies his arguments by quotations from the Hindu medical Çāstras.

Periodicals and Magazines.

1. Dikdarçana by Çrirāmapore Missionaries, 1818.

2. Gospel Magazines, 1823.

3. Brāhmanical Magazine by Rāma Mohana Ray, 1821.

4. Çāstra Prakāça, 1851.

5. Jnānodaya by R. C. Mitter, 1831.

6. Vijnāna Sevadhi by Gangā Charana Sen, 1832.

7. Jnāna Sindhu Taranga by Rasika Mallick, 1832.

8. Four-anna Magazine, 1833.

9. Vidyā Sāra Saṁgraha, 1834.

10. Vidyā Darçana by Akṣaya Kumara Datta, 1834.

11. Vidya Darçana by Prasanna Kumāra Ghose.

12. Kaustabha Kiraṅa by Rāja Nārāyaṅa Mitra, 1846.

13. Jagatvandhu Patrikā edited by the students of the Hindu College, 1846.

14. Satya Sanchārini by Çyāmā Charṅa Bose, 1846.

15. The Kāyastha Kiraṅa, 1846. It gives translations from the Puraṅas and advocates the claims of Kayasthas to wear the Brahmanical thread.

16. The Durjana Damana Navami by Thākur Dās Bose, (Tri-monthly), 1846;—opposed Young Bengal, defended idolatry, had as its symbol the picture of a cross fastened by a charm to signify that it would restrain Christian influence.

17. Hindu Dharma Chandrodaya by Hari Nārāyaṅa Gosvāmi.

18. Jnāna Sanchāriṅī—organ of the orthodox community, 1847.

19. The Kāvya Ratnākara, edited by the students of the Hindu College, 1847.

20. Muktāvali by Kali Kānta Bhattachāryya. Commenced at the instigation of Rāja Nārāyan of Andul, opposed the right of Kāyasthas to wear the Brahmanical thread, 1848.

21. Bhakti Suchaka by Rāma Nidhi, 1848.

22. Rasa Ratnākara by Jadu Natha Pal, 1849.

23. Satjnana Ranjana by Govinda Chandra Gupta, 1849.

24. Duravikṣanikā by Dvārikā Natha Mazumder, 1850.

25. Dharma Marma Prakāçikā from Konnagar, 1850.

News papers.

1. Bengal Gazette by Gangādhar Bhattāchāryya, 1816.

2. The Çri Rāmapore Darpaṅa, 1818.

3. The Kaumudi, edited by Rāma Mohana Ray and Bhavāni Banerjee, 1819.

4. Chandrikā by Bhavāni Charan, 1822. It was for many years the native "Times of Calcutta."

5. Timira Nāçaka by Kriṣṇa Mohana Dās. 1823.

6. Vanga Dūta by Nila Ratana Hāldār. 1825.

7. Sudhākara by Prema Chānd Ray, 1830.

8. Prabhākara by Iṣvara Chandra Gupta, 1830.

9. Sabha Rājendra by Maulvi Ālimolla, 1821.

10. The Jnānāṅveṣaṅa by Rasika Mallik and Dakṣina Mukherjee, students of the Hindu College, 1831.

11. The Ratnākara by Vraja Mohona Sinha. 1831.

12. The Sāra Saṁgraha by Veni Madhava De, 1831.

13. Ratnāvali by Jagannatha Mullik, 1832.

14. Sudhāṁçu by Kali Kinkara Datta, 1835.

15. Divākara by Gangā Narayan Bose, 1837.

16. Saudāmini by Kāli Chandra Datta, 1838.

17. Guṅākara by Giriça Chandra Bose, an ex-student of the Hindu College, 1858.

18. The Mrityunjaya by Pārvati Charaṅa Datta, 1838.

19. The Rasarāja by Gauri Çankara Bhattā-chāryya, 1839.

20. Aruṅodaya by Jagannārāyaṅ Mukherjee, 1839.

21. The Murshidābād Patrikā, 1840.

22. Jnāna Dipikā by Bhagavata Charaṅa, 1840.

23. Sujana Ranjana by Govinda Chandra Gupta, 1840.

24. Bhārata Vandhu by Çyāmā Charaṅa Banerjee, 1841.

25. Niçākara by Nīlāmvara Dās, 1841.

26. The Bhringā Dūta by Nīlakamala Dās.

27. Rāja Rāni by Gangā Narayaṅa Bose, 1844.

28. Jayadā Dīpaka by Maulvi Āli, 1846.

29. The Mārttanda, 1846.

30. The Jnāna Darpaṅa by Umā Kanta Bhattacharyya, 1846.

31. The Pāṣandakiraṅa by Içvara Chandra Gupta, 1846.

32. Rungpur Vārttavaha by Nīla Ratan Mukherjee, 1847.

33. Jnāna Sancharinī from Kānchdāpaḍa, 1847.

34. Sudhi Ranjana by Içvara Chandra Gupta, 1847.

35. Ākkala Guḍum by Vraja Nātha, 1847.

36. The Dikvijaya by Dwaraka Natha Mukherjee, 1847.

37. Jnananjana by Chaitanya Charaṅa Adhikāri, 1847.

38. Sujana Vandhu by Nivaraṅa Chandra De, 1847.

39. The Manoranjana by G. C. De, 1847.

40. The Jnana Rātnakara by Viçvamvara Ghoṣe, 1848.

41. Dinamaṅī (scandalous), 1848.

42. The Ratna Varṣaṅa by Madhavā Chandra Ghoṣe of Bhowanipur, 1848.

43. Rasa Sāgara by Rāma Gopala Banerjee of Kidderpore, 1848.

44. The Aruṅodaya by Panchānana Banerjee, 1848.

45. Rasa Mudgara—advocated Hinduism, by Kṣetra Mohona Banerjee 1849.

46. The Mahajana Darpaṅa by Jaya Kali Basu, 1849.

47. The Satya Dharma Prakāçika—an organ of the Kartā-bhajās.

48. Varaṅaçi Chandrodaya.

49. The Bhairāvananda, 1849,—both edited by Umā Çankar Bhattāchāryya, a blind scholar who helped Rājā Jaya Nārāyaṅa in his translation of Kāçi Khanda.

50. Vardhamāna Chandrodaya by Rāma Tārana Bhattāchāryya, 1850.

51. Vardhamāna Samvāda, 1850.

III. General remarks chiefly indicating the characteristics of the new age and its contrast with the earlier one.

The growth of the modern literature.

These are some of the products of the literary labours of our countrymen in the vernacular tongue under the intellectual stimulus of the first contact with Europe. They continued the work with an ardour which has grown without intermission, and our present day literature is the richest among the vernaculars of India in quality and in its many-sided activity. The lists I furnish embrace the literature of a period ending 1850, but it is only at and after

the middle of the 19th century that we can see the full harvest grown from the seeds sown at the beginning. The works on various subjects written in Bengali after the model of European works abound like "leaves by the streams of Vallombrosa," and it will be a hard task for the historian of the present epoch of our literature to make his selection from amongst the very considerable materials which will be at his command.

The representative character of our past literature.

Bengali literature, previous to the advent of the Europeans on the field, was mainly in the hands of the Vaiṣṇavas and Çāktas. The songs of Kriṣṇa Kamala who belonged to the former and of Rāma Prasāda who belonged to the latter sect, are the last great utterances of the two cults, the echoes of which will ring in the ear of future generations of Bengalis for ages to come. The *yatrawalas*, *kaviwalas*, and *panchalikars* drew profusely from the vast resources of our past lore, and having put the old sentiments in modern garb appealed to our masses. But with these people the last echoes of our past literature have nearly died out. There are still *kirtanas*, *kathakatas* and *yatras*, but they no longer contribute to the rich literature of the past. They only recite what the old masters have sung or said, and are mere relics of institutions which were once a living force in the country.

The old literature of Bengal was a truly representative literature; Bhārata Chandra's writings and Ālāol's style, though so artificial and loaded with classical figures, were yet accessible to the masses of Bengal. The literature of the Bengalis belonged essentially to them all,—not to the literate

merely, but to the whole race. For hundreds of years its ideas had been made familiar to the whole country by innumerable ways and means. The whole race had assimilated these sentiments which found expression in their literature; and even the finished expressions, and the highly coloured metaphors that had characterised the productions of latter-day Sanskritic Bengali were not unintelligible to the people. The best evidence of this statement will be found in the fact that very low classes of men and even those who are thoroughly illiterate, have preserved up to the present, works like the Padmāvat which are still being printed for them. This shows great advancement on the part of the people in mastering a highly wrought literary style, and the past literature of Bengal was the medium through which the words of her poets and scholars were communicated to the lowly, the humble and the poor, who, often without knowing the alphabet, could understand the most difficult points in the Hindu philosophy or poetry under the educative influences of their own heredity and environment.

The old school upset.

But towards the end of the 18th century the Vaiṣṇavas and the Çāktas were practically driven out of the field. Our vernacular literature passed into the hands of Europeans; and they trained a class of people to write manuals and school books after the manner of their own standard works. Mr. Wilkins trained Panchānana Karmakāra in the art of punch-cutting, but this was not all; it was the Europeans and chiefly the missionaries who trained the Pundits to write Bengali,—not

as they would have it, but as their European masters wanted it.

The Vaiṣṇavas and the Çāktas, who had hitherto been at the helm of our literature, inspite of their occasional indulgence in ornamental style, always meant their works for readers who would understand them. But the great Sanskrit scholars, the Bhattāchāryyas, as the *Tol* pundits were called, had hitherto nothing to do with vernacular literature. They were now considered fit to write in the vernacular tongue on account of their proficiency in Sanskrit. Their classical accomplishments, however, proved an utter disqualification for the purpose.

We have seen that the specimens of early Bengali prose that have come down to us were all written in simple language. They were generally used for the interpretation of the doctrines of particular creeds or of Sanskrit texts. So the writers found it expedient to adopt popular language.

The Bhattāchāryyas

But the Bhattāchāryyas not accustomed to write Bengali showed the defects and faults of untrained hands. They affected a pedantic style which sounded strange to the Bengali ear. In their efforts to display their great learning they wrote in a ridiculous style which was difficult not only to foreign people but also even to Bengalis themselves. The pedantry of the old school of poetry, though sometimes carried to excess, had in it elements which suited the genius of our language. It was absurd in some places, but it was a natural though a peculiar growth. The pedantry of the Bhattāchāryyas on the other hand—the vollies of

high sounding compounds that they poured out—were unbearable in our language. It was as if giants had been let loose; and the artistically decorated gardens, into which they had found entry, could ill bear their heavy and unwieldy tread. We quote here a few specimens of their style. The great Pundit Mrityunjaya of the Fort William College, whom Dr. Marshman compared to Johnson in all respects, wrote in his Pravodha Chandrikā.

Specimens of their style.

" কোকিল কলালাপ বাচাল যে মলয়াচলনিল সে উচ্ছলচ্ছী-করাতাচ্ছ নিকরাস্তঃ কণাচ্ছন্ন হইয়া আসিতেছে।*

In a translation of the Government Regulations and Laws entitled the Ādālata Timira Nāçana, by one Rāma Mohana Kay (he could not have possibly been the illustrious Rāma Mohana Roy) printed in 1828, we find a preliminary prayer in prose, addressed to God as follows:—

" বারংবার অপার জগদুদয়স্থিতিসংলয়াদি সাধারণকারণ মানস-বাক্‌পথাতীত পরমাদ্ভুতবিবিধবিচিত্রচিন্তাতীত পরাৎপরানন্ত বৈভবানুক্ষণ বিস্তারক অবিরতাধ্যাত্মিকাদিবহুবিধতাপকলাপ-কবলিত-বিকলিত-মানস-মানবসমূহনিস্তারক পরমকারুণিক মনু-জাণ্ডজ বিবিধস্থলচরজলচরাকাশচর কীটপতঙ্গাদিজীবকৃত

*"The Malaya breeze, resounding with the warbles of the cuckoo, is becoming drenched with the transparent particles of the ever-flowing sprays of water.

†" To him who is the cause of the creation, of the preservation and of the final dissolution of the universe which occurs again and again in cycles—who is beyond all comprehension and [illegible] no language can express,—no thought however subtle can reach,—to Him who is the saviour of all men, ground down and distressed by Providential and physical and other evils, who is mercy itself and the one great equitable Judge of the deeds

সতত সদসদ্বিচারক জগদেকনিয়ামক বিশ্বোপকারার্থ দিনকর-নিশাকরাসংখ্যেয় তারকাদ্যনিশবিভ্রমকারক সদাচারনিরত সর্ব্বজ্ঞমানমোদক তৎকর্ত্তৃক নিখিলকার্য্যান্দৃষ্টা শ্রবণমননদ্বারা অকিঞ্চিৎস্বরূপাভাসমাত্র রূপকাখিলাধ্যক্ষের প্রতি গণণাতিরিক্ত প্রণতিপূর্ব্বক বিশিষ্টশিষ্ট সদসদ্বিচারকমহাশয়সমূহ সমীপেষু বহুতর বিনয়পুরঃসর নিবেদন।"

All this is a single sentence, which moreover is not yet complete: it appears like some monstrous sea-reptile coiling into a thousand folds and dragging itself to an appalling length.

Praphulla Jnāna-netra.

The author of "Praphulla Jnānanetra" is Içāna chandra Banerjee This writer grievously errs in every sentence in spelling, yet poses as a great and erudite scholar. His address to Hare Krisna Addy in the dedication shows that, however inferior may be his qualifications, he desires to surprise the readers by his pedantry.

"আপনকার সাহার্য্যতরণী কর্ত্তৃক গভীর তিমির দুস্তার অজ্ঞানার্ণব হইতে নিস্তার পাইয়া"

(which means.—'being enabled to cross the illimitable and the deep sea of ignorance by the boat of thine help).'

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virtuous or otherwise of men, of the oviparous, acquatic, and amphibious animals, of worms and birds,—to Him who is the great law-maker of the universe, who for the good of the world created the moving celestial bodies—the sun, the moon and the innumerable stars, who observes all, and only a glimpse of whose attributes is obtained by our perception of sight, hearing etc.,—after offering numberless salutations to that great Master of the universe, next with humility and respect do I approach the benevolent judges of right and wrong with the prayer that—."

Sarvāmoda Tarangini.

In "Sarvāmoda Tarangini" written in 1850,—a work expounding theistic principles, we find "সর্ব্বোপাস্য সর্ব্বশক্তিমান সর্ব্বান্তর্য্যামী সর্ব্বস্বামী সর্ব্বভূতের কর্ত্তা পাতা বিধাতাকে সর্ব্বতোভাবে প্রণাম পূর্ব্বক সর্ব্বামোদতরঙ্গিণী নামক গ্রন্থ প্রকাশ করিতেছি।"

Representative character lost

The whole literature of the period abounds with such absurd instances of pedantry. They are specimens of composition by untrained hands. Those who were the natural leaders, so long acknowledged to be the masters of the vernacular style of composition,—at whose hands and by whose disinterested and self sacrificing labour Bengali literature had flourished and attained distinction,—the Vaiṣṇava and Çākta writers were ousted from the field, and in their place the Tol pundits, who knew nothing of our past literature, whose study was confined to Sanskrit, were called in to write Bengali books; the result was that their unwieldy style and its uncouth form struck a discordant note to the spirit of our language. Besides, the subject-matter which they chose was all upon the model of European books. This naturally failed to appeal to our masses unacquainted with the new spirit which was inspiring the authors of our modern prose. Modern literature thus lost that representative character which the yellow leaves of the old Mss. had so pre-eminently possessed. A foreign plant was, as it were, engrafted on an old tree and it required years for the graft to grow and become a true and living branch of our literature.

and the link broken.

The old school had been a homogeneous creation; one would hear the echoe of Vidyāpati, who

died 400 years ago, in Bhārata Chandra who lived 250 years after. The choes of Chandi Dās's songs, sung 500 years ago, were traceable in the lays of the modern *kaviwala* ; and the joys and sorrows, pain and pleasures, embodied in the Bengali literature extending over a period of 700 years worked in the minds of the whole Bengali race and found a ready response from every soul. The niceties and even the pedantry of our past literature proved no barrier, as I have said, to our masses in enjoying the productions of the artificial school of poetry which grew up under circumstances natural to the soil. But now the link was suddenly snapped. Our old literature was, as it were, walled up, and a new one substituted which the people found inaccessible to them, and thus Bengalis ceased for half a century to understand the written Bengali of this age,—a time required by the masses to train themselves up to the new style and to the new subject matter. Even now the works of some of our best modern poets, wrought in the simplest of terms, seem unintelligble to a large section of the people, because of the European ideas in them with which they are not familiar ; and yet these readers can scale all the heights of the mystic metaphors of Bhārata Chandra and Ālāol.

Admixture of Persian.

Persian scholars no less than Sanskrit-knowing pundits contributed their share towards making the style of modern prose in its early stages, cumbersome and corrupt to a degree : and we have found such specimens of writing in Rāma Rāma Vasu's Pratāpāditya printed at Çrirāmapore Press in 1800 A.D. Lipimālā or model letters by this author

shows a style which was in current use in the country for long years. The epistles on mercantile and state affairs show a greater preponderance of Persian words, whereas the correspondence of a domestic and personal nature and those on religious subjects were generally free from such admixture. The addresses to high personages contained stereotyped sentences which were full of corrupt Sanskrit words. The form seems to have come down from a very remote age. Here is a curious specimen of the usual form of one Rājā addressing another. We take the extract from the Lipimālā.

Lipimālā.

"রাজাধিরাজ হিন্দুস্তানমাঝ যাহা দর্পময় ক্ষমা অতিশয় সরলান্তকরণ রূপ হেমবরণ শক্তিমন্ত ধীর অতি মহাবীর আত্ম-লোকপাল বৈরীমর্দ্দকাল শ্রীমান গুণধর মহারাজ রাজেশ্বর রাজচক্রবর্ত্তীর সাহায্য লিপি লেখা যাইতেছে।"

When Bengali literature had been thus placed in inexpert hands and committed to pedantic follies from which there seemed no way of its resuscitation, the European writers of Bengali cut a new channel of their own and made the style of vernacular prose flow into it; it was thus saved from the mazy and intricate paths of involved sentences and compound words in which it had entangled itself. The European writers naturally chose simple and short sentences and colloquial words and obliged the pundits to write in a similar style. However high a pundit might soar in the atmosphere of classical learning, he certainly knew the colloquial dialect of his country, though he had hitherto treated it with great contempt and had never thought of adopting it as a medium for literary composition. We find Dr.

The colloquial style favoured by the Europeans.

Carey employing Pundits to write a portion of his colloquies in Bengali, and even Mrityunjaya, the great scholar was made to introduce a colloquial style into his Pravodha Chandrika. Side by side with his উচ্ছলচ্ছিকরাত্যচ্ছ নিঝরান্ত কণাচ্ছন্ন হইয়া আসিতেছে" we find :—

* "স্ত্রী কহিল, গুড় হইলেই কি রাঁধা হয়? তৈল নাই, লুন নাই, চাউল নাই, তরকারী পাতি কিছুই নাই। কাঠগুলি সকলি ভিজা, বেসাতি বা কিরূপে হবে * * * কুটনা বা কে কুটিবে, বাটনা বা কে বাটিবে? তৎপতি কহিল, আজ কি ঘরে কিছুই নাই, দেখ দেখি খুদ কুঁড়া যদি কিছু থাকে, তবে তার পিঠা কর, এই গুড় দিয়া খাইব। ইহাতে তাহার স্ত্রী কহিল, বটে পিঠা করা বুঝি বড় সহজ? জান না, পিঠা আঠা; যেমন আঠা লাগিলে শীঘ্র ছাড়ে না, তেমনি পিঠার লেঠা বড় লেঠা, শীঘ্র ছাড়ে না। কখনো ত রাঁধিয়া খাও নাই। আর লোকদের মাউগের মতন মাউগ পাইয়া থাকিতে, তবে জানিতে।"

The great Pundit Mrityunjaya, who could discourse on all the six systems of Hindu philosophy, would hardly have condescended to adopt the despised *patois* of the country and choose such an humble subject for treatment, had it not been set

* "The mistress of the house said 'Is molasses the only thing required for cooking? There is no oil, no salt, no rice, no vegetable of any kind: the fuel is wet. What about the spices? My son's wife is out of health and cannot work. Who will grind the spices and who prepare the vegetables? Her Lord said, 'Look closely; is nothing available in the house? See, woman, if you can find out some refuse rice and make cakes with it. We shall take them with molasses.' The mistress said, 'Indeed, is the preparation of cakes so simple then? They say that the making of cakes is like putting gum in the hands, if once it sticks, it takes a good deal of time to clean it off. Cake preparation takes much time and is full of trouble. You never cooked anything in your life, husband, therefore you speak so foolishly. Had you had an ordinary woman for your wife you would by this time, no doubt, have had much bitter experience.'"

on him as a task by the European masters of Fort William College.

The European's Bengali.

It was unavoidable that European's writing in Bengali would now and then commit mistakes of idiom. Instances of translating 'গোপাল উড়ের যাত্রা' as 'the flying journey of Gopala' and 'বীচি বিক্ষেপ হইতেছিল না' as 'did not shed its seeds' or 'bad humours of the body' as 'শরীরের দুষ্ট রসিকতা' and similar writings which would amuse every Bengali, abound in the prose writings of the foreign scholars; and if they had had occasion to cultivate our language with the earnestness with which we are acquiring English, it is certain that we should have had as ample materials at our command to amuse ourselves as the ridiculers of "Babu English" have at theirs.

Errors in idioms.

We find in the Sarasamgraha by the Rev. Yates D. D, a very good scholar of Bengali, such lines as "ভ্রমণের দ্বারা তাহাদের মন প্রফুল্ল ও উত্তম হইতে পারে এবং অনেক অনেক বিবেচনার কথা উপস্থিত হইতে পারে." The writer confounds চিন্তা with বিবেচনা in the last line. In a Bengali vocabulary the difference in meaning of the two words is not indicated; and it is only to be known by a mastery of the idiom, hence this writer fell into such an error.

In a grammar of the Bengali language by the Rev. J. Keith, we find the following curious specimen :—

নিত্যশুদ্ধ ভূতকাল।

একবচন	বহুবচন
আমি করা যাইতেছিলাম	আমরা করা যাইতেছিলাম
তুমি করা যাইতেছিলা	তোমরা করা যাইতেছিলা
তিনি করা যাইতেছিলেন	তাহারা করা যাইতেছিলেন

In Satguṅa O Viryyer Itihāsa written in 1829 by a Çrirampur missionary, we come across the following sentences on the title page :

"সকল লোকের হিতার্থে বাঙ্গালা ভাষায় তর্জ্জমা করা গেল . তাহার একদিকে ইংরাজী ও এক দিকে বাঙ্গালা" ।

General excellence of style.

But inspite of these unavoidable defects met with now and then in the use of Bengali idioms, the vernacular style of the foreign writers commended itself generally for its simplicity, closeness of argument, and directness as contrasted with the high flown unmeaning jargons of scholarly pedants : and the latter had gradually to adopt the simpler style of the European which erred occasionally in idiom, but was, generally speaking, correct and elegant.

Indirect benefit.

The indirect benefit derived from the writing of vernacular works by Europeans was great, for they controlled Bengali prose ; and though it was taken out of the hands of the Vaiṣṅavas and the Çāktas, it came once more to competent hands, who made it a vehicle of thought and not a show thing to be admired for artistic excellence or rendered too abstruse for popular understanding by pedantic follies.

Europeans ceased to take the great interest in the vernacular literature as they had done in the first half of the 19th century, only when the native hand grew sufficiently strong to take up the work in right earnest, and this our country men ere long did, even beyond all expectations of their friendly patrons.

Scientific and technical terms.

The great zeal of the European writers of Bengali prose is evidenced by the fact that Mr. Felix Carey coined scientific and technical terms

for writing on those subjects in Bengali. How far he succeeded in his attempt is not the question, but it shows the ardour of his soul in attempting to bring the vernacular language of Bengal up to the standard of the advanced languages of the world. In the descriptive catalogue of Bengali by the Rev. J. Long, we find the following reference to this fact,—"Goldsmith's History of England (Bengali translation of) came out in 1819. Pages 412, by Felix Carey, an able Bengali scholar, the history closes with the peace of Amiens in 1802. A useful glossary of technical and difficult words was appended, though some names are rendered curiously. Admiral of the Blue is Nilpatakādhyernaya, Whig is Svātantra Pakṣapāti." "Haḍāvali or Anatomy by Carey. The glossary of the technical terms by the translator Felix Carey, a good Bengali scholar, is of use to translators."

Books in colloquial style.

Under European influence a taste for writing in the colloquial language came into considerable favour; and writings like Ālāler Gharer Dulāla and Hutum Pechār Naksā, which are usually supposed to be our first attempts at witty writing in the colloquial dialect, were preceded and anticipated in style by numerous works which served as models to Tek Chānd Thākur and Kāli Prasanna Siṁha in later times. Some of these earlier works reached a high level of success and were very popular at one time. Nowhere in the whole range of colloquial literature of this epoch, do we find a better sample of style or display of naive humour, and of scathing satire than in the Nava Bābu Vilāsa or sketch of a modern Babu by Pramatha Nāth Çarmā, published in 1823. The Rev. J. Long in 1855 wrote

The ablest satire of the time.

of this book as "one of the ablest satires of the Calcutta Babu as he was thirty years ago. New editions of the work are constantly issuing from the press. The Babu is depicted as germinating, blossoming in flower, in fruit. The Babu under Guru Mahāçaya, under the Munsi, devoted to licentiousness and his lament for past folly. It is a kind of Hogarth's Rake's Prayers." The book was analysed at length in the Quarterly Friend of India, 1826.

I quote below an extract from this book. There is no need for any comment on the corrupt taste which prevails in it—which was the vice of the age and the spirit of the time.

* "Then came dancing girls—three or four parties of them—a glorious band,—those who generally appear in the foremost row of a marriage procession and, riding on Taktāramā (a state *palkee*), dance to the admiration of the on-lookers. When all had joined the party, the Babu with his Chādar on his neck, as a sign of humility, and with clasped palms, addressed Baknā Piary and other dancing girls,—the best of their kind, reputed far and wide, and worshipped by the public, and said

* "আর যাহারা বিবাহাদি সময় রাস্তায় সর্ব্বাগ্রে তক্তারামায় আরোহণ করিয়া নৃত্য করে, এমত নর্ত্তকী প্রায় তিন চার সম্প্রদা আইল; তৎপরে সকলের আগমনান্তর বাবু জনসমাজ পূজ্যা বারাঙ্গনাগ্রগণ্যা বক্না পেয়ারী প্রভৃতির নিকট গললগ্নকৃতবাস হইয়া করপুটে কহিলেন "আপনারা স্নান করুন" তৎপরে অন্য ভক্তগণ আসিয়া বাবুর আজ্ঞামত আতর মর্দ্দন করাইলেক, কাঁচা-গোল্লা দিয়া মাথা ঘসাইয়া দিলেক, নির্ম্মল পুষ্করিণীর জল ক্রীড়াচ্ছলে কুতুহলে ভৃত্যগণের বহুসমাদরে ভক্তগণেরা গোলাপ জলে শরীর ধৌত করাইলেক। সেই সময়ে এক গাটি বস্ত্র

"Be pleased now to take a bath." The other admirers of these fair creatures appeared on the scene and at the request of the Babu rubbed perfumes on their delicate persons, and with Kānchāgolla (a rich pudding) cleaned their long black hair: the servants with a feeling of great reverence took them to tanks, and in a sportive spirit poured water upon their heads, and then come the admirers who bathed them with rose-water. At this stage the tailor came and produced a bundle of fine clothes. There were in the bundle beautiful Sāḍies made by the far-famed weavers of Çāntipur, Amvikā, Vādāgāchhi, Dacca, Chandrakonā, Khāsvāgān and other places. Some of these fine stuffs had beautiful borders in imitation of Kashmir shawls, others with borders in which the figures of crabs were neatly woven with the threads, and others where the amulet was imitated. These elegant borders were of different colours, purple, blue and crimson. The Barānagar striped Sadies looked particularly gay. These clothes were distributed by the tailor among the worthy votaries of the terpsichorean art. Then in the pleasure garden the Babu and his friends seated themselves on costly seats with the accomplished

The reception to the dancing girls.

আনিয়া উপস্থিত করিলেন। শান্তিপুর অম্বিকা, বাদাগাছি ঢাকা, চন্দ্রকোণা, খাসবাগান, বরাহনগর প্রভৃতি নানা স্থানের শাটী, শালপেড়ে, কাঁকড়াপেড়ে, লালপেড়ে, নীলপেড়ে, তারিজপেড়ে, বরানগরের, দূরে ব্যক্তিবিশেষে প্রদান করিলেন। তৎপরে আনন্দকাননে অপূর্ব্ব আসনে সজ্জন প্রফুল্ল বদনে বেশ্যাসমবিধানে উপবিষ্ট হইলেন, সেই আসনে ভৃত্যগণেরা নানাবিধ সুখাদ্য মিষ্টান্ন মদ্য মাংস আনিয়া প্রস্তুত করিলেক: ইতিমধ্যে এক নির্ব্বোধ পূর্ব্বদেশীয় বাঙ্গাল ব্রাহ্মণ কহিলেক, যে ভোজন কালে পৃথক পৃথক স্থানে করিতে হইবে। এমন সময়ে খলিফার কুলপুরোহিত

hirelings. The servants brought to them various kinds of sweetmeats, meat and wine in profuse quantities, when a fool of an East Bengal Brahmin said that there should be separate seats at dinner. Hearing this the high priest of the Babu—the jewel of the forehead of all *pandits*—stepped forward and said 'O thou the most despised of all mortals, dost thou not know the sacred books, dunce and illiterate as thou art? This is a Bhairavi *chakra* (a circle of the Tantricks), as people of various castes are present here and women have joined us. In a Bhairavi *chakra* no caste distinction should be observed. You want authority! Here it is :—

Upsetting of caste-rules in the Chakra.

Recites a Sanskrit couplet here which means ;—

'Those who join a Bhairavi *chakra*, whatever caste they may belong to, should be considered for the time as the best of Brahmins. They should all drink wine, till they turn tipsy and reeling fall to the ground and rise to drink again. If they do so they shall be free from all future births and attain final emancipation.'

"When authority had thus been quoted all were quite satisfied and the Hindus, Mahomedans and

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শিরোমণি কহিলেন "ওরে নরাধম মূর্খ শাস্ত্র জানিলি না, এক্ষণে এস্থল ভৈরবী চক্র বলা যায়, ভৈরবী চক্রে জাতিবিচার নাই। প্রমাণং যথা—

'আগতা ভৈরবীচক্রে সর্ব্বে বর্ণাঃ দ্বিজোত্তমাঃ
পীত্বা পীত্বা পুনঃ পীত্বা পুনঃ পততি ভূতলে
উত্থায় চ পুনঃ পীত্বা পুনর্জ্জন্ম ন বিদ্যতে'

ইত্যাদি প্রমাণ শুনিয়া সকলে হৃষ্টচিত্ত হইল। হিন্দু মুছলমান

women of ill fame sat together with a clear conscience, and began to eat various preparations of meat and other dainties with profuse quantity of wine."

A Seriocomic aspect.

The *Pundits* took up Bengali prose under the direction of European writers of Bengali; and under their direction also the former had to come down from high flown bombasts to colloquial simplicity. The best works produced by the *Pandits* during this epoch of our literature are characterised, on the one hand, by ascent to obscure heights and, on the other, by descent to slang;—from the cloudy region of philosophical dissertations to the housewife's harangue with her husband on the question of the preparation of cakes. There was no *via media*. When the theme soared high, it became mystic,—the phalanx of compound words scarcely left a loop-hole for the ordinary reader's understanding to penetrate into it; but when it came down from these heights it grovelled in the mire of vulgarity; street scenes were described in terse, forcible but exceedingly corrupt style; all limits of decency were exceeded on,—coarse and flat jokes passed for humour, and the Bengali prose of the period presented a seriocomic aspect which puzzles us in its seriousness and almost repels when it tries to amuse.

The good result.

But the advent of the *Pandits* into the field of Bengali, though associated in the earlier stages of its modern prose with uncouth efforts verging on

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বেশ্যা সাধারণ তাবতেই নির্ম্মলান্তঃকরণে একাসনে বিবিধ মদ্য মাংস প্রভৃতি নানা দ্রব্য ভোজন করিলেন।"

Babuvilas, Page 38.

the ridiculous, was not an unmixed evil. Their productions materially aided the cause of Bengali style in the long run. The *pundits* had a perfect command over the Sanskrit vocabulary and Sanskrit grammar and aimed at a pure grammatical style which was gradually introduced into Bengali prose, mainly through their influence and by their writings. Under the salutary control of the European scholars these *pundits* were trained to write in a simple style and they no longer despised the colloquial dialect from which they gradually imported a large number of simple and elegant expressions into the written language. Modern prose was developed both in purity of style and in resources of words by the efforts of these scholarly writers, and abundant proofs of this are to be found in the standard works of the 19th century, written by them. In the prose works of Içvara Chandra Vidyāsāgara we have that crowning success in prose composition to attain which the *pundits* had been struggling for half a century. The high sounding compounds were reduced in his writings to simpler and more elegant forms, the coarse and the vulgar element was entirely eliminated; and living at this distance of time, as we do, we cannot help being struck with the inimitable grace and purity of his style. He saved our prose alike from pedantry and vulgarity and adopted a golden mean which only a finished master of Sanskrit and gifted literature could have been capable of achieving.

The high price of printed books.

The printing of Bengali books was a costly affair in those days. We have seen that Dr. Carey calculated the cost of printing ten thousand copies of the Bengali New Testament at Rs. 43750, and

that even, at the wrong estimate of the cost of a punch as 5*s.* whereas it was really a guinea. Considering the enormous expenditure on printing as also the very limited sale of Bengali books, we should not be surprised at the high price set on many of the books of this period; for instance Mitter's Bengali Dictionary was published in 1801, "equal to an 8vo of 50 pages": the price was Rs. 32. Tara Chand Chakravarty's Anglo Bengali Dictionary: pages 25, price Rs. 6. "The original price of Kṛiṣṇa Chandra Charita by Rajiva Lochana Rs. 5 only for 120 pages. It barely paid its expenses then, so limited was the demand for Bengali books."

Journals edited by students.

The energetic devotion displayed in the cause of learning by the students of the Hindu College under the influence of Dr. Richardson and Mr. D'Rozario is evidenced in the list of Bengali newspapers and magazines of this period already given on a foregoing page. Along with a hundred other channels into which that energy flowed for promoting the cause of learning, no less than four journals (Nos. 13, 19 pp. 908-909 and Nos. 10 and 17 p. 911,) were edited and conducted by the students of the Hindu College.

The excellence of the Hindu method in arithmetic.

It is curious to observe that when the English were introducing European educational methods into our schools, they were frequently struck with the excellence of the Hindu method of teaching already current in our Pāthaçālās, and this they freely admitted. An English writer in the London Asiatic journal, 1817, bestows a high panegyric on the arithmetical rules set to doggerel rhymes by Çubhankara who is said to have been "the Cocker of



Duke Henry Monmouth &c.

Specially [illegible] Mr. [illegible] painting
at Ditton Monmouth. By kind permission of Mr. [illegible] N. Champion

Bengal." "These rules" wrote another English reviewer in the middle of the 19th century "have been chanted for 150 years in 40,000 schools. Thus the Hindus took the lead in a practice which have been since introduced into our infant schools." In the May-Gaṅita printed at Çrirāmapore in 1817, the author, Mr. May, says of the Çubhankari Aryyās in his preface to the book :—"It is remarkable that many coincidences may be traced between them and the most improved kind of arithmetical tables adopted in the schools in Britain on the new model."

IV (a) Decadance of the high spiritual ideal in Hindu Society, and the advent of Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy.

A touch from outside.

When Buddhism had sunk into depraved Tantrik rites, sophistry and atheism, the Hindu Society awaited but a touch from outside for blossoming into that living faith which is so preeminently observed in the lives of Chaitanya and Nānaka. The Renaissance brought about by the great Çankara required only a touch with the faith of Islam to develop the creed of faith into the creed of love, which in the 16th century showed itself in the glories of renunciation and the spiritual ecstasies of so many ardent souls. Similarly also when towards the end of the 18th century, the religion of the Hindus was more or less reduced to superstitious practices, and empty ceremonies, and ritual, Hindu society required only a touch from outside to be restored to a realisation of high spiritual truths. The Christian Missionaries awakened the spirit of research into religious truth

once more in the minds of our countrymen, who were never found slow to respond to a call for putting forth their best activity in the cause of religion.

The simple ways taught by Chaitanya Deva, of reciting the name of God and of praying to Him in the spirit of true renunciation had gradually fallen into disfavour. Pompous processions and great festivities accompanied with dances of *nauch* girls and display and flourish of materialistic grandeur now attracted people to religion, which had, however, lost its serious character, and become a source of amusement to the vulgar. The great devotees had already begun to realise the uselessness of a multiplicity of religious rites, and the vanity which in many cases prompted the ostentation of religious festivals in Bengal. Rājā Rāma Kriṣṇa expressed the idea in one of his songs that he would fling away his rosary into the waters of the Ganges as soon as true devotion for the divine Mother should dawn on his mind,—thus showing an utter disregard of formal observances in religion; and Rāma Prasada, already quoted on page 716, said of himself that he was a fool to worship an image of clay, when his divine Mother was manifesting herself throughout the whole universe. He said how foolish it was to kill goats before the image instead of sacrificing the passions—his real enemies, and that it was but so much energy wasted to visit the sacred shrines. If one's mind is fixed on the lotus feet of the Mother, there he will feel all the sanctity of the Ganges and of the holy cities of Benares and Gaya.

Ostentation in religion.

Severe codes for petty offences.

Violation of petty rules was regarded as a great sin in the code of the Brahmins. "That infidel who has not cleansed his teeth before sunrise, has no right to worship God."* "One who takes Putikā (*Basella lucida* on the twelfth day of a lunation is worse than a murderer of Brahmins." "One who takes a meal while touching the seat with his feet is to be reckoned as a beef eater."†

"If one raises a cup of water with his left hand and drinks therefrom he commits the offence of him who drinks wine."‡

These were some of the rules for the guidance of a Hindu householder's life. "Murder, theft or perjury, though brought home to the guilty man by a judicial sentence, so far from inducing loss of caste, is visited in their society with no peculiar mark of infamy or disgrace. A trifling present to the Brahmin commonly called Prāyaçchitta, with the performance of a few idle ceremonies, are held as sufficient atonement for all those crimes: and the delinquent is at once freed from all temporal inconvenience as well as dread of future retribution."§

* "উদিতে জগতীনাথে যঃ কুর্য্াদ্দন্তধাবনম্।
স পাপিষ্ঠঃ কথংকৃতে পূজয়ামি জনার্দ্দনম্॥"

Smriti.

† Raja Rama Mohana Roy's Bengali works edited by Raja Narayan Bose p. 620.

‡ Raja Rama Mohana Roy's Bengali works, published from the Panini Karyalaya, Allahabad, page 228.

§ Raja Rama Mohana Roy's English works, published by Cri Kanta Roy vol. I, p. 203.

The plant Tulasi is sacred with the Vaiṣṇavas and the Bel tree with the Çaivas. When regarded in the light of simple devotion and as possessed of emblematic significance, these plants have a charm for the Hindus which is indescribable. When the pious wife lights the evening lamp at the foot of the sacred Tulasi, the darkness of evening yields to that quiet light glittering through the leaves, and the vermillion-marked forehead bends low in the act of making obeisance to the deity whose symbol it is, the small scene breathes poetry to the soul which feels in its presence as before some alter; but when the atrocious Brahminic code lays down "the great sinner who seeing a *Bilva* tree or a *tulasi* plant does not instantly bow down, will be sent to hell and be afflicted with leprosy,"* —the poetry and spirituality of the whole vanishes, and our mind revolts against such ordinances and feels strongly against Brahminic tyranny. The horrid hook-swinging festivity called the Chadaka, the custom of throwing children to the Sāgara, human sacrifices offered to Kāli and other atrocious ceremonies performed under the sanction and control of the Brahmins compelled our enlightened rulers to check them by enacting new laws, and if the missionaries were unsparing in their abuses of our religion and called us semi-barbarious, they were justified in their condemnation of the crimes that pervailed in the lower stratum of our society.

* "বিল্বং বা তুলসীং দৃষ্ট্বা ন নমেদ্যো নরাধমঃ।
সযাতি নরকং ঘোরং মহারোগেণ পীড্যতে॥

Skanda Purāṅa.

The pure faith promulgated by Chaitanya was now giving its last flicker. In the lower order of the Vaiṣṇava community men and women mixed promiscuously and, interpreting the emblematical religion in the light of gross sensualism, preached unrestrained licentiousness; and the cries of those who were forcibly made to play *sutties*,—though subdued and unheard owing to the noisy music deliberately kept to drown them, rose to heaven where the Lord heard them though men would not. The missionaries drew attention to these matters. Such were some of the superstitions and crimes that pervaded the whole of our society at the moment we are considering. Young men of the new generation, who had not fathomed the depths of religious life that still pervaded the quiet villages of Bengal inspite of their superstitions, ran to the extreme, and in the general sweep of their reformatory procedures turned their backs upon good and evil alike, indiscriminately condemning all in their own society. They did not wish to reform but aimed at totally upsetting society, which, though in its lower grades showed Brahminical craft and oppression, had in its great heights—on its topmost pinnacles, an unequalled glory which is conspicuous in the doctrines of love and renunciation inculcated by the Vedanta.

Leanings towards Christianity.

Young men saw wrongs on all sides and did not care to hear of the speculative theology of the Hindus or to keep the patience to scale its great height themselves. They felt that Christianity was better than their own religion owing to the moral principles which were a living force amongst its votaries. "Young Bengal" showed a decided leaning towards the new creed.

Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy.

At this juncture stepped forward Rāma Mohana Roy, born at the village of Rādhānagar in the district of Hughli in the year 1774,—the year in which the great Rāma Prasāda Sen died at Hālisahara.

(b) A comprehensive review of his life and work.

A born fighter.

As I look upon the portrait of Rājā Rāma Mohana, with his huge turban on his head, his loose flowing garments, his dark eye brows bent in serious thought and his brilliant eyes with their meditative look,—a voluminous book held tightly in his right hand and lips which display determination and the power of persuasive eloquence, the high forehead beaming with intellectuality,—his tall robust figure erect to its full height,—he appears to me rather as a warrior bound for the battle field, than as a pious religious man—the part he chose to play in life.

He was in fact a born fighter. The combative element is not only found throughout his stupendous writings in English, Bengali, Sanskrit and Persian, but even in the hymns he offered to God. He could not forget the fighting and controversial spirit even when he was addressing praises to the Deity. Referring to the rite of *Prana pratistha* or "endowment of animation" and that of subsequently throwing the clay image in the water after the *puja* is over, Rāma Mohana sings in one of his hymns "O deluded mind, whom do you invoke, and whom do you cast away." Again, dealing with the swinging ceremony in the Dolotsava he sings: "You want to swing him who moves the sun, the moon and the stars! How vain your efforts are! He

who feeds the beasts, and birds, fishes and men, how absurd it is to think of feeding him! The Deity who pervades the whole universe, with what propriety can you say to him 'stay here' (refers to the *mantra* ইহ তিষ্ঠ &c.)

"It is vain, if you do not accept the truth; it is like taking food through the nose when you are endowed with a mouth."*

When half a century before, Rāma Prasāda had composed songs in this strain, there had been a sincerity in his utterances, and there was no polemic spirit in them; he was actually engaged in all the multifarious ritual of Hindu worship, and passing through them as an orthodox Hindu, he only refreshed his consciousness of the clay image as an emblem by referring to the monotheistic views which he really held and realised through all the rites to which he had to conform outwardly. But Rājā Rāma Mohana had given up all such Hindu practices and declared them idolatrous. His hymn to the Deity in the passages quoted above

* "মন একি ভ্রান্তি তোমার
আবাহন বিসর্জ্জন কর তুমি কার?
চন্দ্র সূর্য্য গ্রহ যত,
যে চালায় অবিরত,
তারে দোলাইতে কত করহ যতন।
পশুপক্ষী জলচরে, যে আহার দেয় নরে,
চাহ সেই পরাৎপর করাতে ভোজন।
যে বিভু সর্ব্বত্র থাকে
ইহ তিষ্ঠ বল তাঁকে।"
"সত্য সূচনা বিনা সকলি বৃথায়
যেমন বদন থাকিতে অদন করা নাসিকায়।"

sounds the trumpet of battle: and though he apparently applied to himself the word 'deluded', it is really meant for those who held views in religion other than his own.

Throughout all his writings this combativeness is obvious. He probably felt it necessary for the times, believing that people had begun to accept the image as God Himself and forget that it was a mere emblem.

As a combatant he was superior to most who came in contact with him, not only by the strong and forcible manner in which he marshalled his arguments, based on a learning which was most extraordinary, but in the equanimity of temper that he preserved throughout all controversy. Seldom or never did he resort to the language of abuse so freely indulged in against him by his opponents. He was master of many languages,—Hebrew, Greek, Persian, English, Sanskrit, Arabic Hindusthani and Bengali, and knew something of French besides. The missionaries found in him a scholar who could point out flaws in their translations of the Bible and refer them to the original text in Hebrew, or Greek.* His antagonists were generally brought to their knees by the solid learning of the Rājā who, with all respect for the scriptures of different religions, assailed his opponents with ample quotations from the books held sacred by them, and beat them on their own ground in the most effective way. In

His European admirers.

* "He argues the matter very fairly and quotes with great ease and fluency the passages of both Old and New Testaments explaining some maltranslations of Hebrew which Trinitarians sometimes urged in their favour."

Monthly Repository, 1822.
Page, 754.

fact his giant intellect struck every one with the sense of his superiority, and the testimonies of admiration left by Europeans are even more laudatory than those which he received from his own countrymen. Sir John Bowring, while greeting him with an address of welcome from the Unitarian Society of London, said "I recollect some writers have indulged themselves with inquiring, what they should feel, if any of those time-honoured men, whose names have lived through vicissitudes of ages, should appear among them. They have endeavoured to imagine what would be their sensations if a Plato, or a Socrates, a Milton or a Newton, were unexpectedly to honour them with their presence. I recollect that a poet, who has well been called divine, has drawn a beautiful picture of the feelings of those who first visited the scenes of the southern hemisphere, and there saw, for the first time, that beautiful constellation, the Gold Cross. It was with feelings such as they underwent, that I was overwhelmed when I stretched out in your name the hand of welcome to the Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy."*

Dr. Booth, an American physician of London, wrote to Mr. Estlin on the 27th November, 1833. "I have studied his (Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy's) writings with a subdued feeling since his death and risen from their perusal with a more confirmed conviction of his having been unequalled in past or present time."† The Rev. J. Scott Porter said in a funeral sermon on the death of the Rājā—preached

* Monthly Repository, June, 1831. (Vol. V, pages 417-20.)
† Last days of Rama Mohana Roy by Mary Carpenter Page 174.

in the meeting-house of the first Presbyterian congregation, Belfast, on the 10th of November, 1833:—"Never have I known a person who brought a greater variety of knowledge to bear upon almost every topic on which he conversed, never one whose remarks were more original, solid and useful.....,—one of the most extraordinary men whom the world has witnessed for centuries." * The Rev. J. Fox spoke of the Rājā in his sermon delivered at Finsbury Chapel, South Place, on Sunday October 14, 1833, "His presence has passed away as a poetic image fades from the brain!..... And, 'being dead, he yet speaketh' with a voice to which not only India but Europe and America will listen for generations."† The Rev. R. Aspland preached a funeral sermon in the New Gravel Pit Meeting, Hackney, in the course of which he said "the name of Rāma Mohana Roy will endure as long as the history of religious truth."‡ Lieutenant-Colonel Fitzclarence, latterly Earl of Munster, wrote (in his Journal of a Route across India through Egypt to England in the years of 1817 and 1818). "The most extraordinary Brahmin..... His learning is most extensive, as he is not only conversant with the best books in English, Arabic, Sanskrit, Bengali and Hindusthani but has even studied rhetoric in Arabic and English, and quotes Locke and Bacon on all occasions."§ The English editor of the *India Gazette* referred to him while writing about his controversy with Dr. Marshman as "a most gigantic combatant in the theological

* Last days of Rama Mohana Roy Page 223.
† do. do. do. 242
‡ do. do. do. 203
§ do. do. do. 40

field."* Many English writers wrote verses on his death, and those by Miss Dale, Miss Acland, Mrs. Thomas Woodforde, the Rev. W. J. Fox, and Dr. Carpenter, quoted in 'The Last Days of the Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy' by Mary Carpenter, are not only exquisite as pieces of poetic composition, but also breathe those sentiments of profound love and respect, which his great personality raised in the minds of all who came in contact with him. The tender care with which he was attended by the ladies at Stapleton Grove during his last illness, and their tears at his death, lend deep pathos to the description of the scene of his death at Bristol; and our heart goes forth in gratitude to those kind friends of a foreign clime who not only appreciated the noble qualities of the great Indian but felt for him a veneration which annulled all distinctions of birth and associations.

In his controversies with the Çrirāmapore Missionaries, some of whom went the length of calling him a heathen, his mild answers bearing the impress of superior reasoning power, showed that he was a far better Christian in spirit than his adversaries; and the impression they made on the mind of the distinguished William Roscoe, who poured over the Rājā's Precepts of Jesus with admiring delight, amply testifies to the great appreciation of his writings throughout the whole of Christendom. Mr. Recorder Hill writes about his encounter with the celebrated Robert Owen† :—"one of the guests was Robert Owen who evinced a strong desire to

Robert Owen's defeat.

* Last days of Rama Mohana Roy, Page 17.
† do. do. do. 111.

bring over the Rājā to his socialistic opinions. He persevered with great earnestness, but the Rājā, who seemed well acquainted with the subject and who spoke our language in marvellous perfection, answered his arguments with consummate skill, until Robert somewhat lost his temper,—a very rare occurrence which I never witnessed before. The defeat of the kind hearted philanthropist was accompanied with great sauvity on the part of his opponent." Dr. T. Boot wrote about the Rājā to Mr. Estlin, in November 1833 :—"to me he stood in the single majesty of, I had almost said, perfect humanity, no one in past or present ever came to my judgment clothed in such wisdom, or humility." Another Englishman spoke of him as "a rare combatant. We are constrained to say he has not met with his match here." "It is well known" writes Mary Carpenter (p. 252) "that Mr. William Adam a Baptist of Çrirāmapore, who endeavoured to make him a convert to orthodoxy, concluded his task by acknowledging himself a convert to the true Evangelical opinions of the Rājā." The greatest philosopher of England at the time, Jeremy Bentham, gave him a cordial reception and addressed him as "intensely admired and dearly beloved collaborator in the service of mankind." "Your works," wrote Bentham to the Rājā, "are made known to me by a book in which I read a style which, but for the name of a Hindu, I should certainly have ascribed to the pen of a superiorly educated and instructed Englishman" and in the same letter while praising the great work of James Mill on the History of India, Bentham remarked "though as to the style I wish I could with truth and

Other European admirers.

sincerity pronounce it equal to yours."* The poet Campbell was also one of his great admirers. When he landed in England the Rājā met with a reception which only the most exalted men of Europe could expect to receive. He was presented to His Majesty the King by the President of the Board of Control and had a place assigned to him among the foreign ambassadors. The highest honours were publicly accorded to him. "Persons most remarkable for their social standing and literary eminence sought his society and highly esteemed the privilege of intercourse with him. He was received into our English homes not only as a distinguished guest but as a friend."† During his short stay at Paris he was more than once at the table of Louis Philippe. Wherever he went he had to attend meetings according him a most hearty and cordial reception. Mary Carpenter writes that she had herself met some of those "who still treasured the remembrance of the Rājā; one of these, now a grayheaded man, recollected when a young midshipman on arriving at Calcutta, going to visit the magnificent residence and grounds of the Brahmin who was even then celebrated. It was in the Circular Road at the Eastern extremity of the town. He did not see the master of the mansion, but he picked up in the large aviary a relic in remembrance of the distinguished man which he still treasures."‡

Reception in Europe.

A midshipman's recollections.

Social and religious reformation he chose as the chief object of his pursuit. His evidence before

* Bowring's works of Bentham, vol. X; page 586.
† Mary Carpenter's life of the Raja, page 65.
‡ Do. do. page 67.

Evidence before the select Committee.

the Select Committee of the House of Commons in England regarding the Judicial and Revenue system of India and his essay on the European colonisation show a masterly grasp of the subject as also the vast range of his study and minute observation in every detail of the administrative questions of the country, upon which the British press bestowed at the time their highest encomiums. His writing materially assisted the Government in enacting legislation for the administration of the country on a more solid and efficacious basis. His letter on the question of education preceded the memorable minute of Lord Macaulay and sounded the key note of the future educational policy of the Government.

On Education.

In fact in every department of thought, calculated to advance the cause of his countrymen, his great intelligence and zealous advocacy of all that he considered right have left a powerful impress. In all movements, whether of social or political nature, the start that he gave to the enlightened Hindu Society of Bengal has kept it going forward up to the present. Thoroughly acquainted with the political conditions in Europe, the sympathy of his great mind went forth to the cause of liberty and freedom, wherever it was at stake. His humane feelings were also as cosmopolitan. When on one occasion he attended divine worship at Carter Lane Chapel, the Minister was reading a letter from a clergyman in that quarter describing the sufferings of the poor people in the west of Ireland, then in a state of lamentable distress. Writes Mr. Poter on the occasion "the tears that fell from his, (Rājā's) eyes declared how deeply

Broad sympathy and cosmopolitan views.

he was moved by the reciter."* He materially contributed to the fund collected for affording them relief.

For women the sympathy of his heart was ever in readiness; and one, who reads his arguments in favour of the abolition of Suttee, cannot but be struck with the great humanity with which he advocated the cause, as also with the high reverence in which he held Indian women. When a pro-Suttee champion declared woman-kind as weak, frail and irreligious, his honest indignation burst forth in a glorious speech in which the sufferings, the devotion and the firmness of Hindu Women are so vividly represented, that no poet could do it in better language or in more effective form. He suffered all kinds of persecution, intolerance and abuses from his opponents who even tried to waylay and belabour him, but reading his answers to the charges made against him by orthodx Hindus, and even by the clergy, one is struck with his gentle and persuasive eloquence, his kindly words indicating a sweet and unruffled temperament. These are found in sharp contrast to the foul and wanton abuse of his antagonists. He himself says in some of his answers that as a child frets, when the well-meaning doctor gives him medicine, but the doctor heeds it not, even so does he treat those who without understanding his good intentions are crying down his works. He was never weary of arguing in favour of what he considered to be the truth. Such an untiring champion of truth is scarcely to be met with now. Mr. Arnot writes of him,

Good for evil.

* Miss Carpenter's "Last Days of Raja Rama Mohana Ray," page 225.

Vindicates the unity of God.

"During the greater part of the period of Rāma Mohana Roy's residence at Calcutta, the whole powers of his mind were directed to the vindication of the doctrine of the unity of God. In this, he maintained, the sacred books of the Hindus and Mussalmans, Jews and Christians agreed; and that all apparent deviations from it were modern corruptions. He propagated it day and night by word and writings, with the zeal of an apostle and the self-denial of a martyr. He was ever ready to maintain it against all gain-sayers, from the believer in thirty three millions of God to the denier of one, for both extremes are common in the East. The writer remembers finding him at his Garden House near Calcutta, one evening, about 7 o'clock, closing a dispute with one of the followers of Buddha, who denied the existence of the Deity. The Rājā had spent the whole day in the controversy, without stopping for food, rest or refreshment, rejoicing more in confuting one atheist than in triumphing over hundred idolators: the credulity of the one he despised; the scepticism of the other he thought pernicious; for he was deeply impressed with the importance of religion for the virtue and happiness of mankind."*

Rejects miracles.

His pro-Christian tendencies are well known. Yet he would not agree with the missionaries in their orthodox views. When the Çri Rāmapur missionaries advanced their arguments in support of them iracles of Christ, the Rājā quietly remarked:—"His miracles were less stupendous than those of the Hindu who drank up the ocean and discharged

* "Last Days in England" by Miss Mary Carpenter, page 299.

it from his body."* Though attacking the idolatrous practices of the Hindus, the Rājā boldly declared his profound respect for the Hindu philosophy before his European friends. An English writer writes, "he (the Rājā) asserts that he has found nothing in European books equal to the scholastic philosophy of the Hindus."†

Respect for Hindu Philosophy.

He combined in himself the best elements of European and Asiatic ideals. In spirituality he was a Vedantist and in morality he was a follower of Christ.

This extraordinary man, with his noble efforts in all works of reformation, did a great service to the cause of Bengali literature to which we shall refer hereafter. We here briefly give a sketch of his life as narrated by himself.

An autobiographical account.

"My ancestors were Brahmins of a high order and, from time immemorial, were devoted to the religious duties of their race, down to my fifth progenitor who, about one hundred and forty years ago, gave up spiritual exercises for worldly pursuits and aggrandisements. His descendants ever since have followed his example and, according to the usual fate of courtiers, with various success, sometimes rising to honour and sometimes falling; sometimes rich and sometimes poor; sometimes excelling in success, sometimes miserable through disappointment. But my maternal ancestors, being of the sacerdotal order by profession as well as by birth, and of a family than which none holds a higher rank in that profession, have

* History of Cri Ramapur Mission Vol. I, page 238.
† Monthly Repository 1818, Vol. XV, pp. 2-4.

up to the present day adhered to a life of religious observances and devotion, preferring peace and tranquillity of mind to the excitements of wordly grandeur.

"In conformity with the usage of my paternal race, and the wish of my father, I studied the Persian and Arabic languages,—these being indispensable to those who attached themselves to the courts of the Mahomedan princes; and agreeably to the usage of my maternal relations, I devoted myself to the study of the Sanskrit and the theological works written in it, which contain the body of Hindu literature, law and religion

"When about the age of sixteen, I composed a manuscript calling in question the validity of the idolatrous system of the Hindus. This, together with my known sentiments on that subject, having produced a coolness between me and my immediate kindred, I proceeded on my travels, and passed through different countries, chiefly within, but some beyond, the bounds of Hindustan, with a feeling of great aversion to the establishment of British power in India. When I had reached the age of twenty, my father recalled me, and restored me to his favour; after which I first saw and began to associate with Europeans and soon after made myself tolerably acquainted with their laws and form of government. Finding them generally more intelligent, more steady and moderate in their conduct, I gave up my prejudice against them, and became inclined in their favour, feeling persuaded that their rule, though a foreign yoke, would lead more speedily and surely to the ameli-

oration of the native inhabitants; and I enjoyed the confidence of several of them even in their public capacity. My continued controversies with the Brahmins on the subject of their idolatry and superstition, and my interference with their custom of burning widows, and other pernicious practices, revived and increased their animosity against me; and through their influence with my family, my father was again obliged to withdraw his countenance openly, though his limited pecuniary support was still continued to me.

"After my father's death I opposed the advocates of idolatry with still greater boldness. Availing myself of the art of printing, now established in India, I published various works and pamphlets against their errors in the native and foreign languages. This raised such a feeling against me, that I was at last deserted by every person except two or three Scotch friends, to whom, and the nation to which they belong, I will always feel grateful.

"The ground which I took in all controversies was, not that of opposition to Brahminism, but to a perversion of it; and I endeavoured to show that the idolatry of the Brahminism was contrary to the practice of their ancestors, and the principles of the ancient books and authorities which they profess to revere and obey. Notwithstanding the violence of the opposition and resistance to my opinions, several highly respectable persons, both among my own relations and others began to adopt the same sentiments.

"I now felt a strong wish to visit Europe and obtain, by personal observation, a more thorough

insight into its manners, customs, religion and political institutions. I refrained however, from carrying this intention into effect until the friends who coincided with my sentiments should be increased in number and strength. My expectations having been at length realised in November, 1830, I embarked for England, as the discussion of the East India Company's Charter was expected to come on, by which the treatment of the natives of India and its future government would be determined for many years to come, and an appeal to the King in Council against the abolition of the practice of burning widows was to be heard before the Privy Council; and His Majesty the Emperor of Delhi had likewise commissioned me to bring before the authorities in England certain encroachments on his rights by the East India Company. I accordingly arrived in England in April, 1831."*

His work in England

Rāma Mohana Roy was requested to give his evidence before the Select Committee of the House of Commons on the Judicial and revenue systems of India. He was also examined on the condition of the native inhabitants of India. His answers, as already mentioned, were remarkable as showing his great command over the subjects in which he was thus consulted. Through his earnest attempts

* Miss Carpenter introduced this Autobiographical sketch into her book 'Last Days in England of Raja Rama Mohana Roy' with the following remarks :—

"The following letter from Rama Mohana Roy himself first appeared in the 'Athenæum' and in the Literary Gazette, from one or other of which it was copied into various papers. It was written just before he went to France. It was probably designed for some distinguished person who had desired him to give an outline of his history; and he adopted this form for the purpose. The letter may be considered as addressed to his friend Mr. Gordon of Calcutta.

the appeal against the abolution of Suttee was rejected on the 11th of July, 1832. After a residence of three years in Europe Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy died at Bristol on the 27th of September, 1833. **and death.**

How far the Rājā's strenuous and self-sacrificing efforts against idolatry may have succeeded will engage us for a few moments. As a heated controvercy was going on in the vernacular tongue on this point, we consider ourselves justified in summarising here the arguments advanced by the other side. From the time of the Riṣis, when Uṣās appeared to them as beautiful nymph of the horizon clothed in purple apparel, down to the days of the Purāṅas, the religious history of India has been one in which monotheism has constantly adopted the garb of allegory, in order to appeal more potently to popular minds; and the vast pantheon of the Hindu gods and goddesses have an emblematical significance which has been repeatedly emphasised by the writers of theological treatises. The Rājā himself admitted "there can be no doubt however, and it is my whole desire to prove, that every rite has its derivation from the allegorical adoration of the deity, but at the present day all is forgotten";* and again "many learned Brahmins are well informed of the pure mode of divine worship."† **Gods and goddesses of the Hindus.**

The position taken by his opponents was not without a rational basis; and the controversy was as interesting as it was learned. In the spiritual world, as in poetry and even in Mathematics, the symbol

* English works of Raja Rama Mohana Roy,' vol. I, page 5.
† Do do. vol. I, page 127.

is adopted for convenience. As in the geometrical definition of a line or point the basis is taken for granted, or as in the play of Hamlet the historic facts need not be authentic, so in any subject the ground-work may always be called in question; but the stupendous facts which rest upon it are not therefore to be ignored or undervalued. The whole civilisation of the Hindus, their vast poetic literature, their architectural achievements, shrines, temples, the geography of India as revealed to them in a spiritual light—the sacred Ganges, the Godāvari, the Brahmāputra, the snow-topped Himalaya and the Vindhya hills, all are associated with religious stories and episodes, underlying which there is the Vedanta Philosophy which invests external forms with spiritual truth: and the idea of the Supreme Being permeates all that may superficially strike us as irrational. From the lays of Jayadeva, Chandi Dās and Vidyāpati to the Kīrtana and the Āgamani songs of Bengal, our whole vast lore of devotional sentiment is no literary curiosity to our people;—it is a perpetual fountain of faith to the humble as well as to the enlightened. The gods and goddesses of the Purāṇas, like the Ṛṣās of the Ṛiṣis, represent the attributes of one who attracts us through their familiar forms even as the sun approaches us through a thousand rays of light. This vast religious fabric was not created in a day. It has taken deep root in our soil for hundreds of years. Such gods as these could not be dismissed at a word, however great might be the power that cried to them 'Vanish!' Even when Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy was decrying what he called idolatry in unsparing language there were already

Europeans who were attracted by it,—nay had adopted the 'idolatrous practices' themselves. The facts disclosed by the extracts quoted below should be judged independently. The comments made on them are what one naturally expects from the biassed persons from whose writings they are taken.

European converts to Hinduism.

"Mr. Twining and Major Scott Waring were joined in their missionary crusade by a colleague in the person of a "Bengal officer," Col. Stewart, generally known in India under the name of "Hindu Stewart." He had abjured Christianity and become a worshipper of the Hindu deities. He exposed himself equally to the ridicule of his own countrymen, by going down in the morning to the Ganges, with flowers and sacrificial vessels, to perform his ablutions according to the Hindu rituals. At a subsequent period, he asked permission to accompany the army in its progress towards the capital of Nepal, that he might have an opportunity of paying his devotion at a celebrated shrine of Çiva which lay on the route. .... The Bengal officer exhibited the most profound respect for the Hindu religion, and entertained the most lofty conceptions of the morals and virtues of the Hindus; and he now came forward to denounce the sacrilegious attack of the missionaries 'on the sacred and venerable fabric of Hinduism.' In his pamphlet called 'The Bengal Officer's Pamphlet' published in 1808, he says, "wherever I look around me in the vast region of Hindu mythology, I discover piety in the garb of allegory: and I see morality, at every turn blended with every fable; and as far as I can rely on my

Hindu Stewart.

judgment, it appears the most complete and ample system of Moral Allegory that the world has ever produced."*

We find from the introduction to Abridgement of Vedanta by Rājā Rāma Mohanā Roy, published in 1816, that he attacked "that system of popular idolatry on which Sir Thomas Munro, and Mr. Lushington, and Mr. Marsh had bestowed the highest eulogium three years before in the presence of the Parliament."†

Mr. W. Ward of the Çrirāmapore Mission seemed to be particularly hostile to any who advocated the cause of Hinduism. In his work on the Hindus, he writes, "The Rev. Maurice has attempted to describe the Hindu ceremonies in the most florid colours. It might have been expected, (idolatry being in itself an act so degrading to man and so dishonourable to God) that a Christian Divine would have been shocked while writing in this manner. If Mr. Maurice thinks there is something in Hinduism to excite the most sublime ideas, let him come and join in the dance before the idol or assist the Bramhins in crying Huree bul: Huree bul!"‡

Mr. Maurice on Hinduism.

From this Mr. Maurice himself, we quote the following interesting and sympathetic passage. "Mr. Forbes of Stanmore Hill in his elegant museum of Indian rarities numbers two of the bells that have been used in devotion by the Brahmins,

* History of the Criramapore Mission by John Clark Marshman, vol. I. pp. 354—56.

† "History of the Criramapore Mission," vol. II. page 128.

‡ Introductory Remarks, Ward's 'on Hindus' vol. II page ixxv.

as great curiosities, and one of them in particular appears to be of very high antiquity, in form very much resembling the cup of the lotus, and the tune of it was uncommonly soft and melodious. I could not avoid being deeply affected with the sound of an instrument which had been actually employed to kindle the flame of that superstition, which I have attempted to unfold. My transported thoughts travelled back to the remote period when the Brahmin religion blazed forth in all its splendour in the caverns of Elephanta: I was, for a moment, entranced and caught the ardour of enthusiasm. A tribe of venerable priests, arrayed in flowing stoles and decorated with high tiaras, seemed assembled around me, the mystic song of initiation vibrated in my ear; I breathed an air, fragrant with the richest perfumes and contemplated the deity in the fire that symbolised him." Dr. Ward quotes this passage from an article written by the Rev. Maurice in the fifth volume of "Indian Antiquities" and treats it with great contempt. But it is the last part of the article which most of all annoys him. This runs as follows.

"She (the Hindu religion) wears the similitude of a beautiful and radiant cherub from heaven, bearing on his persuasive lips the accents of pardon and peace, and on his silken wings benefaction and blessing."*

Pro-Hindu tendencies of Halhed and Jones.

Dr. Ward also finds faults with Mr. Halhed of the Civil Service, the first writer on Bengali grammar, because he "seems to prefer Hinduism to

* 'Ward's 'on the Hindus,' vol. II. Introduction. Page IXXVI.

Christianity;" and condemns even Sir William Jones for his pro-Hindu tendencies. The great scholar was, according to the critic, "accustomed to study the Çāstras with the image of a Hindu god placed on his table."

The Hindus were never known to possess any proselytising zeal; yet the poetry and devotion which pervaded the allegorical mode of their worship could not fail to commend itself to many an enlightened European who would openly avow his partiality for it. These foreign admirers of our religion were Rājā Rāma Mohana's contemporaries—a circumstance which shows that the Hindu religion in Bengal had not yet sunk into utter grossness as it was represented to have done by its reformers; for, in that case it could not have counted its votaries among the Europeans who lived in the country. Almost a century has pssed since Rāma Mohana Roy breathed his last. The incense still burns in the Hindu temples at the time of the Ārati or evening service: the village *potters* still prepare clay images of the gods. The auspicious sound of the evening conch still resounds beyond the temples across our fields and lawns. The sacred books Bhāgvata, Chandi and other Purāṅas, still find hundreds of listeners, whose love is far more ennobling than if the works had possessed a merely literary interest and how dreary would be the Hindu home without these things! To me it appears that if the allegorical forms of our religion were all swept away, the whole Hindu civilisation, intervening between the period of the Vedas and that of Rāma Kriṣṇa Paramahaṁsa's sayings, would be overthrown, and the spiritual soul of India,

Hinduism in our village-homes.

thousands of years old, would have to be born anew, as a child of to-day, losing the benefit of the rich heritage transmitted by our forefathers through the ages of the past.

The success of the Rājā's mission.

But has the Rājā's mission failed in its attempt to lead our society to a realisation of the truth that symbols are not to be mistaken for realities and that the deity is not to be confounded with them? Every right thinking man must emphatically say 'no' to this enquiry. The enlightened Hindu youth of the present day has reverted to the Vedanta Philosophy; and the movements of the revivalists, though often displaying ridiculous niceties in their metaphysical interpretations, have constantly aimed at taking a rational and sensible view of matters. The modern Hindu is not the Hindu of the old school. In the general awakening of the intellect and in the widening of the search after spiritual truth which followed Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy's advent, the Hindus have not neglected to make their position secure by studying the Çāstras in a new light; it has been a point of their constant efforts to interpret rationally what a great number of people of the preceding generations did blindly.

The Rājā has therefore been directly instrumental in helping the cause of monotheism by founding the Brahmo Samāja, and indirectly by giving a stimulus to Hindu Society, which in its anxiety to defend itself against the Rationalists, soon came forward to propound myths about the gods in accordance with monthiestic principles, for which, however, it had ample authority in its scriptures. Like all great men the Rājā came to minis-

ter to a real need of society. It may be that the enlightened people of Bengal would without him have been drawn more irrevocably to Christianity, being dissatisfied with the existing state of their religion. The spirit of the Rājā not only dominates the Brahmo Samāja of to-day, but his influence is distinctly traceable in the general a wakening of the Hindu mind to a consciousness of new ideals in the spiritual world.

The Rājā's work in Bengali prose.

This great man approached his countrymen through the vehicle of his mother tongue. Before Rāma Mohana the prose literature that existed was of very minor importance. The Europeans had already set themselves to the task of compiling Bengali Grammar and vocabularies. They had begun to translate the Gospel, and those placed at the head of the judicial administration had found it expedient to translate the Laws and Regulations into the vernacular. There was a general activity in Bengal among an enlightened though limited circle of men to contribute to our prose literature—an activity which as I have said in a foregoing chapter, was largely due to the energetic efforts of missionaries in bringing home to the people the truths of the Bible, as also to their sincere desire to promote the condition of our countrymen by a diffusion of western education. Rāma Mohana Roy is generally known as the father of the Bengali prose; but we have seen that some of the earliest writings in Bengali, composed in the 10th century A.D, were in prose. Small and even large treatises were written in simple Bengali prose before the advent of the Europeans. The assertion of "fatherhood" therefore can not be

'The father of Bengali prose.'

countenanced. Even before any book had been published in Bengali prose except the Regulations and Vocabularies, Rām Basu's *Pratapaditya Charita* came out in the year 1800. It has been urged by many people that Rāma Mohana Roy in his sixteenth year (1790 A.D.) wrote a book in Bengali prose "against idolatry of all religions." True, he wrote a pamphlet bearing that name, but it was written in Persian with an Arabic preface. The Vedanta Sutra was his first work in Bengali, and this appeared in 1815. In the Vedanta Sutra he himself refers to a translation of Bhāṣāparichchheda in Bengali prose as having already existed before he began to write in Bengali.* We have mentioned several translations of the above work on Logic, while dealing with the old Bengali literature. If one reads the translations of the Bhāṣāparichchheda, the latest of which was written nearly a century before Rāma Mohana Roy's Vedanta Sutra, one will be struck with the similarity of language in the above treatises with the style of Rāma Mohana Roy. The missionaries had taken up Bengali, in right earnest, and they had required no impetus from the Rājā in adopting the vernacular prose as the medium through which to approach the people of Bengal.

But all these considerations hardly detract from the glory which attaches to the name of Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy for his furtherance of the cause of Bengali prose. The literary works by Europeans in Bengali were mostly translations, and whatever credit and reverence may be due to these authors for undertaking a task which required them to over-

* Raja Rama Mohana Roy's Bengali works, P. 267.

come the difficulties of a foreign tongue and master its idioms, their works, judged from the standpoint of pure merit, have, we are constrained to observe, no great attraction. They scarcely rise above the level of school-books. They were pioneers in the field of their labours, so we need not underrate their laudable efforts ; but except awakening the Hindu mind to a sense of its own duty in literature and diverting it into practical channels, their productions have not served any essential or permanent purpose. These works will, in time to come, be looked upon merely as literary curiosities, to be preserved on the shelf amongst old and rare books.

Their Bengali imitators set themselves mostly to the task of compiling and translating English works, which, though extremely necessary at that early period of the diffusion of western education, possess no remarkable merit or permanent interest. The whole of this period in the history of our literature, inspite of its great activity diverted to useful purposes, strikes us as singularly barren of originality ; and the greatest productions then worked out, though they required years of patient and indefatiguable industry, are no land-marks in the history of our progress ; and our minds, while full of admiration for the noble band of writers, involuntarily turn to the old literature for the gratification of those desires which true and original composition can alone fulfil. There was much in the prose writings of this age to interest the intellect but little to give pleasure or satisfaction to the soul.

The Bengali works of the Rājā.

Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy rose on the horizon of our letters at this stage, and all lesser lights grew dim at his advent. The whole aspect of our literature became changed. He wrote the following books in Bengali:—

1. Vedānta Sutra. Quarto size, 114 pages, 1815 A.D.
2. Vedānta Sutra, 15 pages, 1815.
3. Talavakāra Upaniṣad, 11 pages, 1816.
4. Īçopaniṣad, 24 pages, 1816.
5. Sahamaraṅa Viṣaya (on the Suttee), part I, 33 pages, and part II, 12 pages 1819.
6. Do. Part III, 21 pages, 1829.
7. Pathya Pradāna, 139 pages, 1823.
8. Brahmanistha Grihasther Lakṣaṅa, 5 pages, 1826.
9. Kayasther Sahita Madyapāna Viṣayaka Vichāra, 4 pages, 1826.
10. Vajra Suchi, 6 pages, 1830.
11. Anusthāna, 13 pāges, 1829.
12. Suvrahmaṅya Çāstrīr Sahita Vichāra, 5 pages.
13. Prārthanā Patra, 3 pages.
14. Ātmānātma Viveka, 17 pages.
15. Brahmaṅā Sevādhi, 38 pages, 1721.
16. Pādri O Çisya Samvāda, 4 pages.
17. Brahma Saṁgita, 116 songs.
18. Brahmopāsanā, 3 pages.
19. Gāyatrir Artha, 7 pages, 1818.
20. Kathopanisad, 34 pages, 1817.
21. Mundakopanisad, 9 pages.
22. Māndukyopanisad, 26 pages, 1819.
23. Goswāmir Sahita Vichāra, 30 pages, 1818.

24. Kavitkārer Sahita Vichāra, 35 pages, 1821.

25. Bhattācaryyer Sahita Vichāra, 80 pages, 1817.

26. Gauḍiya Vyākaraṅa, 80 pages, 1833.

27. Samvāda Kaumudī, 20 pages.

The English works of Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy have been edited by Jogendra Chandra Ghose, M.A., B.L., and published by Çrīkantha Roy of Calcutta in three volumes.

The Bengali works of the Rājā referred to above, were collected and published by Rājā Nārāyaṅa Vasu and Ānanda Chandra Tarkavāgiça in 1873. The collection contains over 800 pages (quarto size). Most of his Bengali treatises are short; but the vast learning which he displays in each of these productions, together with the closeness of argument and sincere and ardent desire for truth, lends them an importance second to none in our literature. His interpretation of the Vedānta, chiefly based on the commentary of Çankarāchāryyā, gives in lucid Bengali prose what would be impossible for any other person of his age to have done in the vernacular. The intricacies of one of the most abstruse subjects that ever engaged the human intellect,—the difficulties of a language whose prose was not yet properly formed, were all overcome, and the truths of the great Philosophy were brought within the easy reach of every man of ordinary intelligence in a masterly way. The Rājā, like a Riṣi, realised the truths of the Vedanta and expressed them from his own soul through his vernacular writings. We repeat that it would have been impossible for any other man of his age, however

Their merit.

learned, to have reduced such great and abstruse truths to pristine simplicity in a language which as yet was so inadequate to the purpose as our own. It was possible for the Rājā to do so only because he was a himself a seer of these truths like the great sages—the Riṣis of the past.

His controversies similarly display his great powers, his logical acumen, and his vast classical erudition. He gives precedence to reason in every step of his arguments ; and it is the light of his own soul that he brings forward, in order to dispel the darkness of superstition and ignorance that prevails all round. Nowhere does he make his motive prominent. He brings forward a whole array of texts from Sanskrit, Hebrew, Persian and Arabic in favour of what he advocates, so that while arguing with a Maulvi he seems to be himself a Maulvi, with a missionary, he appears to be a Christian, and before a Bhattāchāryya he comes in the garb of the Brahmin that he was. While holding a controversy with a Mahomedan, the Rājā quotes from the Korān, with a Hindu from the Çāstras, and with a Christian from the Bible. He does not decry even the most obvious evils on his own authority, but he brings his whole learning to bear upon each topic ; and the quotations he makes are of an overwhelming nature and display his minute knowledge of the different theological systems of the world. This power of keeping his personal opinions in the back ground and advancing them merely on the authority admitted by his antagonists, required a colossal range of studies which in his age only Rāma Mohana Roy possessed. This accounts for his unique position and his

great ascendency over his rivals in discussion. Another noteworthy feature in his writings is the entire absence of any outburst of feeling. It might have been supposed that a man who so deeply felt the wrongs that prevailed all around, would denounce them in the fiery language of an ardent enthusiast in the cause of reformation. But his great intellectuality and deep conviction made him proceed quietly in controversy, like a doctor in the process of a serious surgical operation; occasions, however serious, did not disturb his temper. This superior control over himself is to be traced distinctly in all his writings. What was said of some of his English works by his English reviewer in the Monthly Repository for September, 1833, applies equally to his Bengali writings also. "The method and coolness with which the Rājā arranges and states his facts, in contrast with the rousing nature of those facts, are as remarkable as anything in the whole affair; and the courtesy with which he accounts, where he can, for the rise and growth of abuses, will not impede, but hasten the rectification of those abuses. The Rājā appreciates too well the nature and operation of free institutions, not to have felt many a throb of indignation, many a pang of grief, when witnessing the oppressed condition of the ryots of his country, and the various kinds and degrees of guilt among his countrymen, which have been originated by British misgovernment: but when the cause can be best served by a plain statement of facts, he can adduce them with all the calmness of a mere observer. That which it makes our spirits sink to read, he states unaccompanied by reproach

or entreaty. Suggestions on which we should stake our lives, and which we should be apt to thrust in the face of friend and foe, he offers in their due connection, and with a moderation most likely to ensure them a hearing."

However trivial or puerile were the charges made against him, he listened to every point urged by his opponents with great attention, and in his anxious solicitude to bring conviction of the truth home to the party, he gave a sensible reply to their foolish abuses and revilings prompted by animosity, with a surprising quietness of temper. I quote a passage from his Bengali writing.

Extracts from his Bengali prose.

* "The first argument in support of idolatry, is that the Supreme Being is beyond all power of human comprehension and cannot be expressed by words; hence the necessity of worshipping a Deity endowed with form and other attributes, as Master of the universe. The plain answer to this is:—If a person in his early childhood, before he has had any knowledge of his father, is kidnapped, or by other causes separated from home, would it be proper for him, when growing into manhood, to call some object before him his father? Rather should he not, when observing a

*" প্রথমত: এই যাহাকে ব্রহ্ম জগৎকর্ত্তা কহ তিহোঁ বাক্য মনের অগোচর সুতরাং তাহার উপাসনা অসম্ভব হয় এই নিমিত্ত কোন-রূপ গুণবিশিষ্টকে জগতের কর্ত্তা জানিয়া উপাসনা না করিলে নির্ব্বাহ হইতে পারে নাই অতএব রূপগুণ বিশিষ্টের উপাসনা আবশ্যক হয়। ইহার সামান্য উত্তর এই। যে কোন ব্যক্তি বাল্যকালে শত্রুগ্রস্ত এবং দেশান্তর হইয়া আপনার পিতার নিরূপণ কিছু জানে নাই এ নিমিত্ত সে ব্যক্তি যুবা হইলে পরে যে কোন

religious ceremony or engaged in a prayer for the good of his father,—say 'Peace be unto him who has begotten me!' In the same way, it should be understood, though the Divine Being may be incomprehensible to us, that we may always address Him as the creator and preserver of the universe without giving Him fictitious attributes and a fancied name. The quality and nature of many objects of creation,—such as the sun or the moon, are not fully known to us; how is it then possible for us to know the nature of the creator! But observing the objects around us, and the laws which govern the universe, we are conscious of His omnipotence and of His divine dispensation which is good for all: and with such a consciousness we are always quite free to approach him. Our common sense tells us that the creator is mightier than his creation, and that a created object, as forming but a part of the universe, cannot be its master. The

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বস্তু সম্মুখে পাইবেক তাহাকে পিতারূপে গ্রহণ করিবেক এমত নহে বরঞ্চ সেই ব্যক্তি পিতার উদ্দেশে কোন ক্রিয়া করিবার সময়ে অথবা পিতার মঙ্গল প্রার্থনা করিবার কালে এই কহে যে যে জন জন্মদাতা তাঁহার শ্রেয়ঃ হউক। সেই মত এখানেও জানিবে যে ব্রহ্মের স্বরূপ জ্ঞেয় নহে কিন্তু তাঁহার উপাসনা কালে তাঁহাকে জগতের স্রষ্টা পাতা সংহর্ত্তা ইত্যাদি বিশেষণের দ্বারা লক্ষ্য করিতে হয় তাহার কল্পনা কোন নশ্বর নাম রূপে কিরূপ করা যাইতে পারে। সর্ব্বদা যে সকল বস্তু যেমন চন্দ্র সূর্য্যাদি আমরা দেখি ও তাহার দ্বারা ব্যবহার নিষ্পন্ন করি তাহারো যথার্থ স্বরূপ জানিতে পারি না ইহাতেই বুঝিবে যে ঈশ্বর ইন্দ্রিয়ের অগোচর তাঁহার স্বরূপ কিরূপে জানা যায় কিন্তু জগতের নানাবিধ রচনার এবং নিয়মের দৃষ্টিতে তাঁহার কর্তৃত্ব এবং নিয়ন্তৃত্ব নিশ্চয়

supporters of idolatry urge that the worship of an invisible power is impossible. This argument is curious, since they may observe that their own countrymen and the people of other countries have found it quite possible to pray to the invisible Deity. The second point urged is :—It is not at all worthy of a good soul to leave the ways of their ancestors and of their own people and trample upon old customs.

Ans.—People seem to be carried away a good deal by their love for ancestors and kinsmen. But it is the lower animals only which altogether follow the beaten track of their own kind. How should a man, endowed with a sense of right and wrong, be justified in following a certain path merely because his forefathers adopted it? Blind faith in past

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হইলে কৃতকার্য্য হইবার সম্ভব হয়। সামান্য অবধানে নিশ্চয় হয় যে এই দুর্গম্য নানা প্রকার রচনা বিশিষ্ট জগতের কর্ত্তা ইহা হইতে ব্যাপক এবং অধিক শক্তিমান অবশ্য হইবেক ইহার এক অংশ কিম্বা ইহার ব্যাপ্য কোন বস্তু ইহার কর্ত্তা কি যুক্তিতে অঙ্গীকার করা যায়। আর এক অধিক আশ্চর্য্য এই যে স্বজাতীয় বিজাতীয় অনেকেই নিরাকার ঈশ্বরের উদ্দেশে উপাসনা করিতেছেন ইহা প্রত্যক্ষ দেখিতেছেন অথচ কহিতেছেন যে নিরাকার ঈশ্বর তাঁহার উপাসনা কোন মতে হইতে পারে না॥ ১॥ দ্বিতীয় বাক্য রচনা এই যে পিতা পিতামহ এবং স্ববর্গেরা যে মতকে অবলম্বন করিয়াছেন তাহার অন্যথা করণ অতি অযোগ্য হয়। লোকসকলের পূর্ব্ব পুরুষ এবং স্ববর্গের প্রতি অত্যন্ত স্নেহ সুতরাং এ বাক্যকে পর পূর্ব্ব বিবেচনা না করিয়া প্রমাণ স্বীকার করেন ইহার সাধারণ উত্তর এই যে কেবল স্ববর্গের মত হয় এই প্রমাণে মত গ্রহণ করা পশু জাতীয়ের ধর্ম্ম

authority is inadmissible with a progressing race. But inspite of their advancing this argument, we see that our countrymen never gave such absolute authority to custom in by-gone ages. Amongst the Hindus one born in a Vaiṣṇava family is often seen to change his faith and become a Cākta; and a Cakta is similarly observed to accept the Vaiṣṇava faith; within the last hundred years the people of Bengal have adopted the views of Raghunandana in their religious observances, and in this respect there has been an entire deviation on their part from following the beliefs and practices of their ancestors. We read in history besides that when the five Brahmins first came to Bengal they had socks on their feet, wore coats, and they came riding in bullock carts. Such practices are now considered as sacrilegeous on the part of Brahmins. In olden times a Brahmin would never accept service under a *Yavana* or foreigner, nor learn any

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হয় যে সর্ব্বদা স্ববর্গের ক্রিয়ানুসারে কার্য্যে করে। মনুষ্য যাহার সং অসং বিবেচনার বুদ্ধি আছে সে কি রূপে ক্রিয়ার দোষ কি গুণ বিবেচনা না করিয়া স্ববর্গে করেন এই প্রমাণে ব্যবহার এবং পরমার্থ কার্য্যনির্ব্বাহ করিতে পারে। এইমত সর্ব্বত্র সর্ব্বকালে হইলে পর পৃথক পৃথক মত এ পর্য্যন্ত হইত না বিশেষত আপনাদের মধ্যে দেখিতেছি যে এক জন বৈষ্ণবের কুলে জন্ম লইয়া শাক্ত হইতেছে দ্বিতীয় ব্যক্তি শাক্ত কুলে বৈষ্ণব হয় আর স্মার্ত্ত ভট্টাচার্য্যের পরে যাহাকে এক শত বৎসর হয় না যাবতীয় পরমার্থ কর্ম্ম স্নান দান ব্রতোপবাস প্রভৃতি পূর্ব্ব মতে ভিন্ন প্রকার হইতেছে আর সকলে কহেন যে পঞ্চ ব্রাহ্মণ যে কালে এদেশে আইসেন তাঁহাদের পায়েতে মোজা এবং জামা ইত্যাদি বেশ এবং গোযান ছিল তাহার পরে পরে সে সকল ব্যবহার কিছুই রহিল

language other than the Sanskritic; they were also prohibited from teaching Sanskrit to non-Hindus; but they do all these things now. So it is evident that we have not over zealously persevered in our old customs and manners. Why, therefore, should we be led by an idle prejudice in their favour in the matter of faith itself which concerns the good of our souls and our hereafter.

The third argument in support of idolatry is that the knowledge of the absolute makes a man unfit for all practical purposes. To him good and evil, fire and water, sweet scent and obnoxious stench become all the same as he rises above the phenomenal; such a knowledge is therefore not compatible with the pursuits of ordinary men.

Ans.—What they mean to imply by this is not clear. You, sirs, will admit that Nārada, Sanat-Kumāra, Çuka, Vaçistha, Vyasa, Kapila and other sages had a knowledge of the absolute and invisible Brahma. Nevertheless these sages recognised

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না আর ব্রাহ্মণের যবনাদির দাসত্ব করা এবং যবনকে শাস্ত্র পাঠ করান কোন্ পূর্ব্ব ধর্ম্ম ছিল। অতএব স্ববর্গে যে উপাসনা ও ব্যবহার করেন তাহার ভিন্ন উপাসনা করা এবং পূর্ব্ব পূর্ব্ব নিয়মের ত্যাগ এমত বাক্যে বিশ্বাস করিয়া পরমার্থের উত্তম পথের চেষ্টা না করা যায়। তৃতীয় বাক্য এই যে ব্রহ্ম উপাসনা করিলে মনুষ্যের লৌকিক ভদ্রাভদ্র জ্ঞান থাকে না, অতএব সুতরাং ঈশ্বরের উপাসনা গৃহস্থ লোকের কিরূপে হইতে পারে। উত্তর। তাহারা কি প্রমাণে এবাক্য রচনা করেন তাহা জানিতে পারি নাই যেহেতু আপনারাই স্বীকার করেন যে নারদ জনক সনৎ-কুমারাদি শুক বশিষ্ঠ ব্যাস কপিল প্রভৃতি ব্রহ্মজ্ঞানী ছিলেন অথচ

fire as fire and water as water; they administered justice, and taught their disciples; so how can you urge that they had lost all consciousness of the phenomenal world? Besides it seems very curious to me that you believe that by worshipping your gods the knowledge of the visible world becomes keener; but by praying to the invisible and absolute Power, people become mad, and lose all consciousness of the external world. The knowledge of the world is not interfered with by a knowledge of the Deity, as a man who has the knowledge of God still continues to live in the world and his eyes and ears continue to perform their functions, and if he lives with his father, son, and others, he continues to fulfil his duties to them and all this is the will of the Supreme being. It is not indicated where a knowledge of God clashes with the knowledge of the world. The sages of the past who were endowed with a knowledge of the true God

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ইঁহারা অগ্নিকে অগ্নি জলকে জল ব্যবহার করিতেন এবং রাজকর্ম্ম আর গার্হস্থ্য এবং শিষ্য সকলকে জ্ঞানোপদেশ যথাযোগ্য করিতেন তবে কিরূপে বিশ্বাস করা যায় যে ব্রহ্মজ্ঞানীর ভদ্রাভদ্রাদি জ্ঞান কিছুই থাকে নাই আর কিরূপে এ কথার আদর লোকে করেন তাহা জানিতে পারি না। বিশেষতঃ আশ্চর্য্য এই যে ঈশ্বরের উপাসনাতে ভদ্রাভদ্র জ্ঞান থাকে আর ব্রহ্ম উপাসনাতে ভদ্রাভদ্র জ্ঞানের বহির্ভূত হইয়া লোক ক্ষিপ্ত হয় ইহাও লোকের বিশ্বাস জন্মে। যদি কহ সর্ব্বত্র ব্রহ্মজ্ঞান করিলে ভেদ জ্ঞান আর ভদ্রাভদ্র জ্ঞান কেন থাকিবেক তাহার উত্তর এই যে লোকযাত্রা নির্ব্বাহ নিমিত্ত পূর্ব্ব পূর্ব্ব ব্রহ্মজ্ঞানীর ন্যায় চক্ষু কর্ণ হস্তাদির কর্ম্ম চক্ষু কর্ণ হস্তাদির অবশ্য করিতে হয় এবং

according to your own admission, did nothing less than ordinary people in worldly matters, nay they did it with a more elevated and refined sense of duty. Some of the supporters of idolatry say "Is it proper to discard the view held by all the world and in preference to follow the opinions of one or two men? Was there no scholar born before him? and is there none who is equal to him in learning now? Would they not also arrive at the same conclusions, if there were any truth in this?"

Ans. Though I am pained at these reflections, yet I feel inclined to answer them for the furtherance of my cause. In the first instance, India does not form even one twentieth part of the earth already known to us. The country inhabited mainly by the Hindus is known as Hindusthān. Excluding this Hindusthān, more than half of the entire population of the rest of the globe profess

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পুত্রের সহিত পিতার কর্ম্ম পিতার সহিত পুত্রের ধর্ম্ম আচরণ করিতে হইবেক যেহেতু এ সকল নিয়মের কর্ত্তা ব্রহ্ম হয়েন। মধ্যে মধ্যে কহিয়া থাকেন যে পৃথিবীর সকল লোকের যাহা মত হয় তাহা ত্যাগ করিয়া দুই এক ব্যক্তির কথা গ্রাহ্য কে করে আর পূর্ব্বে কেহো পণ্ডিত কি ছিলেন না এবং অন্য কেহ পণ্ডিত কি সংসারে নাই যে তাঁহারা এই মতকে জানিলেন না এবং উপদেশ করিলেন না। যদ্যপিও এমত সকল প্রশ্নের শ্রবণে কেবল মানস দুঃখ জন্মে তত্রাপি কর্ম্মানুরোধে উত্তর দিয়া যাইতেছি প্রথমত এ পর্য্যন্ত পৃথিবীর যে সীমা আমরা নির্দ্ধারণ করিয়াছি এবং যাতায়াত করিতেছি তাহার বিংশতি অংশের এক অংশ এই হিন্দোস্থান না হয়। হিন্দুরা যে দেশেতে প্রচুর রূপে বাস করেন তাহাকে হিন্দোস্থান কহা যায়। এই

faith in an invisible Supreme Being. In Hindusthān itself, the Nirvānists, the Nānaka Panthis, the followers of Dādu, the disciples of Çiva Nārayaṇa—ascetics and householders alike—worship one Supreme God. How is the view then tenable that the worship of one Supreme God is against the established ways of all the world? If the next contention,—that scholars before me have not joined such mode of prayer were true—how could we then possess the works of Vyāsa, Vaçistha and other sages who promulgated the pure doctrine of theism! The divine Çankaracharyya and other commentators of the Vedās have all tried to establish monotheistic principles, and Nānaka who lived only a few centuries ago, enjoined the worship of one Supreme Being as an imperative duty on the part of both the Sannyāsins and householders belonging to the sect founded by him. In modern

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হিন্দোস্থান ভিন্ন অদ্ধেক হইতে অধিক প্রথিবীতে এক নিরঞ্জন পরব্রহ্মের উপাসনা লোকে করিয়া থাকেন এই হিন্দোস্থানেতেও শাস্ত্রোক্ত নির্ব্বাণ সম্প্রদা এবং নানক সম্প্রদা আর দাদু সম্প্রদা এবং শিবনারায়ণী প্রভৃতি অনেকে কি গৃহস্থ কি বিরক্ত কেবল নিরাকার পরমেশ্বরের উপাসনা করেন তবে কিরূপে কহেন যে তাবৎ পৃথিবীর মতের বহির্ভূত এই ব্রহ্মোপসনার মত হয় আর পূর্ব্বেও পণ্ডিতেরা যদি এই মতকে কেহ না জানিতেন এবং উপদেশ না করিতেন তবে ভগবান বেদব্যাস এই সকল সূত্র কিরূপ করিয়া লোকের উপকারের নিমিত্ত প্রকাশ করিলেন এবং বাদরী বশিষ্ঠাদি আচার্য্যেরা কি প্রকারে এইরূপ ব্রহ্মোপদেশের প্রচুর গ্রন্থ প্রকাশ করিয়াছেন। ভগবান শঙ্করাচার্য্য এবং ভাষ্যের টীকাকার সকলেই কেবল ব্রহ্ম স্থাপন এবং ব্রহ্মোপাসনার

times there are thousands of men, from Bengal to the Punjab, who uphold and preach the noble theistic principle."

The above shows that he had a rational answer for every argument of his antagonist, however petty or foolish; and the great patience with which he would try to convince them, knowing fully well that they were simply maligning him, is to be explained by his great love and his eagerness to lead others from error to truth. To know the superior merits of his composition, readers are referred to his Vedānta Sāra in Bengali and to his English works. As the field traversed by him in his original works comprehends a wide range of theological matter containing technicalities, we do not find it convenient to give further extracts or translations from them.

The Bengali grammar.

The Bengali grammar written by the Rājā, though a short treatise, bears the impress of his great genius Some of the Europeans had already been in the field with treatises on this subject. Mr. Halhed's Bengali grammar, which is one of the earliest attempts in the direction, is more interesting as a vocabulary, since it gives on a somewhat elaborate scale the meanings of words and translations of short sentences. It also gives

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উপদেশ করিয়াছেন নব্য আচার্য্য গুরু নানক প্রভৃতি এহ বঙ্গো-পাসনাকে গৃহস্থ এবং বিরক্তের প্রতি উপদেশ করেন এবং আধুনিকের মধ্যে এই দেশ অবধি পঞ্জাব পর্য্যন্ত সহস্র সহস্র লোক ব্রহ্মোপাসক এবং ব্রহ্মবিদ্যার উপদেশকর্ত্তা আছেন?"

Vedānta Sāra.

selections from some of our old poems. The purely grammatical element is not very prominent among the various subjects comprised in the book. The Bengali writers who wrote grammar before Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy had in their heads the rules of Sanskrit grammar, and thonght that the Bengali language as a matter of course was bound to conform to them. But Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy discarded Sanskrit grammar in so far as its rules could not be philologically applied to Bengali. We refer our readers to pages 727 and 738 of his Bengali works. He observed the genius of our language, and in what respects it differed from Sanskrit; he formulated principles based on the natural laws which govern Bengali, and treated the subject scientifically. He also indicated the broad lines on which a comprehensive Bengali grammar might be compiled. Unfortunately, however, no other writer on the subject after Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy was possessed of his great insight to continue the work that he had commenced; and the Bengali grammar has since fallen hopelessly into the hands of Sanskrit-knowing pandits. These with their erudite enunciation of rules about Sanskrit compound-words and its prosody have dominated the situation. Following too closely the steps of Mugdhavodha they are applauded by critics who belong to the same school. The Gauḍiya Bhāsār Vyākaraṅa by the Rājā is a highly original publication and contains many important rules. On page 724 he deals with the pronunciation of words. He says that in Bengali the difference of pronunciation between শ, ষ, স, is not observed; but there are certain exceptions

to this rule. When শ is joined with র, ঋ, ন it is pronounced as স, as in শ্রদ্ধা, শৃগাল and প্রশ্ন; Similarly when স is joined with ত, থ, ন, র, ঋ it retains its Sanskritic sound of স as in স্তব, স্থান, স্রক্, সৃষ্টি. In all other places it is pronounced as শ. The chapter on Case is full of original observations. In the dative case, says the Rājā, those words which bear the long vowel আ in the last letter adopt তে or য় as suffix. But those words which have ই, ঈ, উ, ঊ, এ, ঐ, ও, ঔ in their last letters adopt only তে to denote the locative form. Instances of the former are to be found in the forms মৃত্তিকাতে and মৃত্তিকায়, থালাতে and থালায়, শয্যাতে and শয্যায় etc., and of the latter in ছুরিতে, হাতীতে, রজনীতে etc. Regarding the forms of Bengali words in singular and plural numbers, the learned author gives curious rules which are nevertheless correct and testify to his accurate observation. The suffixes গুলি, সকল etc., are generally adopted to indicate the plural number; in the case of men and higher beings the suffix রা is often used, and it is generally speaking restricted to them only; when however the suffix রা is used in the case of lower animals it is implied that such words do no longer signify them; for instance গরু সকল means cows, but গরুরা is used to imply those men who are stupid as cows.*

Before we close the account of Rājā Rāma Mohan Roy we have to say a few words regarding the movement led by him for the abolition of Suttee. His Bengali pamphlets against Suttee were translated by him into English; and they aim chiefly at establishing the superiority of an

The Suttee.

* Bengali works of Raja Rama Mohana Roy. Page 733.

unimpeachable and pure widowhood of woman in accordance with the rules of Brahmachāryya after the death of her husband, over the practice that largely prevailed in his time of self immolation, against which he fought, in conjunction with European clergymen and officials.

Like other reforms this was also proposed and carried out at the teeth of great opposition. While alluding to the controversal literature that sprang up in connection with this movement, we propose to take a dispassionate view of the history of Suttee in Bengal. It is an usage which was prevalent amongst the ancients. The rite was practised in early times amongst the Thracians, the Getæ, and the Scythians. Diodorus wrote in B. C. 44 and he describes it to have occurred in the army of Eumenes, upwards of 300 years before the Christian era (Diodorus Siculus lib XIX, Chapter II.) The Danish Northmen of Europe retained the recollections of Suttee in the story of Balder, one of the sons of Odin.*

The custom grew in India as a natural result of the peculiarly organised social institutions of the Hindus. It has been more than once observed in the foregoing chapters that the Hindus aspire to a realisation of God through the various domestic ties which bind them to their homes. Without this value given to domestic virtues which was the main basis of the Indo-Aryan civilisation, their joint-family system could not have stood. It is the call of home that has always made Hindus

* The Cyclopædia of India by Balfour, P. 781.

endure the greatest sacrifices. Their immortal epics bear striking evidences of this ideal as governing society. But no sacrifice within the precincts of one's home is raised to so high a point of merit as that prompted by sacred nuptial devotion. There are a thousand fables, stories and poems illustrating these noble sacrifices of devoted wives for their husbands. The Hindu woman lives in the atmosphere of this ideal. From her tenderest years she is trained up to it. The stories of Sāvitrī, of Sītā, of Damayanti, of Behulā—these are what a Hindu girl is accustomed to hear every evening in Bengal and even when she is a mere child she willingly fasts on the day of Sāvitri Brata. The Hindu woman grew, as Spartan boys did in ancient Greece,—under great hardships imposed on them by society, but they were meant for a great purpose. Even now the stories and poems that she reads are full of high ideas illustrative of the noblest virtues attendant upon faithful wifehood. The ideal embodied in them would fascinate and attract any tender soul; for the tales of supreme sacrifice undergone for love, never pass in vain with those young audiences who are most susceptible to nobility of spirit.

The love of a Hindu wife is scarcely expressed in passionate utterances. It pervades her whole life. The sacrifices she runs, the spirit of resignation and of entirely losing herself in the thought of doing good to her husband, raise her love beyond all sorts of mundane considerations, not to speak of any for her own comforts. It is this spirit which made women court death willingly on the funeral pyre of the husband. They often died

there like mute images without uttering a word,—without heeding the sensations of pain caused to the body. While their husbands lived, such women were not known to display their great love outwardly. They ministered to the wants of numerous members living together in the family, and gave the minutest attention to each of them and to the servants; but they really lived and moved, without ever saying so, in the thought of their husbands; they kept the vermillion mark on their forehead and the shell-bracelets on their wrists; and prized these sacred signs of wifehood more dearly than their lives. A Hindu wife would sooner agree to be killed than allow them to be removed. This patient all-engrossing sentiment, this love without a thought of return, constant and unchangeable through all vicissitudes of life, in spite of many ills,—its object only the offering of life-long devotion and humble service to the husband,—is expressed in many of the old poems of Bengal,—in our folk-lore and in those rustic songs which I have mentioned in previous chapters.

The peculiar position of the Hindu wife trained her silently to sacrifices of all sorts for domestic feeling. She is not the joy or inspiration of social gatherings as a western woman is. Outside her home there is absolutely no scope for the appreciation of her qualities. Praise from outside world would be as assuredly spurned by her as abuse. Even in one's own family, it would not be good taste to allude to the beauty of a woman who has once borne a child. Her environment develops her domestic instincts more than anything else. Cut

off from the rest of the world—in her own little home she is trained to an idealism of the highest sort, without the facts being observed by any. She would only be seen in public when she was to ascend the funeral pyre of her husband. Foreign people are apt to suppose that her martyrdom was the result of compulsion, oppression or superstition. But those, who possess a more intimate knowledge on the point, will see in *Suttee* only an excess of that idealism that made Sāvitri, in our earliest times, shudder at the thought of her coming widowhood and Tārā express a wish to burn herself with her deceased husband in the Rāmāyaṅa. Suttee is the highest realisition of that dream of womanhood, the perfection of which was imagined by the ancients to lie in an all absorbed thought of the husband. Each country has a peculiar idea of its own to inspire its people with a spirit of self-sacrifice, the growth of which has depended upon a succession of causes and circumstances peculiar to itself. Some people in the world's history have staked their fortune and life for what they called "a national cause," others for what they believed to be the "word of God,"—as the iconoclasts once made it the mission of their lives to destroy temples and images at any cost or sacrifice. Hindu women similarly elected to die out of the devotion they bore to their husbands. Of various reports left of the Suttee by European observers, who were drawn to involuntary admiration on witnessing such scenes, I quote two below. This will be helpful in rightly understanding the controversy held by the pro-Suttee champions against the attempts of the Rājā.

"The widow was a remarkably handsome woman, apparently about thirty, and most superbly attired. Her manner was marked by great apathy to all around her, and by complete indifference to the preparations which for the first time met her eye. From this circumstance an impression was given that she might be under the influence of opium ; and in conformity with the declared intention of the European officers present to interfere, should any coercive measure be adopted by the Brahmins or relations, two medical officers were requested to give their opinions on the subject. They both agreed that she was quite free from any influence calculated to induce torpor or intoxication."

"Captain Burnes then addressed the woman, desiring to know whether the act she was about to perform was voluntary or enforced, and assuring her that, should she entertain the slightest reluctance to the fulfilment of her vow, on the part of the British Government he would guarantee the protection of her life and property. Her answer was calm, heroic and constant to her purpose. "I die of my own free will; give me back my husband, and I will consent to live."

"Ere the renewal of the horrid ceremonies of death was permitted, again the voice of mercy, of expostulation and even of entreaty was heard; but the trial was vain, and the cool and collected manner with which the woman still declared her determination unalterable chilled and startled the most courageous. Physical pangs evidently excited no fears in her; her singular creed, the

customs of her country, and her sense of conjugal duty, excluded from her mind the natural emotions of personal dread; and never did a martyr to a true cause, go to the stake with more constancy and firmness than did this delicate and gentle woman prepare to become the victim of a deliberate sacrifice to the tenets of her heathen creed. Accompanied by the officiating Brahmin, the widow walked seven times round the pyre, repeating the usual mantras or prayers, strewing rice and cowries on the ground, and sprinkling water from her hand over the bystanders, who believed this to be efficacious in preventing disease and expiating committed sins. She then removed her jewels, and presented them to her relations, saying a few words to each with calm soft smile of encouragement and hope. The Brahmins then presented her with a lighted torch, bearing which——

"Fresh as a flower just blown,
And warm with life, her youthful
pulses playing,"

she stepped through the fatal door, and sat within the pile. The body of her husband wrapped in rich *kinkaubs*, was then carried seven times round the pile and finally laid across her knees. Thorns and grass were piled over the door; and again it was insisted that free space should be left, as it was hoped that the poor victim might yet relent, and rush from her fiery prison for the protection so freely offered. The command was readily obeyed; the strength of a child would have sufficed to burst the frail barrier which confined her, and a breathless pause succeeded; but the woman's constancy was faithful to the last. Not a

sigh broke the death-like silence of the crowd, until a slight smoke, curling from the summit of the pyre, and then a tongue of flame, darting with bright and lightning-like rapidity into the clear blue sky, told us that the sacrifice was completed. Fearlessly had this courageous woman fired the pile, and not a groan had betrayed to us the moment when her spirit fled." *

The following is quoted from Bengal Under The Lieutenant Governors by C. E. Buckland, Vol. I, pages 160-161.

"Although it does not fall within his Lieutenant Governorship, I think the following account of a Suttee, as narrated by Sir F. Halliday, 70 years later, will be considered interesting, and it has never been printed elsewhere :—

"Suttee was prohibited by law in 1829. At and before that time I was acting as Magistrate of the district of Hoogly. Before the new law came into operation, notice was one day brought to me that a Suttee was about to occur a few miles from my residence. Such things were frequent in Hooghly as the banks of that side of the river were considered particularly propitious for such sacrifices. When the message reached me, Dr. Wise of the Medical Service and a clergyman (whose name I forget), who was Chaplain to the Governor General, were visiting me and expressed a wish to witness the ceremony. Accordingly we drove to the appointed place where a large crowd of natives was assembled on the river bank and the funeral pile

* Mrs. Porstan's Random Sketches during her residence in one of the northern provinces of Western India in 1839.

already prepared, the intended victim seated on the ground in front of it. Chairs were brought for us, and we sat down near the woman. My two companions, who did not speak the language, then began to press the widow with all the reasons they could urge to dissuade her from her purpose, all of which at their request I made the woman understand in her own language. To this she listened with grave and respectful attention but without being at all moved by it; the priests and many of the spectators also listening to what was said.

At length she showed some impatience and asked to be allowed to proceed to the pile. Seeing that nothing further could be done, I gave her the permission, but before she had moved, the clergyman begged me to put to her one more question,—"Did she know what pain she was about to suffer?" She seated on the ground close to my feet, looked up at me with a scornful expression in her intelligent face and said for answer, "Bring a lamp": the lamp was brought, of the small sauce-boat fashion used by peasants, and also some *ghi* or melted butter and a large cotton wick. These she herself arranged in the most effective form and then said, "Light it;" which was done and the lamp placed on the ground before her. Then steadfastly looking at me with an air of grave defiance she rested her right elbow on the ground and put her finger into the flame of the lamp. The finger scorched, blistered and blackened and finally twisted up in a way which I can only compare to what I have seen happen to a quill pen in the flame of a candle. This lasted for some time,

during which she never moved her hand, uttered a sound or altered the expression of her countenance. She then said:—"Are you satisfied?" to which I answered hastily, "satisfied," upon which with great deliberation she removed her finger from the flame, saying: "Now may I go?" To this I assented and she moved down the slope to the pile. This was placed on the edge of the stream. It was about 4½ ft. high, about the same length, and perhaps 3 ft. broad, composed of alternate layers of small billets of wood and light dry brushwood between four upright stakes. Round this she was marched in a noisy procession 2 or 3 times and ascended it, laying herself down on her side with her face in her hands like one composing herself to sleep, after which she was covered up with light brushwood for several inches, but not so as to prevent her rising had she been so minded. The attendants then began to fasten her down with long bamboos. This I immediately prohibited and they desisted unwillingly but without any show of anger. Her son, a man of about 30, was now called upon to light the pile.

It was one of those frequent cases in which the husband's death had occurred too far off for the body to be brought to the pile, and instead of it a part of his clothing had been laid thereon by the widow's side. A great deal of powdered resin and, I think, some *ghi* had been thrown upon the wood which first gave a dense smoke and then burst into flame. Until the flames drove me back I stood near enough to touch the pile, but I heard no sound and saw no motion, except one gentle upheaving of the brushwood over the body, after which all was

still. The son who had lighted the pile remained near it until it was in full combustion, and then rushing up the bank threw himself on the ground in a paroxysm of grief. So ended the last Suttee that was lawfully celebrated in the district of Hooghly and perhaps in Bengal."

But sacrifices made by a few, under promptings of extraordinary sentiments, are not such as may be enforced in the case of every widow in a society. The Suttees in later times increased in number from very many causes besides that of affection. Within six or seven centuries before the abolition of the rite, the Hindu widows found their position insecure, as the country was overrun by the Mahomedan conquerers and by the Burmese and Portuguese marauders who seized helpless young widows and carried them away or which was worse, put them to indelible infamy. Even Nawabs and noblemen would sometimes not let go the opportunity to do the same as the robbers did, regarding beautiful Hindu widows. The genealogical works referred to by us in pp. 73—91 contain many instances of such atrocities. The number of Suttees must have grown largely in proportion owing to these causes. Besides when one family boasted of its Suttees, the other families wanted, for the sake of increasing their prestige, to possess similar records of sacrifice from among their own members, so what had been in early ages a practice of but rare occurrence became frequent, often under compulsion. The following incident will show to what a heinous extent of barbarity the practice of Suttee might be carried.

*"About the year 1796, the following most shocking and atrocious murder, under the name of *Sahamarana*, was perpetrated at Mājilpur, about a day's journey south from Calcutta. Banchharāma, a Brahman of the above place, dying, his wife at a late hour went to be burnt with the body: all the previous ceremonies were performed; she was fastened on the pile, and the fire was kindled; but the night was dark and rainy. When the fire began to scorch this poor woman, she contrived to disentangle herself from the dead body, and creeping from under the file, hid herself among some brushwood. In a little time it was discovered that there was only one body on the pile. The relations immediately took the alarm and searched for the wretch; the son soon dragged her forth, and insisted that she should throw herself on the pile, or drown or hang herself; she pleaded for her life at the hands of her own son, and declared that she could not embrace so horrid a death—but she pleaded in vain: the son urged, that he should lose his caste, and that therefore he would die or she should. Unable to persuade her to hang or drown herself, the son and the others present then tied her hands and feet, and threw her on the funeral pile, where she quickly perished."

We ask our readers to read the vernacular treatises of the Rājā on Suttee-rites, which are master-pieces of close argumentative writings disclosing his great humane feelings and profound scholarship.†

* Ward's on the Hindus, Vol. II, Part III, Page 304.

† Rāja Rama Mohana Roy's Bengali works, Pages 167-223.

Rājā Rama Mohana was born in Bengal when all the brightness had faded from the illuminated pages of our history, when the glorious had grown ignominous in many places, when faith and devotion had been reduced to superstition, "sweet religion become a mere rhapsody of words," and the scarcely audible beatings of the heart indicated the loss of all social vitality. He led us from superstition to faith, from darkness to light; and though he may seem to have found nothing good in the Hindu religion of his own day,—not even in the self-sacrificing devotion of true hearts which, though few, still weilded the greatest influence in the country, yet we must remember that, generally speaking, it was not the season for extolling a deteriorated virtue, for admiring the atrocious slaughter of women—too heinous an offence to be condoned by idle panegyric. The movements in various fields of enlightenment started by the Rājā have borne ample fruit. The educated community have followed his lead in the general awakening of the intellect observed thoroughout the country after his advent. The Rājā was a great admirer of the English people and, with a sincere heart, approached them with prayers to aid him in his beneficient attempt at reform, and he found a ready response and sympathetic hearing from the rulers of the land. Though a scholar of world-wide renown and a perfect master of the most important classical and many modern languages, he did not despise his mother tongue. He wrote master-pieces in Bengali. "It is a remarkable fact that the address he presented to Lord William Bentinck was in Bengali, a circumstance

The fruit of the Rājā's labours.

which showed how deep was his love for his mother tongue."* His works in Bengali struck the keynote of a new style, for though the Raja was full of admiration for the English, yet he would not accept any matter second-hand; with him began an attempt at free enquiry after truth. The works by the missionaries and those that wrote under their instructions consisted, as already said, mainly of compilations and translations: but in the Bengali works of the Rājā begins a new epoch and a movement for the right understanding of the truths of our own religion. Rāma Mohana Roy began with the Vedānta; and taking the cue of rational explanation from him we have come down to the Puraṅas. From the time of Rāma Mohana Roy, Bengali literature in its poems, romances and theologial works, has striven to restate the truths contained in our classics in the light of western rationalism of thought; it has tried to combine the realistic mode of thinking peculiar to the west with oriental idealism; sometimes the occidental element has been too prominent in Bengali writings almost alienating itself from our national ideal in the views propounded, at others verging on extreme conservativeness, and blind orthodoxy. The conflict is going on without intermission up to the present, and a harmony has not yet, I am afraid, crowned the attempts of the opposing forces in this field. But all the same, we are conscious of a great activity in our literature and we owe it preeminently to the devoted labours of Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy.

* The English works of Raja Rama Mohana Roy. Vol. I, Introduction, page XIX.

who advanced its cause, not only by writing monumental works in Bengali himself, but by raising a controversy which has contributed a great deal to the rapid development of prose. Taking this view of matters, it cannot be considered unjust to call him the father of modern Bengali prose.

(c) The writers that followed Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy—Devendra Nātha Tagore—Akṣaya Kumara Datta and others.

After the death of Rājā Rāma Mohana Roy the spirit of reform lay dormant for a while. Even the Brāhma-Sabhā that he had established, succumbed to those othodox forms against which the great leader had fought all his life. In the year 1862 it was found that the Brahmins only were admitted to it, and that they held meetings with closed doors against all of other castes. Içvara Chandra Nyayaratna used to lecture before a select body of Brahmins in the Theistic Hall : and in one of the subjects that he chose, he argued that Rāma had been an incarnation of God. The missionaries knew Rāma Mohana Roy to be their great foe inspite of all professions of amity and peace on both sides; for under the outward form of Unitarian Christianity which the Rājā seemed to profess, he was founding a new Theistic Church based on the Vedanta Philosophy and on Christian Morals. This would inevitably draw to itself those educated Hindus who, if such a society had not been organised by the Rājā, would have gravitated towards the Christian Churches, and proved willing

Renewed activities of the missionaries.

converts. The death of the Rājā, and a total absence in the field of any suitable personage on whom his mantle could fall, gave an opportunity for a time to the Christian Missionaries to renew their attempts at proselytising with redoubled zeal. Stray cases come to our notice which show the vigorous procedure of these gentlemen. In 1845, Umeça Chandra Sarkār and his wife were converted by Dr. Duff in a manner which created a great sensation amongst the whole native population of Calcutta. In fact on the very day of their conversion, the Hindus raised Rs. 40,000 to found a Hindu School in order to counteract the influence of Christian teaching in the schools established by the Missionaries.

Devendra Nātha Tagore.

At this juncture another great man appeared to take up the work of the great reformer. His intellectual powers were not so great as those of Rāma Mohana Roy, but his strength of character, faith in religious views, power of sacrifice for the cause of what he considered right, high-mindedness and unflinching advocacy of theism have deservedly lifted him to the rank of a Riṣi in popular estimation. Devendra Nātha Tagore has, moreover, furthered the cause of Bengali literature in no inconsiderable degree. He was the son of the distinguished Dwarka Natha Tagore who was called Prince Dwarkā Natha in England, and who enjoyed the great confidence of our revered and beloved Queen Victoria during his stay in that country. Devendra Nātha, heir to a princely fortune, and a man of remarkably handsome features and rare accomplishments, in his early youth realised the truth that life was short, fortune was transitory and religion

the only solace of life. Impelled by a sense of moral duty,—for there was no legal obligation,—he handed over his immense inheritance to his father's creditors, who could have claimed no hold upon it. And the effect which this noble act of sacrifice produced on the minds of the people was evidenced by the bestowal of the title of Maharṣi or great Riṣi on him by his countrymen. His creditors, fortunately, were no Shylocks. They arranged for the liquidation of debts in a way convenient to the youthful owner of the property; but all the same a considerable portion of it had to be sold. But Devendra Natha was indifferent to worldly considerations. I quote an extract from his auto-biography which is written in a simple and attractive style.

An extract from his autobiography.

*"My grand-mother loved me very much. In childhood I cared not for any one else but her. I used to take my meals with her, sit by her the whole live-long day and sleep on the same bed with her. When she went to Kālighāta to visit the shrine I used to accompany her thither. At one time she went to Vrindāvana and Puri leaving me at home. I recollect how bitterly I wept owing to my separation from her. She was intensely devoted to religion. Every day at early dawn she used to

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*"দিদিমা আমাকে বড় ভাল বাসিতেন। শৈশবে তাঁহাকে ব্যতীত আমিও আর কাহাকে জানিতাম না। আমার শয়ন, উপবেশন, ভোজন, সকলই তাঁহার নিকট হইত। তিনি কালীঘাটে যাইতেন, আমি তাঁহার সহিত যাইতাম। তিনি যখন আমাকে ফেলে জগন্নাথক্ষেত্রে ও বৃন্দাবনে গিয়াছিলেন, তখন আমি বড়ই কাঁদিতাম। ধর্ম্মে তাঁহার অত্যন্ত নিষ্ঠা ছিল। তিনি প্রতিদিন অতি প্রত্যুষে গঙ্গাস্নান করিতেন। এবং প্রতিদিন

bathe in the Ganges and weave garlands for the tutelary god Sālagrāma. Sometimes she fasted from sunrise to sun-set and offered '*argha*' to the sun. I stayed with her on the roof and got by heart the hymn addressed to the sun, hearing it uttered so often. "O Thou of the colour of the *Java*, offspring of Kāçyapa, radiant with rays, the dispeller of darkness and destroyer of sin, O Sun. I salute thee."

My grand-mother sometimes fasted the whole day and night, and during the whole of such nights Kathakatās and Kirtana songs went on in the house; We could not sleep owing to the noise. She used to supervise the household work and herself assisted the domestics in their service. Owing to her efficient management and firm control, all the work of our house was conducted with strict regularity. When the inmates of the house had all taken their meal she would cook her own food herself. I

শালগ্রামের জন্য স্বহস্তে পুষ্পের মালা গাঁথিয়া দিতেন। কখনো কখনো তিনি সংকল্প করিয়া উদয়াস্ত সাধন করিতেন—সূর্য্যোদয় হইতে সূর্য্যের অস্তকাল পর্য্যন্ত সূর্য্যকে অর্ঘ্য দিতেন আমিও সে সময়ে ছাতের উপরে রৌদ্রেতে তাঁহার সঙ্গে সঙ্গে থাকিতাম, এবং সেই সূর্য্য অর্ঘ্যের মন্ত্র শুনিয়া শুনিয়া আমার অভ্যাস হইয়া গেল। "জবাকুসুম সঙ্কাশং কাশ্যপেয়ং মহাদ্যুতিং। ধ্বান্তারিং সর্ব্বপাপঘ্নং প্রণতোঽস্মি দিবাকরং।" দিদিমা এক এক দিন হরিবাসর করিতেন, সমস্ত রাত্রি কথা হইত এবং কীর্ত্তন হইত; তাহার শব্দে আমরা রাত্রিতে ঘুমাইতে পারিতাম না। তিনি সংসারের সমস্ত তত্ত্বাবধারণ করিতেন। তাঁহার কার্য্যদক্ষতার জন্য তাঁহার শাসনে গৃহের সকল কার্য্য সুশৃঙ্খলরূপে চলিত। পরে সকলের আহারান্তে তিনি স্বপাকে আহার করিতেন।

used to share her plain meal composed of boiled rice and simple vegetables (হবিষ্যান্ন); this food I relished more than my own. The beauty of her person was as great as her accomplishments, and her faith in religion was equally great. But she could not bear the visit of Mā-gosāins (women who posed as teachers of the Vaiṣnava faith) to our house. Though her faith was mixed with superstition she also evinced a considerable freedom in her religious views. With her I often visited the image of Gopināṭha in our family residence. I never wanted to come out of the temple without her. I used to sit on her lap and through the window quietly observe all that passed. My grand-mother is no more; but after how many days of weary search for the truth have I found One who is more than even my beloved grand-mother ever was

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আমিও তাঁহার হবিষ্যান্নের ভাগী ছিলাম। তাঁহার সেই প্রসাদ আমার যেমন স্বাদু লাগিত তেমন আপনার খাওয়া ভাল লাগিত না। তাঁহার শরীর যেমন সুন্দর ছিল, কার্য্যেতে তেমনি তাঁহার পটুতা ছিল, এবং ধর্ম্মেতে ও তাঁহার তেমনি আস্থা ছিল। কিন্তু তিনি মা-গোঁসাইয়ের সতত যাতায়াত বড় সহিতে পারিতেন না। তাঁহার ধর্ম্মের অন্ধ বিশ্বাসের সহিত একটু স্বাধীনতাও ছিল। আমি তাঁহার সহিত আমাদের পুরাতন বাড়ীতে গোপীনাথ ঠাকুর দর্শনার্থে যাইতাম। কিন্তু আমি তাঁহাকে ছাড়িয়া বাহিরে আসিতে ভাল বাসিতাম না তাঁহার ক্রোড়ে বসিয়া গবাক্ষ দিয়া শান্তভাবে সমস্ত দেখিতাম। এখন আমার দিদিমা আর নাই। কিন্তু কতদিন পরে, কত অন্বেষণের পরে, আমি এখন আমার দিদিমার দিদিমাকে পাইয়াছি ও তাঁহার ক্রোড়ে বসিয়া জগতের লীলা দেখিতেছি। দিদিমার মৃত্যুর

to me! Seated on the lap of the divine Mother I quietly observe all that transpires through Her wishes.

Shortly before her death my grand mother one day told me 'I have decided to bequeath to you all that I have in the world, I won't give it to any one else.' Thereupon she gave me the key to her box; I opened it and found some gold and silver coins in it. I told people that I had found parched rice in my grand mother's box. In the year 1835 her end drew near. My father had at that time gone on a trip to the neighbourhood of Allahabad. The physician said that the patient should no longer be kept at home. Whereupon our relations came and brought my grand mother down to the ground-floor and made preparations to take her to the Ganges.* But she was still

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কিছুদিন পূর্ব্বে আমাকে বলেন আমার যা কিছু আছে আমি তাহা আর কাহাকেও দিব না, তোমাকেই দিব। পরে তিনি তাঁহার বাক্সের চাবিটা আমাকে দেন। আমি তাঁহার বাক্স খুলিয়া কতকগুলিন টাকা ও মোহর পাইলাম, লোককে বলিলাম যে আমি মুড়ি মুড়কি পাইয়াছি। ১৭৫৭ শকে দিদিমার যখন মৃত্যুকাল উপস্থিত, তখন আমার পিতা এলাহাবাদ অঞ্চলে পর্য্যটন করিতে গিয়াছিলেন, বৈদ্য আসিয়া কহিল রোগীকে আর ঘরে রাখা হইবে না। অতএব সকলে আমার পিতামহীকে গঙ্গাতীরে লইয়া যাইবার জন্য বাড়ীর বাহিরে

* The usual custom of the Hindus is to take the dying people to the bank of the Ganges or to any other river that may be near, when the case is declared as hopeless and death is expected at every moment.

hoping to live and did not like to be carried to the Ganges. She said "If Dwarka Natha (her son) were here, he would never allow you to remove me from home as you are doing." The men did not pay any heed to her words, but went on carrying her towards the Ganges; upon which she said, "As you have not obeyed my wishes I shall cause you great trouble. I shall not die soon."* On reaching the Ganges they placed her in a hut of tiles. She lived three nights in that situation. I was with her all this time. On the night previous to the day when she would expire, I was seated on a mat spread near the tiled hut, the full moon had risen on the horizon and close by me was the funeral ground. At that time they were singing

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আসিল। কিন্তু দিদিমা আরও বাঁচিতে চান, গঙ্গায় যাইতে তাঁহার মত নাই, তিনি বলিলেন যে "যদি দ্বারকানাথ বাড়ীতে থাকিত তবে তোরা কখনই আমাকে লইয়া যাইতে পারিতিস্ না।" কিন্তু লোকে তাহা শুনিল না। তাঁহাকে লইয়া গঙ্গা-তীর চলিল। তখন তিনি কহিলেন, "তোরা যখন আমার কথা না শুনে আমাকে গঙ্গায় নিয়ে গেলি, তেমনি আমি তোদের সকলকে খুব কষ্ট দিব, আমি শীঘ্র মরিব না।" গঙ্গাতীরে লইয়া একটী খোলার চালাতে তাহাকে রাখা হইল। সেখানে তিনি তিন রাত্রি জীবিত ছিলেন। আমি সেই সময়ে গঙ্গাতীরে তাহার সঙ্গে নিয়ত থাকিতাম। দিদিমার মৃত্যুর পূর্ব্বদিন রাত্রিতে আমি ঐ চালার নিকটবর্ত্তী নিমতলার ঘাটে একখানা চাঁচের উপর বসিয়া আছি, ঐ দিন পূর্ণিমার রাত্রি—চন্দ্রোদয় হইয়াছে, নিকটে শ্মশান। তখন দিদিমার নিকট নাম সঙ্কীর্ত্তন

* If a person does not die soon on reaching the Ganges, the carriers are required to wait there till her death and undergo great hardships.

kirtana songs around my grand-mother. One ran thus :—

"When will that blessed day come, when I shall leave this mortal body reciting thy name, O Hari?"

A gentle breeze was carrying the sound to my ear: suddenly at that moment a strange emotion passed over my mind. For the time being I became an entirely different man from what I was,—I felt a total abhorrence for wealth. The mat on which I sat appeared to me to be my proper and fit place. The rich carpets and all seemed worthless and of no value to me; I felt a complacency and joy which I had never experienced before. I was only 18 years old at the time.

(2)

So long I had lain deep-plunged in the pleasures of luxury. I had never for one moment felt any longing for truth. I never cared to know

হইতেছিল, "এমন দিন কি হবে হরি নাম বলিয়া প্রাণ যাবে।" বায়ুর সঙ্গে তাহা অল্প অল্প আমার কাণে আসিতেছিল। এই অবসরে হঠাৎ আমার মনে এক আশ্চর্য্য উদাস ভাব উপস্থিত হইল। আমি যেন আর পূর্ব্বের মানুষ নই। ঐশ্বর্য্যের উপর একেবারে বিরাগ জন্মিল। যে চাঁচের উপর বসিয়া আছি, তাহাই আমার পক্ষে ঠিক বোধ হইল, মনের মধ্যে এক অভূতপূর্ব্ব আনন্দ উপস্থিত হইল। তখন আমার বয়স ১৮ বৎসর।

দ্বিতীয় পরিচ্ছেদ।

এতদিন আমি বিলাসের আমোদে ডুবিয়া ছিলাম। তত্ত্বজ্ঞানের কিছুমাত্র আলোচনা করি নাই। ধর্ম্ম কি, ঈশ্বর কি,

what religion or God was; nobody gave me any instruction on the subject. The joy I felt on the funeral ground that day overflowed my soul. Language is feeble; how can I express it or convey what I felt to others? No one can experience this joy by filling his head with logical discussions. Who says there is no God? Here is the evidence of his existence: I was not prepared for it; how could I then have felt such joy! With this spirit of asceticism and joy I came home at midnight. I could not sleep that night. The reason of my sleeplessness was this ecstasy of soul; as if moonlight had spread itself over my mind for the whole of that night. At dawn I went to the bank of the Ganges to see my grand-mother. I found her drawing her last breath. 'They had brought her

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কিছুই জানি নাই, কিছুই শিখি নাই। শ্মশানের সেই উদাস আনন্দ, তৎকালের সে স্বাভাবিক সহজ আনন্দ মনে আর ধরে না। ভাষা সর্ব্বথা দুর্ব্বল, আমি সে আনন্দ কিরূপে লোককে বুঝাইব? তাহা স্বাভাবিক আনন্দ। তর্ক করিয়া যুক্তি করিয়া সে আনন্দ কেহ পাইতে পারে না। সেই আনন্দ ঢালিবার জন্য ঈশ্বর অবসর খোঁজেন। সময় বুঝিয়াই তিনি আমাকে এ আনন্দ দিয়াছিলেন। কে বলে ঈশ্বর নাই? এই তো তাঁর অস্তিত্বে প্রমাণ। আমি তো প্রস্তুত ছিলাম না, তবে কোথা হইতে এ আনন্দ পাইলাম? এই ঔদাস্য ও আনন্দ, লইয়া রাত্রি দুই প্রহরের সময় আমি বাড়ীতে আসিলাম। সে রাত্রিতে আমার নিদ্রা হইল না। এ অনিদ্রার কারণ আনন্দ সারা রাত্রি যেন একটা আনন্দ-জ্যোৎস্না আমার হৃদয়ে জাগিয়া রহিল। রাত্রি প্রভাত হইলে দিদিমাকে দেখিবার জন্য আবার গঙ্গাতীরে যাই, তখন তাঁহার শ্বাস হইয়াছে। সকলে

down to the Ganges and were enthusiastically reciting in a loud voice "Gangā-Nārāyaṅa Brahma" She died immediately. I approached her and saw that one of her hands lay on her breast, the middle finger pointed towards heaven. 'Recite the name of Hari' she said at the last moment pointing with her finger, which remained fixed towards heaven. As I saw it I surmised that while leaving this world it was God and hereafter that she pointed to me, beloved as I was. My grand-mother was not only my greatest friend in this life, but also my friend in the hereafter."

The Early Brahma Samaja.

In the year 1845, Devendra Nātha organised a band of workers who accepted the Brahma Dharma and gave up "idolatrous practices." The number swelled to five hundred in 1849. We find the name of Akṣaya Kumāra Dutta, the great Bengali writer of this period, in the list of the first batch of Brāhmas.

Akhsaya Kumāra Dutta.

In the year 1843, the Tatta Bodhini Patrikā was started by Devendra Nātha Tagore and Babu Akṣaya Kumāra Datta was appointed as editor.

ধরাধরি করিয়া দিদিমাকে গঙ্গার গর্ভে নামাইয়াছে এবং উৎসাহের সহিত উচ্চৈঃস্বরে "গঙ্গা নারায়ণ ব্রহ্ম" বলিতেছে। দিদিমার মৃত্যু হইল। আমি নিকটস্থ হইয়া দেখিলাম, তাঁহার হস্ত বক্ষঃস্থলে, এবং অনামিকা অঙ্গুলীটী ঊর্দ্ধমুখে আছে। তিনি "হরিবোল" বলিয়া অঙ্গুলী ঘুরাইতে ঘুরাইতে পরলোকে চলিয়া গেলেন। তাহা দেখিয়া আমার বোধ হইল, মরিবার সময় ঊর্দ্ধে অঙ্গুলি নির্দ্দেশ করিয়া আমাকে দেখাইয়া গেলেন "ঐ ঈশ্বর ও পরকাল।" দিদিমা যেমন আমার ইহকালের বন্ধু ছিলেন, তেমনি পরলোকেরও বন্ধু।"

Devendra Nātha Tagore compiled a code for the guidance of Brāhma-life from the Upaniṣada in 1848, to which he also appended a Bengali translation. This serves as the hand-book and guide to the modern Brahmas,—specially to the members of the Ādi Samāja The Bengali translation does great credit to the compiler owing to its simplicity and elegance, and it is a interesting point to note that Devendra Nātha dictated the treatise to Akṣaya Kumāra Datta who took it down, the whole thing occupying only three hours.

The great activity and the religious earnestness displayed by the band of noble workers has borne great fruit in various spheres of Bengali life. Bengali literature particularly has been immensely profited by them. The Tattta Bodhini Patrikā under the editorship of Babu Akṣaya Kumāra Datta weilded an influence which it is difficult to conceive now-a-days. "It is scarcely possible" writes Mr. R. C. Dutt "in the present day when journals have multiplied all over the country to describe adequately how eagerly the moral instructions and earnest teachings of Akṣaya Kumāra conveyed in that famous paper, were perused by a large circle of thinking and enlightened readers. People all over Bengal awaited every issue of the paper with eagerness; and the silent and sickly, but indefatigueable, worker at his desk swayed for a number of years the thoughts and opinions of the thinking portion of Bengal."*

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* Literature of Bengal by R. C. Dutt, Page 87.

Içwara Chandra Vidyā-Sāgara.

It was at this time also that the young Içwara Chandra Vidyasāgara, who had already passed through his novitiate in the art of Bengali composition as a pandit in Fort William College, was first winning his laurels in the literary field. He had already written his Vatriça Siṁhāsana which showed unmistakable traces of that elegant and correct style which later on developed so splendidly in his Sitār Vanabāsa, Çakuntalā and other works. It was at this time also that Peary Chand Mitra (*nom de plume*) Tek Chand Thākur—whose

Tek Chand Thākur.

'Alāler Gharer Dulal' or 'The Spoilt Child' many European writers have so freely eulogised, some comparing it with the best productions of Moliere or Fielding,—was trying to master the simple and colloquial style spoken by the gentle and rustic folk of Bengal. We can not however review the works of these master-minds, as our scope is limited to a treatment of the subject up to 1850, and most of their works were written in the decade that followed that year. Babu Akṣaya Kumāra Dutta, however, whose life like Pope's was "a long disease" had already written a considerable portion of those valuable contributions to the Tatta Bodhini Patrikā by 1850,—which were subsequently compiled by him and published in the form of separate books such as, 'Chāru Pātha,' 'Vāhya Bastur Sahita Mānava Prakritir Sāmvanda Vichāra' &c. and we trust it will not be going beyond the limit to give a few extracts from his contributions to the Tattva Bodhini Patrikā. The following is taken from one of the issues of the paper published in 1850.

Extracts from Aksaya Babu's works.

* "A heart void of love may be compared to a desert through which no current of water flows. Both are barren and fruitless. It is a highly fortunate circumstance for us that our Almighty Father has endowed the beings of the earth with abundance of love and devotion. There are persons who love wealth, some seek after reputation, some knowledge, but those that are particularly blessed love God. There is no object higher than love. If there were no love in this earth, where then would have been the heart to enjoy the beauty of a delightful garden, diffusing pleasant fragrance in the breeze, the glad-some beauty of a night clothed in the charming white light of the full moon! Where then would have been the pleasures of conversation with one's devoted, chaste and accomplished wife, whose face radiant with love's glow, beams forth the light of the full moon! Where would have been without love the sweet smiling faces of children, beautiful as painted cherubs and innocent, pure and gay as flowers,—the wonderful harmony that pervades a family

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*"জলশূন্য মরুভূমি ও প্রীতিবিহীন অন্তঃকরণ উভয়ই তুল্য। উভয়ই নীরস ও নিষ্ফল। কিন্তু ইহা আমাদিগের পরম সৌভাগ্যের বিষয় এই যে প্রীতিপূর্ণ পরমেশ্বর মর্ত্ত্যলোকে অপর্য্যাপ্ত প্রেম বিতরণ করিয়াছেন। কেহ বা ধনের, কেহ বা মানের, কেহ বা জ্ঞানের, কেহ বা যশের এবং কোন কোন ভাগ্যবান ব্যক্তি পরমেশ্বরের প্রেমে মগ্ন হইয়া রহিয়াছেন। প্রীতির পর আর পদার্থ নাই। প্রীতি না থাকিলে কোথায় বা সুগন্ধময় পুষ্পোদ্যানের মনোহর শোভা, কোথায় বা শুভ্রবর্ণা সুধাময়ী পূর্ণিমা নিশির সুশীতল নির্ম্মল সুখকর জ্যোতি, কোথায় বা গুণবতী

of spotless reputation, the members bound by ties of love and full of reverence for religion! Where would have been that vivifying and heavenly intercourse with friends of high character, dearer to us than our own selves, and in whose hearts dwell self-sacrificing love and all high qualities! Where would have been those soul-stirring poems, storehouses of high and lofty emotions, which overwhelm us with the never-failing effect of their sweet and matchless melody!

Imitation of English style.

This appears like a Bengali version of one of the familiar essays of the Rambler with Seneca's sayings as head-lines, the difference being that the oriental imitation is even more over-coloured and high flown than the style of Dr. Johnson himself. The writings of Addison and Steele in the Spectator and those of Dr. Johnson in the Rambler supplied models for the Bengali writer, who combined with his Moral and Theological discourses dissertations on Etiolgy and Science much after Paley.

পুণ্যবতী পতিপ্রিয়া প্রিয়তমার পৌর্ণমাসী তুল্য প্রেমোৎফুল্ল মনোহর আনন সন্দর্শন ও তাহার সহিত সুধাময় মধুর আলাপ কোথায় বা চিত্রিতপুত্তলিকা তুল্য প্রফুল্ল কুসুম সদৃশ সহাস্য শিশুগুলির নিষ্কলঙ্ক মুখশ্রী, কোথায় বা পরস্পর প্রীতিযুক্ত নিষ্পাপ পুণ্যশীল পরিবারের আশ্চর্য্য সুদৃশ্যতা, কোথায় বা হৃদয়াধিক প্রণয় পরিপূর্ণ সুচরিত্র মিত্রের স্বর্গোপম নিরুপম সুখদায়ক সহবাস, কোথায় বা রসার্দ্রচিত্ত পদাবলীর সরস লালিত্য ও অনুপম মাধুর্য্য থাকিত?"

Supplementary Notes to Chapter VII.

(i) Three early centres of Vernacular writings.
(ii) The patronage accorded to Vernacular writers
(iii) Peace and her boon.

(i) **Three early centres of Vernacular writings:—**

Before the advent of Chaitanya Deva we find three recognized centres of Vernacular composition. The songs of the Vaiṣṇavas had for their principal seat the historic land of Birbhum and its contiguous districts. Jaya Deva hailed from Kenduli in Birbhum; and a few centuries after him, Chandi-Das sang his celestial lay from the village Nannur in the same district. When Vaiṣṇavism was at its zenith in Bengal, its chief exponents and song-masters flourished in this part of the country. This Vaiṣṇava movement belonged to the people and required no aristocratic patronage to push it in its forward course; it drew its nutrition straight from the soil and soon, by its own power, attained a most luxuriant growth.

Birbhum, the early Vaiṣṇava centre.

In Eastern Bengal where Vaiṣṇavism was yet unknown, the traditions of the Buddhistic age were the inspiration of the songs of the Manasā and Chandi cults. The traditions of Behulā's wonderful devotion and Chānd-Sadagar's stern defiance to Manasā Devi,—the story of Dhanapati Sadāgara and his adherence to the Çaiva faith in the face of great dangers—belong to a period

Eastern Bengal, the centre of Renaissance.

when Brahmanic influence had not yet commenced. As I have already said, the chief actors in the drama of these stories belong to the mercantile classes and some of them are of even humbler origin. The Brahmin has hardly any function to discharge in them. Though after the Hindu Renaissance, these stories were recast by the Brahmins and worked out from mere popular fables into poems of great beauty, their original ground-work, with its traditions of a society which is anterior to that built up by Brahmanical influence, remains unchanged. The earliest writer of Manasā-mañgala, that we have yet been able to trace, was one Hari Dutta. He lived in Mymensing, or somewhere in its vicinity, more than six hundred years ago. Narāyaṅa Deva and Bijaya Gupta came after him in the 15th century and latterly Ṣaṣthibara and Gangā Das, father and son, wrote Manasā-mañgalas, which the subsequent poets of the Manasā cult of east and west alike imitated. These early poets were all of Eastern Bengal. We must remember that the tale of Manasā Devi is of much older date than even six hundred years. In this country earlier efforts are always lost when a gifted successor assimilates and embodies the best features of his predecessors' works in his new poem. Thus nearly a dozen early poems of the Mahābhārata, written before Kāçi Dās, were all forgotten by the people, until quite lately, these works were again brought to the notice of the public by scholarly research. The earlier poets of the Manasā-cult all wrote their poems in Eastern Bengal; and these supplied inspiration to the poets of the western districts in a subsequent age. Ketakādas

Kshemānanda and other poets of the Rāḍa Deça abridged the story described by East Bengal poets, adding some poetical features which the improved resources of our tongue had placed at their command. The Chandi-cult had also its earliest exponents in the poets of Eastern Bengal. Mādhavāchāryya was a native of Mymensing and Dvija Janārdana, probably of Tipara. Owing to to the great beauty of Mukundarāma's poem written in later times, preceding attempts in the same field which had belonged to Eastern Bengal, were cast into the shade. Manuscripts of these early works, from two to three centures old, have been recovered not only from Eastern Bengal but also from the Raḍa-Deça, showing that they were at one time read by the people of the whole of Bengal. We thus see that poems belonging to the various Çākta-cults had for their earliest home the much despised east of the country, which remained politically free for more than a century, after western Bengal had been conquered by the Mahamadans. The Sen-kings at Vikrampur patronised Brahmins; and it was natural that in the 13th century Vikrampur should be turned into an important seat of classical learning. The first translation of the Mahābhārata was undertaken by Sanjaya, probably a Brahmin of Vikrampur. He belonged to the Varatdwāja Gotra, and compiled the translation in an abridged form. The next translation of the great epic by Kabīndra Parameçvara, an inhabitant of Chittagong rose to the highest point of popularity; it was written in the latter part of the 15th century, and was read by the people of east and west alike. Manuscripts of this recension of the

Mahabhārata, written about three centuries ago, have been received not only from Chittagong, Noakhali, Dacca, Mymensing, Tippara, and Sylhet, but also from various parts of Western Bengal. We have with us an old manuscript of the poem recovered from the village of Khalisani, near French Chandarnagar, and several others are to be found in the library of Babu Nagendra Nath Vasu, obtained by him from Pātrasāyer and other villages of Birbhum. A manuscript of this poem about 200 years old was collected by the late Mr. Umesh Chandra Batabyal from a village in the district of Rangpur. We may conceive from all this how extensively popular Kabīndra's Mahābhārata was in those days. Amongst the older recensionists of the Mahābhārata, the influence of Kabīndra Parameçvara was the greatest on Nityānanda and Kaçi Das—the two great luminaries who have enlightened our masses on the beauties of the classical epic in comparatively recent times. There is a host of other early Eastern Bengal poets on the subject of the Mahābhārata whose works will be found mentioned in the body of this book.

Krittibāsa, the earliest writer of the Rāmāyaṅa, got his education in Eastern Bengal, somewhere on the banks of the Padma, as he has himself informed us, in his auto-biography. His ancestors had belonged to Vikramapur, and the family were driven to Phuliā by the oppression of Tugral Khan in the year 1348. Ṣaṣthibar and Gangādās, whose poems have been already mentioned here in connecttion with Manasā-literature, wrote elaborate works on the Ramayaṅa and the Mahā-

bhārata, about 350 year ago. These poets were inhabitants of Jhinārdi in Vikrampore; manuscripts of their poems have been found in large numbers, in various districts of Western Bengal, as they have been in the native districts of the poets themselves. It will thus appear that Eastern Bengal, having been one of the great seats of Sanskrit learning, produced a number of translations that helped to disseminate Pouranik ideas amongst the masses. Before the advent of Chaitanya, Eastern Bengal thus formed the chief nucleus of Vernacular composition. Çakta-cult had strong adherents in that part of the country and classical learning was encouraged by Hindu Kings and noble men. These helped powerfully in the importation of Sanskrit words into our tongue—a process which is especially conspicuous in the translations that were compiled in that province.

This wave was retarded by the democratic movement in letters that was inspired by Chaitanya. The Vaiṣṇavas adopted Bengali as the chief vehicle for the teaching of their religion and at once monopolised the right of producing literature in it. This accounts for the flourishing growth of vernacular literature in the Raḍa Deça from the 16th century onwards. The light that came from the East gradually subsided below the horizon of our letters, and under Vaiṣṇava influence, even the Çākta writers of Western Bengal profited by the general intellectual awakening there, and wrote poems of considerable beauty, which gradually over-shadowed the works written by the poets of Eastern Bengal, till the latter lost all the lustre that

Eastern Bengal falls to the back ground

she had once possessed. She had once occupied the place of pioneer in Vernacular composition, but this has now passed completely out of our memory. The Battala-publishers have confined their attention to manuscripts of Bengali poems of comparatively later date, such as were available in the vicinity of Calcutta, and this fact has further helped to obliterate the memory of the early poems of Eastern Bengal until recent discoveries brought to light heaps of long forgotten manuscripts mainly from the houses of the rustics of that country.

The Songs of Pāl Kings and Dharma-maṅgala poems, came from North Bengal.

The third seat of Vernacular composition, which was perhaps one of the oldest, was North Bengal. The songs of the Pāl Kings were first sung in the old capital of Gauḍa and its vicinity. Rāmāi Pandit composed his Manual of Dharma worship in Bengali towards the end of the 10th century. He was born in the district of Bankura but Gauḍa was his chief of field of work. The story of Lāusen, to be found in the Dharma-Maṅgala, relates to the adventures and successes of the hero who was a nephew of the King, Darmapāl II, and the incidents of the poem gather round the old capital of Bengal. The Darma-cult flourished under the patronage of the Pāl Kings, and the Vernacular literature of this cult had, for its original home, the historic land where these Kings reigned.

Summary.

We thus arrive at the following conclusions:—

(1) Rāḍa Deça in olden times was the favoured seat of the growth of Vaiṣṇava ideas. Long before Chaitanya, she delighted in Vaiṣṇava songs and in the study of the Bhāgabata which

was first translated into Bengali metrical verse, about 425 years ago, by Mālādhara Basu, one of her illustrious poets.

(2) Eastern Bengal produced the earliest works of the Chandi and Manasā-cults, and her learned writers compiled most of the earliest recensions of the Sanskrit epics. Eastern Bengal thus gave the earliest impetus towards the dissemination of Pourānik ideas amongst the masses.

(3) From North Bengal we received our songs of the Pâl Kings and our earliest Dharma-mañgāls. These, as we have said, deal with the exploits and adventures of Lâu-sen, a nephew of the King Darmapála II of Gauḍa.

These were the three centres,—the early fields of the activities of our poets in vernacular composition. Rāḍa Deça in the 16th century came to the fore and dominated the great intellectual awakening brought about by Chaitanya.

11.—The patronage accorded to Vernacular writers.

In the first chapter of this book, we indicated how the Hindu Courts, following the examples of Moslem chiefs and noblemen, extended their patronage to the Vernacular poets. Bengali gradually became a favourite vehicle for the expression of thought with scholarly people; and we scarcely find a poet of any renown who was not rewarded and patronised by some noble man. The Vaiṣṇava

poets alone did not care for such patronage, but all others considered it a great privilege and honour to dedicate their poems to their rich patrons, extolling their qualities in terms of high sounding panegyric and poetry.

We find Kavi Kañkaṅa patronised by Bānkura Roy, Rājā of Arrah Brahman Bhumi at a very critical moment of his life, when 8 maunds of rice offered by the Rājā to the famished members of the poet's family elicited his grateful acknowledgements which have found a place in the immortal poem of Chandi. But gradually the Rājās became more bountiful to the vernacular poets and towards the end of the 17th and the beginning of the 18th century, we find vernacular writings of merit very considerably rewarded. We have seen that Rājā Jaya Nārāyaṅa of Bhu-kailāsa made considerable sacrifices of time and money to bring his translation of the Kaçi Khanda to a satisfactory completion. He travelled in different parts of the country for a period of six months in quest of Mss. of the Sanskrit poem. This journey in those days, made in a style befitting the rank of a Rājā of his high status, meant a very considerable expenditure. Besides this, he had to maintain a long time nearly a dozen Pundits for the purpose. Rājā Kriṣṅa Chandra's bounty towards classical learning was well-known. His liberal gifts to Bhārata Chandra and Rāma Prasāda, two gifted Vernacular poets of his time, is also not less worthy of note. Bhārata Chandra was appointed his Court-poet on Rs. 40 a month. This amount about the time of the battle of Plassey was not at all insignificant or small, when we see that Warren Hastings at a

Remuneration to the poets and copyists.

much later period drew a pay of Rs. 300 a month, as member of the Council. Major Rennell as Survey General of India was in 1767 granted a pay of Rs. 300 a month, and this amount was considered to be unusally high requiring an elaborate explanation from the authorities! We find Jaya Chandra a Rājā of the Chittagong district, granting an allowance of Rs. 10 per day to the poet Bhavāni Nātha for translating a poem called the Lakṣmaṅa Digvijaya into Bengali verse. This book was compiled about the middle of the eighteenth century and must have occupied the poet for at least six months. Rs. 300 a month in those days must have been equal to at least 10 times its present value.

Not only poets but even copyists of vernacular poems received a high remuneration for their labour. A copyist of the 18 Parvas of the Mahabharata by Kavīndra Parameçwara wrote the following concluding paragraph at the close of his Ms. in 1714 A.D.

"This Mahabhrata, containing 18 Parvas (copied by me) belongs to Çri Govinda Rāma Roy. The total number of pages is 789. My name is Ananta Rama Çarmā—copyist. The remuneration promised is the maintenance of my family for life in a becoming style. On this condition I have copied the work with great care. Besides this, I have received rewards in cash; and orders for daily allowance and annual gifts have also been obtained. Good luck attend the donor, Çaka 1636–1124 B.S. This the 25th day of Kartic. Finished on Thursday at noon, at Solagram—the native

* Major Reunell's life in Asiatic Society's Journal No. 3 Vol. III p. 2.

village of the copyist." This Solagram is in the District of Tippera and the Ms. from which the above is quoted now belongs to the Asiatic Society of Bengal.

III.—Peace and her boon.

The rapid growth of Bengali prose.

A peaceful administration stimulates and nourishes intellectual activities; and under British rule we are in enjoyment of the manifold benefits of peace. This has caused the rapid and astonishing growth of our prose within the past century. Bengali now heads the list of the Vernaculars of India in point of its many-sided literary activities and general excellence. Many books written in our tongue have been translated into the Vernaculars of other provinces of India; and the number of our readers is fast increasing, as the field and scope of our language are widening. This excellent result is in a large measure due to Bengal being the chief seat of Government. We have been in touch with the civilisation of the West earlier than other Provinces. By the introduction of Bengali into our University, a healthy impetus has been given to the cause of Vernacular literature, and we may confidently hope that this will be productive of strikingly good results. May my country steadily advance in her onward course under the benign administration of our present Rulers. Our review of the Bengali Literature, however, ends with 1850. The historian of a later epoch of this literature will have to acknowldge with gratitude the deep debt which our tongue has owed to England and her people in comparatively recent times.

THE END.

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* Read c as ç=শ, sh as ṣ=ষ, s as স, d as ḍ=ড়.

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Bengali works by Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen.

1. **BANGA BHAṢĀ-O-SĀHITYA.** (History of the Bengali Language & Literature.)

2. **RĀMĀYANI KATHĀ.** (Sketches from the Rāmāyaṅa.)

3. **BEHULĀ.** (The bride of Lakṣmīndra.)

4. **FULLARĀ.** (The hunter's wife.)

5. **SATI.** (The devoted wife of the Great god Çiva.)

6. **JAḌA BHARATA.** (The princely ascetic.)

7. **TINA BANDHU.** (Three freinds.)

OPINIONS.

1. BANGA BHĀṢĀ-O-SĀHITYA—(History of the Bengali Language and Literature.)

Copies of Correspondence between the Government of India and the India office.

NO. 364 of 1899.

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA,

FINANCE AND COMMERCE DEPARTMENT,
PENSIONS AND GRATUITIES.

To

**The Right Hon'ble Lord George Francis Hamilton,
Her Majesty's Secretary of State for India.**

Simla, the 26th October, 1899.

My Lord,

We have the honour to forward, for your Lordship's consideration, a letter from the Government of Bengal, No. 2637—Mis., dated the 21st August, 1899, enclosing a memorial from Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen, B. A., in which he prays for a pension in recognition of his services as the author of a work entitled Bangabhasa-O-Sahitya, a history of the Bengali Language and Literature.

This work has been pronounced by competent authorities to be of considerable original research in the history of the

language and literature of Bengal and is the first attempt at a complete history of Bengali literature. The materials on which the work is founded were contained in manuscripts hitherto unknown to students, scattered over many districts of Bengal, and the great labour involved in discovering and collating them has told seriously on the health of Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen.

We consider, that in a country like India, whose scientific literature at the present day consists almost entirely of compilations or translations, the appearance of a meritorious work of original research is deserving of some recognition at the hands of the Government and we accordingly recommend for your Lordship's sanction, the proposal made by the Government of Bengal that the Babu should be given a pension of Rs. 25 a month, with effect from 1st April, 1899.

We have the honour to be,

My Lord,

Your Lordship's most obedient & humble servants,

(Signed) CURZON OF KEDLESTON.

,, W. S. A. LOCKHART.

,, E. H. H. COLLEN.

,, A. C. TREVOR.

,, C. M. RIVAZ.

,, C. E. DAWKINS.

,, T. RALEIGH.

INDIA OFFICE.

London, 21st December 1899.

FINANCIAL.

No. 248.

To

His Excellency the Right Honourable
The Governor General of India in Council.

My Lord,

I have considered in council your letter of the 26th of October, No. 364, proposing that a special pension of Rs. 25 a month should be granted to Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen.

2. Your recommendation is based on the opinion of competent authorities who consider that a work by Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen entitled *Banga Bhasha O Shahitya* exhibits considerable original research in the history of the language and literature of Bengal. You also state that the labour involved in discovering and collating the manuscripts on which the work is based, has told seriously on the health of the author.

3. Your proposal is sanctioned.

I have &c.,

(Sd.) George Hamilton.

EXTRACTS FROM LETTERS AND REVIEWS.

Dr. G. A. Grierson, C. S., C. I. E., writes from Simla.

"It is an admirable and original account of Bengali Literature. It must long remain the standard authority on the subject."

Mr. H. J. S. Cotton, C. S., C. S. I., late Chief Commissioner of Assam, wrote under date, March 24, 1897.

"Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen's History of Bengali Language and Literature appears indeed to be a work of great erudition and labour."

Mr. F. H. Skrine, late Commissioner of the Chittagong Division, wrote on the 22nd January 1897.

"The History is a work of profound research and severe thankless toil, which I deeply regret, has affected your health. I say 'thankless' because it is much to be feared that your countrymen will not evince a proper appreciation of your labour in the interest of culture and knowledge; and unless Government comes to the rescue by purchasing a number of copies of the book for distribution amongst its officers, you are likely to be out of pocket by your disinterested exertions.

The task has not yet advanced beyond a description of the Bengalee language in the times before British Rule. The second part, if it appears at all, will not be a satisfactory record of progress. Bengali, as I have said in print, is a true daughter of ancient Sanskrit, and approaches its parent more nearly than any Indian language in the qualities which have rendered Sanskrit so unrivalled a medium for the expression of the highest ranges of human thought. It unites the mellifluousness of Italian with the power possessed by German of rendering complex ideas, and I cannot but regret that so little encouragement has been afforded by the State to its cultivation. If a tithe of the pain given by the Bengalis to acquire a smattering of English had been devoted to their mother tongue, they would long since have ceased to merit the reproach of producing little or no original work.

However, this is not their fault but their misfortune Thanks to the decision arrived at by the influence of Lord Macaulay, Bengali, in common with the other vernaculars,

has pined in the cold shade of official disdain. He who seeks to illustrate them receives neither recognition nor praise; and he cannot look forward to the worldly success which attends a very moderate expertness in the English tongue. * * * Wishing you a speedy recovery and patronage of an enlightened Government, etc."

Later on, Mr. Skrine wrote to Dr. Martin.

"It is an epoch-making book. Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen has entirely broken down by the severe labour entailed by this colossal task.

Extract from a letter from Dr. Martin, Director of Public Instruction, dated the 29th November 1897.

"I have the honour to request that you will be so good as to send 70 copies of it (History of Bengali language and literature) to this office, with a bill of cost. You may also circulate a copy of Pandit Hara Prosad Sastri's review of your book to aided colleges and schools of Bengal, with the intimation that in the opinion of this office, the book is deserving of a place in their libraries."

Extract from a letter from Mr. A. Pedler, F.R. S., Director of Public Instruction, dated the 2nd March, 1899.

"I have the honour to state that I am willing to subscribe to 70 copies of this edition.

"I am to add that I fully appreciate the value of the work otherwise I should not be subscribing to the 2nd as well as to the 1st edition."

Luzac's Oriental List says ;—

Babu Dines Chunder Sen's "Banga Bhasa and Sahitya" or "Language and Literature of Bengal," divides, as its title indicates, into two parts. The first is a courageous and learned attempt to shew that, as under Buddhistic influence,

Sanskrit degenerated into loose Prakrit dialects, so with the revival of Hinduism, the modern Languages of India recovered much of the dignity and classical correctness of Sanskrit. In this part of his work, the writer makes copious use of the researches of European scholars, and especially of Dr. Hœrnle and Dr. Grierson, which do in fact shew that the Bengali and its cognate dialects are the survivals through Prakrit of the speech of the first Aryan invaders of India. The writer, however, in his patriotic zeal, goes further than this, and practically denies the existence of any indigenous influence at all. He traces all Bengali inflections, all Bengali metres to Sanskrit origins, and though he admits the existence of a few words which cannot be traced to Sanskrit originals, he regards these simply as unwelcome intrusions into a literature from verbal expressions. In short, his history is one of literary Bengali which is even more highly sanskritized now than English was latinized in the 18th century. Even if we do not accept all the writer's conclusions, we cannot help seeing how natural it is that so enthusiastic a scholar should recognise the importance of upholding the dignity and value of a literature which has been too little studied even by Bengalis. No student of the modern languages of India can read this part of Babu Dines Chander Sen's work without profit and enjoyment, so obvious is the scholarly zeal with which it is written. The second part of the book is entirely original, and is a record of the author's search for manuscripts of works written before the British occupation of India. We have here a description not only of the standard works which every student of Bengali reads, but of works of about a hundred authors hitherto forgotten. To the European reader, it is interesting to note that all this is Hindu literature. It was a literature of revolt against Muslim tendencies and has no trace of Mahomedan influence. Some day, Babu Dines Chunder Sen may write,

we hope, of Bengali literature under British rule; a literature broadened and enriched by European culture. In this literature, Babu Dines Chander Sen's History will itself occupy a high place as an outcome of European methods of scholarship applied to Eastern learning.

Extract from the Calcutta Gazette of March 24, 1897.

"Vangabhasa O Sahitya" is perhaps the most noteworthy book of the year. It is the outcome, as the author says, of six years' patient labour and research. In it the history of the Bengali language and literature has been traced from the earliest times down to 1838 A. D. The writer has, for the first time, brought to light a number of minor Bengali poems, the discovery whereof will greatly help the cause of linguistic research in Bengal. He has remarkably succeeded in utilising the materials at his command. The book is perhaps the first systematic and accurate treatise on the subject, showing a great improvement in this respect over its predecessor, the late Pandit Ramgati Nayaratna's book. The chapters of the book on case-suffixes and verbal inflexions in Bengali may be regarded as perhaps the first systematic and the most successful attempt at the solution of a very knotty problem."

The Englishman *devotes two leaders of its two successive issues of the 24th and 25th December, 1897, to the review of the book from which the following short extract is taken* :—

"The work which under the above title (Bangabhasha O Sahitya) has been recently published by Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen, Head Master of the Victoria School at Tipperah, is one of the most valuable contributions to the history and growth of the language and literature of Bengal that have yet appeared, and will have the result of modifying several previously accepted conclusions on the subject. It is based chiefly on researches made throughout Eastern Bengal, with the object of discovering the numerous ancient manuscripts which have

long lain hid in the houses of cultivators throughout the rural villages of Eastern Bengal, and whose existence was previously not suspected.

As the book is written in Bengali and its contents will be available to comparatively few European readers, a review of its contents and of the conclusions that it leads to may be found to be of interest. It was in 1892, when engaged in writing a treatise on the origin and growth of the Bengali language, that Babu D. C. Sen happened by chance to come across an ancient manuscript of the poem Mrigalabdha by Rati Deb and on further enquiries he ascertained from reliable sources that there were many such ancient books existing in the villages of Tippera and Chittagong. He thereupon set to work to find out and procure such as could be got, and visited many rural villages for the purpose. He succeeded in obtaining a certain number and in ascertaining the existence of others, but they were frequently worm-eaten and otherwise ill-preserved and it was sufficiently clear that unless their contents could be preserved by means of printing them, the bulk of this valuable material must be ultimately lost. Mr. Sen consequently wrote for advice to Professor Hœrnle, from whom he received valuable assistance, and also from Pundit Hara Prashad Shastri under whose advice Pundit Benode Behari Kabyatirtha of the Asiatic Society went to Comilla to assist him in his search and continued to do so from time to time for short periods.

Together, they discovered several further manuscripts, and in the intervals, the author continued his search by himself throughout the villages of Tippera, Noakhali, Sylhet, Dacca and Eastern Bengal generally. He thus collected numerous ancient manuscripts. The task, however, was one of difficulty, as the peasants in whose houses they were to be found, were unwilling to part with them or even to show them fearing that

the enquiry was being made with the object of imposing a tax on the owners of books. Others were unwilling to part with manuscripts that had been in their families for several generations. Babu D. C. Sen, however, persevered in his enquiries in spite of all obstacles and the results of his six years' labours are now incorporated in his History now published. The cost of publishing the work which would have been beyond the author's means has been borne by the Maharaja of Tippera who deserves the thanks of all students of the Bengali language. * * * The thanks of all students of Bengali literature are due to Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen for the labours he has patiently carried on for six years, in the face of many difficulties."

Extract from a lengthy review by Mahamahopadhyaya Pundit Hara Prasad Sastri M.A., Principal, Sanskrit College, Calcutta, in the Calcutta University Magazine, May 1897.

"The graduates of the Calcutta University are often reproached with renouncing the study of literature as soon as they enter into the world. In many instances the reproach is well deserved. It is, therefore, with the greatest pleasure that we introduce Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen, B. A., to the notice of our educated countrymen as a gentleman who has done a good deal of original research in the field of Bengali literature. The result of his researches and labours has been embodied in a handy volume entitled 'Bangabhasa O Sahitya' in which he gives a history of Bengali literature which has cast into the shade all previous works on the subject. Indeed, this is the first work on the history of Bengali literature which deserves the name. Many hundreds of volumes of manuscripts, hitherto unknown to the educated public, have not only been brought to light, but classified, arranged and criticised. Different schools of poetry taking their rise at different periods of national existence, have been traced to their natural historical causes, and the lives of nearly a hundred

authors have been saved from oblivion. The literature of Eastern Bengal was absolutely unknown. Nobody even thought that there were Bengali poets in Dacca, Tipperah and Chittagong who translated the whole of the Ramayan, the Mahabharat and the large number of other works bearing on Hindu religion and traditions, into Bengali. The credit of bringing this vast body of literature to public notice is entirely due to Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen and to him alone."

Extract from an article by Mahamahopadhya Hara Prasada Shastri, M. A., in the Calcutta Review, *dated October 1897, (the article covers 14 pages of the Journal.)*

'Bangabhasa O Shahitya' is the title of a Bengali work by Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen, B. A., Head Master of the Victoria School, Comilla, on the history of Bengali language and literature. It is a neat, handy volume running through 403 octavo pages, replete with information of the highest value to students who take any interest in the past of Bengali races or in their literature. * * * An active search for Bengali manuscripts began in various quarters, led by that admirably useful body of learned men, the Asiatic Society of Bengal. Many private individuals also devoted themselves to the work. The Bangiya Sahitya Parishad or Bengal Academy of Literature was started with this as one of its special objects. But by tacit consent it was agreed that one scholar should be entrusted with the work of compiling and digesting the information already collected, and Babu Dinesh Chandra, whose enthusiasm and earnestness in the matter was an object of admiration to all concerned, took it up. Every one helped him with the result of his researches. For the first time in the history of Bengali literature, all jealousy, obstructionism and petty feelings were set aside to enable him to produce a great work. Whoever reads Dinesh Babu's preface with care will be struck with the modest, yet straightforward, dignified, yet

grateful, acknowledgment of the services he has received from his collaborators. * * * He had to collect MSS. either himself or through friends, to read them, to classify them, and to digest them. The remoteness of his residence, in an out-of-the-way corner of Bengal, was a great drawback to him. It entailed a great deal of correspondence on him, and the progress of his work was often hindered by the dilatoriness of correspondents. But he has surmounted all those and other difficulties, and his work is now before the public. The public, in its turn, has received him kindly and his work is appreciated. * * * In the matter of Eastern poets, Babu Dinesh Chandra deserves the credit of a discoverer. He has laid bare one stratum of thought, and one phase of authorship, the value of which cannot be over-rated. His services in respect of Vaishnava literature, too, are very great."

Mr. A. C. Sen, M. A., C. S., late District and Sessions Judge, Rangpur, wrote referring to the illness of the author caused by his labours in compiling the work—

"It is no exaggeration to say that the great work is both his monument and epitaph."

Mr. B. C. Mitra, M. A. C. S., District and Sessions Judge, Cuttack, writes—

"I can say with the utmost confidence that it is a work which will ensure the permanence of your name and loving labour in the annals of Bengali literature. I am thinking, as soon as I am permitted time, of writing a review of it. For the present, I will content myself with saying that it is a book of the merits and usefulness of which I entertain the very highest opinion. In wealth of details, it rivals Morley's First Sketch; in power of graphic language, it rivals Taine; in subtlety of critical analysis, it rivals Dowden. Your close study of the earliest classics in Bengali has been helpful in investing your language with a delicacy, a refinement, a

directness which relieves and vivifies the minutiæ of details that your industrious research has brought to light, I think, for the first time. I anxiously await the publication of your second volume, and earnestly wish that you will soon recover health and spirit for that undertaking.

Mr. K. C. De, B. A. C. S., Magistrate and Collector of Faridpur, writes—

"I have made time to read through almost the whole of your book with great interest and not inconsiderable profit to myself."

Raja Benoy Krishna Bahadur of Sobhabazar, Calcutta, writes—

"You have dealt with the subject in a manner which has extorted admiration and appreciation from every quarter. Babu Hirendra Nath Dutt, M. A., B. L., Rai Jotindra Nath Choudhury, M. A., B. L., Babu Mano Mohan Bosu and several others who have had opportunities of reading your book, speak very favourably of your efforts. Indeed every one speaks in high terms of your very creditable performance. Although one or two gentlemen differ with you on certain points, but none the less they appreciate your work and your precious labour. The language of the book is all that can be desired. It now remains for me to congratulate you most sincerely on the celebrated work you have published in Bengali language. Every Bengali gentleman is grateful to you for this rich and splendid production from your pen."

Extract from the half-yearly report of the Peace Association, Calcutta, for 1897.

Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen has published his book 'বঙ্গভাষা ও সাহিত্য' and a copy of it has been presented to the Association. Babu Dinesh Chandra was the first Vidyasagar medalist of the Association and he says in the preface to his

book that the Vidyasagar medal gave him the incentive for its composition. 'বঙ্গভাষা ও সাহিত্য' has been enthusiastically received by the public and has been declared to be an epoch-making book in Bengali literature. The members congratulate themselves on having a hand in the production of the work. Concerned as they are to learn that the pressure of work entailed by the composition of the book has shattered the author's health, they pray to God that he may soon be restored to health."

Extract from a circular from the late Babu Dinanath Sen, Inspector of Schools, Eastern Circle, to the Head Masters of High English Schools under him, dated Dacca, the 8th March, 1897.

"A very important book on the History of the Bengali language and literature has been published by Babu Dinesh Chandra Sen, Head Master of the Victoria School at Comilla. It is desirable that a copy of the book should be kept in the library of each school in which Bengali is taught and which may have funds to buy it * * *"

The late Hon'ble Babu Guru Prasad Sen, pleader of Bankipur, wrote—

"Now permit me to say that yours was the best book I read for many a year in Bengali and I at once came to be an admirer of the author and since then knowing that you are a Vaidya and of the same section to which I have the honour to belong and you belong to East Bengal, there has grown in me a sort of, I hope, permissible pride in your work."

Rai Sarat Chandra Das Bahadur, C.I.E., writes—

"I have read your excellent work with keen interest. I should like to buy a copy of it. From the contents of the first volume one can draw a good deal of information for the interest of European scholars.

RĀMĀYAṆI KATHĀ—(Sketches from the Rāmāyana.)

Sister Nivedita (Miss Noble) says :—

"Your Rāmāyani Kathā has been most helpful and inspiring to all of us who heard them read together sometime ago. We liked them very much indeed. I have a very special appreciation of your literary enthusiasm for the Bengali Language used for the Indian classics. You are doing a much greater and more enduring work than you now realise."

Kumar Sarat Kumar Roy M.A. of Dighapatia says :—

"Your Rāmāyani Kathā is another monumental work which will raise you high in the estimation of the public—at the same time benefiting the domestic life of Bengal to an appreciable degree."

Mr. Krishna Kantha Malaviya of Allahabad who is translating the book in Hindi says :—

"To me the Rāmāyani Kathā possesses the world's literature in itself. I have requested many friends of mine to acquire Bengali only for the sake of reading the Rāmāyani Kathā."

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